WWW.ECONOMICTIMES.COM

The Economic Times

BENNETT, COLEMAN & CO. LTD. | ESTD. 1838
VOL. 42 NO. 210 | BENGALURU | 18 PAGES | ₹4.00 ONLY
THURSDAY, 3 SEPTEMBER 2026

Banks have mobilised $127.22 billion from FCNR(B) deposits in less than three months till the scheme closed on Aug 31, RBI said. ▶ Page 1

▶ Gulf Oil Tankers Back in Crosshairs as Iran-US Attacks Restart: P 1 ▶ Credit Card Spends Up, but Revolver-led Model No Longer Firing for Banks: P 10

BHARAT AI ZONE by NPCI ALWAYS FORWARD — TOKEN NXT

GFF NIGHT Fest — FINTECH AFTER HOURS — After the sessions end, the conversations continue

GFF EXPO — Meet 350+ Exhibitors at Pavilion and Jasmine Expo Floor

PCI FCC — GLOBAL FINTECH AWARDS 2026 — Brought To You By VISA — Celebrating Excellence in Financial Services at GFA — Award's Night 9th SEP

scapia Sundowner — 10 SEP 07 PM — SALIM-SULAIMAN

GFF HACKATHONS

Where Leaders Converge — GFF ROUNDTABLE

NPCI ALWAYS FORWARD — Global Fintech Women's Breakfast

15+ THOUGHT LEADERSHIP REPORTS — Launching Live at GFF26

GFF NETWORKING DINNER

ARIFAC — FinSight @GFF — Financial Intelligence • Insight • Integrity Forum — By Invite-Only

Diners Club International — RuPay — CEOs DINNER

GFF26 APP — A Smooth GFF Experience, Just a Tap Away! Scan to Download

1,00,000+ Footfall | **5,000+** Participating Companies | **1000+** Speakers | **500+** Investors | **400+** Sessions | **350+** Exhibitors | **75+** Product Launches & Showcases | **40+** Workshops, Masterclasses

GFF2026 SPEAKERS

- **Aashish Goel** – Stanford University
- **Abhishek Poddar** – Reserve Bank Innovation Hub
- **Abhishek Saraf** – Prudential Health India
- **Aditi Mittal** – IndiaBonds
- **Aditya Khullar** – Adyen
- **Aditya Lakhanpal** – HSBC India
- **Ajay Agarwal** – HDFC Bank
- **Akanksha Sadekar** – Amazon Pay India
- **Akash Sinha** – Cashfree Payments India
- **Akhil Devmurari** – J.P. Morgan
- **Akhilesh Tuteja** – KPMG
- **Akshay Mehrotra** – Fibe
- **Akshit Kaushik** – Mitigata
- **Amir Nagammy** – Wizz Financial
- **Amir Valliani** – PayPal
- **Amit Dave** – Prudential Health India
- **Amit Kumar Jain** – Delhi Metro Rail Corporation
- **Anil Pinapala** – Vivifi India Finance
- **Amit Lakhotia** – Park Plus
- **Amol Dethe** – ETBFSI.com
- **Anand Agarwal** – Standard Chartered Bank
- **Anand Narayanan KB** – Alt DRX
- **Anil Goteti** – Scapia
- **Ankush Tiwari** – pi-labs
- **Antony Vendhan** – identy.io
- **Adelia Castelino** – In-Solutions Global
- **Anuj Khosla** – Hitachi Payment Services
- **Anupam Vasdani** – True Balance India
- **Anuradha Ramachandran** – Prana Ventures
- **Arif Khan** – Razorpay Software Ltd
- **Arindam Das** – DMI Finance
- **Arnika Dixit** – Axis Bank
- **Arun Kohli** – Morgan Stanley
- **Ashish Mehrotra** – Northern Arc Capital
- **Ashish Shah** – BOBCARD
- **Ashwini Kumar Tewari** – State Bank of India
- **Atis Ivanovs** – Unlimit
- **Ayan Agarwal** – Transcorp International
- **Aditya Bhamidipaty** – FirstHive
- **Balaji Koustubha** – CredResolve
- **Balaji Narayanamurthy** – IndusInd Bank
- **Beena Vaheed** – Bank of Baroda
- **Benjamin Lee** – Nexus Global Payments
- **Bharat Joshi** – VuNet Systems
- **Bhavin Patel** – LenDenClub
- **Carlin Crasto** – 86400
- **Chetan Krishnaswamy** – Amazon
- **Debiprasad Sarangi** – ISereU Techonologies
- **Dee Low** – Nexus Global Payments
- **Deepak Mahaur** – ICICI Bank
- **Deepak Mendiratta** – PayU Finance
- **Debiprasad Sarangi** – ISereU Technologies
- **Devraj Sanyal** – Reserve Bank Innovation Hub
- **Dibyendu Kumar Das** – Bandhan Bank
- **Dipak Kumar De** – State Bank of India
- **Dipesh Karki** – NTT DATA Payment Services
- **Disha Dubey** – NVIDIA
- **Dmytro Kolechko** – Wing Bank (Cambodia) Plc.
- **Esam Alkheshnam** – KNET
- **Frances Choo** – NTT DATA Payment Services
- **Frederick Dsouza** – Kotak Mahindra Bank
- **G Sivakumar** – IIT Bombay
- **Ganesh Ananthanarayanan** – Airtel Payments Bank
- **Gary Yang** – Adyen
- **Gaurav Mathur** – Digital Gold India
- **Gaurav Ramdev** – Visa
- **Gaurav Sahgal** – HSBC
- **Gaurav Agnihotri** – Airtel Business
- **Gautam Patel** – Z3 Partner
- **Girish Pandey** – Meta
- **Gunaseelan Sundar** – Pinnacle Teleservices
- **Hari Menon** – Intellect Design Arena
- **Hitesh Sachdev** – ICICI Bank
- **Hitesh Sethia** – JioFinance
- **Jo Yeo** – Monetary Authority of Singapore
- **Jitendra Gupta** – Jupiter
- **Johannes Lamsfuß** – German Federal Ministry of Finance
- **Kamal Singhania** – CCIL
- **Karan Sapra** – Google Pay
- **Kashif Ahmad Khan** – Peko
- **Kashinath Hariharan P** – Jio Payment Solutions
- **Katerina Zemskova** – Pay10 Global
- **Kedar Kulkarni** – Hyperverge
- **Ketan Doshi** – Pay Point India Network
- **Ketan Merchant** – Fino Payments Bank
- **Khilan Haria** – Razorpay
- **Krishnakumar K T** – Oleevia Grameen Credits
- **Kshitij Jain** – Blue Machines AI
- **Kunal Rana** – Google Pay
- **Latha Venkatesh** – CNBCTV18
- **Liberatha Kallat** – Paytm
- **Lizzie Chapman** – Baysys
- **Louis Liu** – FOMO Pay
- **Luciano Salvador Scalise** – CRIF
- **Madhu Menon V P** – Standard Chartered Bank
- **Madhusudan Ekambaram** – KreditBee
- **Mahesh Chandran Iyer** – Thomas Cook (India)
- **Mahesh Ramamoorthy** – YES Bank
- **Maitreya Wagh** – Bolna
- **Manasi Pandey** – HSBC
- **Manish Agrawal** – HDFC Bank
- **Manish Hingar** – Fintoo
- **Manish Lunia** – FlexiLoans
- **Manish Mimani** – Protectt.ai Labs
- **Manish Sinha** – Credilio Financial Technologies
- **Mangesh Surve** – Red Hat
- **Manoj Agarwal** – Angel One
- **Manoj Dugar** – HSBC
- **Matthew Driver** – Mastercard
- **Maulik Joshi** – Paynext
- **Mayank Jain** – Amazon Pay India
- **Mike Walters** – Form3
- **Milind Atrey** – IIT Bombay
- **Murali Mohan Rao Manduva** – DCB Bank
- **Mohit Monga** – ONDC
- **Mohit Narula** – Citibank
- **Motilal Gopilal Oswal** – Motilal Oswal Financial Services
- **Movin Jain** – Skydo
- **Mujiruddin Shaikh** – Reserve Bank Innovation Hub
- **Mukesh Hajela** – NICT Technologies
- **Murali Mohan Rao Manduva** – DCB Bank
- **Namrata Dubashi** – Axis Bank
- **Navin Chandani** – Equifax
- **Navin Jain** – Wise
- **Neeraj Matiyani** – DevRev
- **Neetu Chitkara** – Boston Consulting Group
- **Nikhil Kurhe** – Finarkein Analytics
- **Nirav Prajapati** – Ignosis AI
- **Nirav Kamdar** – Amazon
- **Nitesh Ranjan** – Union Bank of India
- **Pallavi Shrivastava** – Progcap
- **Pankaj Gadgil** – Aditya Birla Capital
- **Pankaj Singh** – Aagama Ventures
- **Pietro Tiberi** – Banca d'Italia
- **Pinak Chakraborty** – Airtel Payments Bank
- **Prabhu Rangarajan** – M2P Fintech
- **Prachi Dharani** – PayGlocal Technologies
- **Pramod Kumar Dwibedi** – Bank of India
- **Pramod Rao** – SEBI
- **Pranav Chawda** – JPMorganChase
- **Prashant Joshi** – Lendingkart
- **Prashant Mehra** – HDFC Bank
- **Prashant Vagal** – NSDL
- **Prateek Sachan** – Bolna
- **Pratik Shah** – EY
- **Praveen Shankaran** – KFIN Technologies
- **Praveen Soni** – European Pay
- **Pravin Jadhav** – Raise
- **Pravin Kumar Sharma** – Getepay
- **Presha Paragash** – Credit Saison India
- **Priti Gupta** – Lxme Money
- **Priyam Alok** – Saraswat Bank
- **Pushkar Mukewar** – Drip Capital
- **Rahul Jain** – Peach Payments
- **Rajappa Tadepalli** – ASPIRE - IITB Research Park Foundation
- **Rajesh Desai** – Lyra Network
- **Rajesh Ranjan** – Google
- **Rajesh Saxena** – Intellect Design Arena
- **Rajesh Thapar** – NSE India
- **Rajiv Kumar Gupta** – NSE India
- **Rajiv Naresh** – Navi
- **Rajkumar Upadhyay** – Centre For Development of Telematics
- **Rakesh Purohit** – J.P. Morgan
- **Rajesh Kumar** – State Bank of India
- **Raman Gaba** – BOBCARD
- **Ramji Chavda** – The Gujarat State Cooperative Bank
- **Ramki Gaddipati** – Zeta
- **Ranjan R Reddy** – Bureau
- **Ranvir Singh** – Kissht
- **Rasika Prashant** – NSRCEL, IIMB
- **Ratan Kesh** – Bandhan Bank
- **Raul Rebello** – Mahindra & Mahindra Financial Services
- **Ravi Kaushik** – Flourish Ventures
- **Ravi Pangal** – IndusInd Bank
- **Priyam Bose** – Truecaller
- **Reeju Datta** – Cashfree Payments India
- **Reuben Lim** – Mars Growth Capital
- **Rhea Chaterjee,** – SafeGold
- **Ricky Lim** – TBCASoft Inc.
- **Ripunjai Gaur** – Paytm
- **Ritesh Pai** – PhonePe
- **Ritu Singh** – CNBC-TV18
- **Roberto Valdovinos** – People's Clearinghouse
- **Rohan Bagai** – AZB & Partners
- **Rohit Chatter** – Angel One
- **Romain Zanolo** – IDEMIA
- **Rupa Mankad** – Citibank
- **Shiladitya Mukhopadyaya** – Truecaller
- **Sachin Jain** – World Gold Council
- **Sadaf Sayeed** – Muthoot Microfin
- **Sajith Sivanandan** – Tata Digital
- **Sunnyraj Agarwal** – Chat360
- **Sandeep Agarwal** – Cisco
- **Shinichiro Nishikawa** – NTT DATA
- **Sridhar Narayana** – Perfios Software Solutions
- **Sandeep Ghule** – Credilio Financial Technologies
- **Sandeep Singh** – BharatPe Capital
- **Sandeep Indurkar** – BharatPe
- **Sandesh G S** – Bureau
- **Sanjay Shorey** – National Stock Exchange of India
- **Sanjay Tripathy** – BRISKPE
- **Sanjib Subba** – Kathmandu FinteK
- **Sanket Nayak** – Digio
- **Sarita Ganesh Kamath** – Tata Capital
- **Saujanya Dev** – CRED
- **Sean Hesh** – NTT DATA Payment Services
- **Sekhar Rao** – PhiCommerce
- **Shaji Varghese** – Muthoot FinCorp
- **Shanti Mohan** – LVX and SamVed
- **Shashank Sharma** – Scoreme
- **Shebin John Samuel** – DBS Bank
- **Shergeran Roberto Naidoo** – PayInc
- **Shiladitya Mukhopadhyaya** – Truecaller
- **Sonia Pankaj Asher** – Paramotor Digital Technology
- **Siddharth Pai** – 3one4 Capital
- **Simon Gorbutt** – Luxembourg for Finance
- **Siris Singh** – Citi
- **Sitashwa Srivastava** – Borderless
- **Sivaram Kowta** – Zeta
- **Sivaramakrishnan Iswaran** – Zoho
- **Smrithi Ravi** – Wise
- **Sonia Pankaj Asher** – Paramotor Digital Technology
- **Sreejith Kottarathil** – Bank of Baroda
- **Subra Kumaraswamy** – Visa
- **Subrat Kumar** – Bank of India
- **Sudhir Sehgal** – Paytm Payments Services
- **Sujay Kumar Yadav** – SBI Payment Services
- **Sujeet Tyagi** – Montran India
- **Sukhvinder Kaur** – State Bank of India
- **Sumit Nigam** – Perfios Software Solutions
- **Sunil Alvares** – CDSL Ventures
- **Sunit Bose** – NexNebula Technologies (Zrika)
- **Takuya Senoo** – MUFG Bank
- **Tejas Goenka** – Tally
- **Uttam Kumar** – Punjab National Bank
- **Utkarsh Shukla** – Ringg
- **Varun Kejriwal** – Boston Consulting Group
- **Varun Khullar** – Yubi
- **Vasanth Jeyapaul** – CAMSPay
- **Venkatesh Gummadi** – Credit Saison India
- **Vibhor Jain** – ONDC
- **Vivan Sharan** – Koan Advisory Group
- **Vijay Chandok** – NSDL
- **Vijay Rajagopal** – Nugget by Zomato
- **Vikas Panwar** – GLEIF
- **Vikash Jalan** – Paytm
- **Vikram Raichura** – Helo.ai
- **Vikram Vaidyanathan** – DeltaZen47 Advisors
- **Vinay Tiwari** – Axis Bank
- **Vineet Tyagi** – Biz2X
- **Vinit Bajaj** – Axis Bank
- **Vipul Jain** – AZB & Partners
- **Vivek Belgavi** – PwC
- **Vivek Mandhata** – Boston Consulting Group
- **Yanan Wu** – Surfin
- **Yannick Schneider** – LEINow by Bundesanzeiger Verlag GmbH

Global Payments Partner: Diners Club International, Discover Network — Credit Insights Partner: TransUnion CIBIL — Agenda Partner: pine labs — Digital Engagement Partner: Karix — B2B Lounge Partner: IDFC First Bank — Registration Partner: truecaller business — Global Enterprise Payments Partner: adyen — Innovation Leadership Partner: HSBC — Payments Orchestration Partner: payu — Diamond Partners: NABARD, WhatsApp, BharatPe — Global Payment Solutions Partner: Pay

Banking Innovation Partner: citi — Data Protection & Consent Partner: digio — VIP Lounge Partner: navi — Platinum Partners: ZOHO, Bureau, Paramotor — Gold Investment Partner: World Gold Council — Omni-Channel Payments Partner: Get ePay — Financial Intelligence Partner: IGNOSIS AI — Credit Innovation Partner: experian — Notepad Partner: WISE — Caffeine Partner: LenDen — Session Partner: intellect — Securing & Insuring Partner: mitigata — Beer Booth Partner: CRED — Autonomous Lending Partner: ScoreMe

Gold Partners: Jio Finance, Indian Bank, sinch, Cashfree, ZRIKA, unlimit, DreamFolks, Yubi, DCB BANK, CRIF, Union Bank of India, JUSPAY, CISCO, data sutram, Biz2X, Bank of India

Gold Partners: Red Hat, MONTRAN, airtel Payments Bank, stripe, Nucleus Software, wizz Financial, CleverTap, J.P.Morgan, PRUDENTIAL — Mobile App Security Partner: Protectt.ai — System Of Intelligence Partner: Finarkein — Spend Management Partner: Zaggle — Hydration Partner: SafeGold — Silver Partners: Mastercard, SIGNZY

Silver Partners: raise, mindgate, ISG, PINNACLE, BOLNA, nugget by zomato, Blue Machines, jocata, DevRev, iServeU, helo.ai, LEI Now, NAVANA, Digitap, NORTHERN ARC, PayGlocal

Silver Partners: VAYANA, Ringg.AI, Business, Fundamento, true balance, first hive, kissht — Cloud Communications Partner: telesign, Sify — AI Powered Payments Partner: Razorpay — Loyalty & Marketplaces Partner: vernost — Payment Processing Partner: 86400 — Country Partner: IDA Ireland — Sundowner Partner: scapia — Bronze Partners: gnani, branch

Bronze Partners: HITACHI, TIMES INTERNET, TRACKWIZZ, TBX, HYPERVERGE, protean, NTT DATA Payment Services, PaySprint, RevRag AI, indifly, ippopay, Shellkode, elento, integra, onsurity, OnFinance AI, brandworks, IndiaBonds

Bronze Partners: Vakrangee, Borderless, RAHI Continuum, M-TECH, appreciate, MPI, MUFG, Vampay, Arrowhead, JCB, novus loyalty, Chat360, CredResolve, neo4j, comviva, CockroachDB, Aerospike, GeekyAnts, sumsub

Bronze Partners: TATA CAPITAL, DigiKhata — Supported By: AADHAAR, Reserve Bank Innovation Hub, ONDC, pwc, BCG, EY, KPMG

Join GFF26 - Scan to Register Now


National Bank for Financing
Infrastructure and Development
FINANCING INDIA'S
INFRASTRUCTURE AMBITION
Join leading voices in infrastructure as regulators, investors, developers, lenders and multilateral agencies come together to collaborate, share insights and shape the future of sustainable development. Discover the latest policy updates, explore innovative solutions and forge impactful partnerships.
INFRASTRUCTURE CONCLAVE 2026
September 17, 2026 - 9 am onwards
Panel Topics
Bridging India's infrastructure financing gap: Unlocking domestic and global capital
Mobilizing domestic and global insurance capital for India's infrastructure growth
Structured financial solutions for recycling capital and expanding investment: Securitization, CDS and TRS
Asset monetization for states: Attracting institutional capital for infrastructure
Jio World Convention Centre, BKC, Mumbai.
Scan to register today


PSBs HACKATHON SERIES-2026
(An initiative of Government of India, Ministry of Finance, Department of Financial Services)
यूनियन बैंक ऑफ इंडिया
अच्छे लोग, अच्छा बैंक
Union Bank of India
Good people to bank with
PRESENTS
IDEA 2.0
INNOVATION | DEVELOPMENT | EXECUTION | ADVANCEMENT
Ai - CSPARC
AI Powered Innovation for Customer: Security, Privacy, Assurance, Reliance, Convenience
Digital Trust | Ease of doing Business
Promoting Innovation and Fostering Collaboration
HACKATHON
GRAND FINALE
In association with
SOMAIYA
VIDYAVIHAR UNIVERSITY
EVENT SCHEDULE
Venue - K. J. Somaiya School of Engineering (Auditorium), Vidyavihar (E), Mumbai.
Date - 03rd September, 2026
Time - 3 p.m.
Tune in live!
Scan the QR code or visit https://www.youtube.com/@UnionBankofIndiaUTube/streams to join the event.
PRIZE CATEGORIES
1. Winner
2. First Runner-Up
3. Second Runner-Up
4. All-Women Team
5. Team with PwD Representative
6. Additional Recognition Category
Entry by Invitation Only
Union ease
NextGen Banking App
(Toll Free No.) 1800 2333 / 1800 208 2244 / 1800 425 1515/1800 425 3555
9666606060 | www.unionbankofindia.bank.in |

"Now that we have it under USA control, we change the name Hormuz Strait to TRUMP STRAIT??? Like America itself, it would be 'hotter' than ever before!" Trump on Truth Social

July Clash Back! US Strikes Iran; Tehran Hits Back at Gulf Bases

Two crew members from Philippines killed aboard oil tanker in Hormuz, says Saudi shipping co

Washington | Cairo | Dubai: Iranians and their Arab neighbours were plunged back into war on Wednesday by the biggest exchange of fire between Tehran and Washington since July, with US, forces striking Iran's southern coast and Iran firing at American bases across the region.

The United States threatened more devastating strikes. Asian and European stocks tumbled after the renewed US airstrikes.

The US military said it struck Revolutionary Guard air defences, radar systems, maritime assets, mine-laying capabilities and communications sites on Tuesday. Iran reported hits on multiple targets near the Strait of Hormuz—the narrow waterway where Tehran has threatened tankers attempting to pass

Iran responded by striking what it said were US assets in Bahrain, Jordan, Kuwait and Iraq, and said its aim was now to drive US forces from the vast network of military bases they have occupied for decades across West Asia.

"American evil in the region will be met with heavier, more widespread, and devastating responses, and any country that cooperates with the aggressive American army must accept its dangerous consequences," Iran's military command said.

Qatar, home of the largest US airbase in the Gulf, said it "holds the Islamic Republic of Iran fully legally responsible for these attacks and their repercussions and consequences." Bahrain, which houses the regional headquarters of the US Navy, said Iranian drones were intercepted and destroyed.

A billboard in central Tehran's Enghelab Square on Wednesday AFP

Iran also said two tankers had been struck by mines while being steered through the Strait of Hormuz by US personnel through a channel Tehran says it has closed. Saudi Arabia's national shipping company reported on Wednesday that two Filipino crew had been killed aboard an oil tanker in the strait two days earlier.

FIVE DEAD AT A WEDDING

Iran reported at least 12 deaths from the night of US strikes, with five people including a four-year-old said to have been killed while celebrating a wedding at a home in Sirik. Iranian media said as many as 68 people were wounded there, and released images of several injured children in hospital.

"Last night was like the end of the world," Mahmoud, 38, a municipal worker in Sirik County said.

XI CALLS FOR NO FOREIGN MEDDLING

Chinese President Xi Jinping said Middle Eastern nations should reject external interference, as he met with his Egyptian counterpart Abdel Fattah El-Sisi in Cairo.

2.2 M RIAL = $1 (RECORD LOW)

Iran's currency has dropped to a record low of more than 2.2 million rials per US dollar, two websites tracking the free market rate showed on Wednesday, amid renewed military strikes. The rial has dropped about 10% in the past week. **Agencies**

VOILATILE! Choppy Day for Crude

Brent crude prices were marginally higher in a volatile session on Wednesday, driven by the West Asia war. Brent crude futures rose 25 cents to $94.90 a barrel by 8:18 PM, while US West Texas Intermediate crude futures were up 10 cents at $90.32. The two benchmarks swung between gains of as much as $2 a barrel and losses of $1 a barrel throughout the session. .The two benchmarks earlier climbed to their highest since July 24 at $97.04 and $92.29 a barrel respectively. **Reuters**

NEXT ROUND OF AMERICAN SANCTIONS SOON: BESSENT

Iranian Air, Water and Virtual Assets on Washington's Hit List

Washington: US treasury secretary Scott Bessent on Wednesday said airlines, the maritime industry and digital assets could be possible targets as the Trump administration continues its planned efforts to squeeze Iran's economy.

Bessent, asked about Russian support for Iran in an interview on Fox News following a G20 gathering in North Carolina this week, also warned "everyone" against backing Tehran.

"My message to everyone is stay away. We all want this conflict to end, and the fastest way for the conflict to end is for no one to provide any support to this regime," he told "Fox & Friends" one day after Russian President Vladimir Putin threw his support behind Iran.

"We are having very fulsome talks with anyone supporting the regime," he added.

On Tuesday, Bessent said the administration could also target airline leasing companies and that more Iran bank sanctions could come this week. **Reuters**

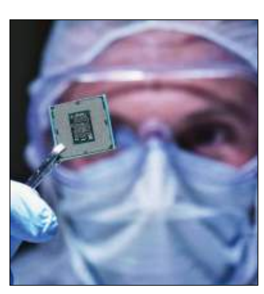
POTUS' Levy Game Chips Won't Taste Good Unless Made in US

The Trump administration is weighing a fresh round of tariffs on imported semiconductors, potentially escalating levies on foreign chips in a bid to lure more manufacturing to the US, commerce secretary Howard Lutnick said Wednesday.

However, Lutnick told CNBC, those levies are likely to be paired with tariff relief for companies that invest in domestic manufacturing, modeling the approach the Trump administration has used on the pharmaceutical industry.

"That's what you should look for in semiconductors: If you build in America, we will give you tariff relief, and if you don't build in America, you will pay tariffs," Lutnick said. "That's pretty much a very sensible way of doing things, and it's working."

President Donald Trump already imposed 25% tariffs on certain advanced semiconductors, ordering those import charges in January after a Commerce Department probe into the trade. However, a new round of tariffs could extend their reach beyond semiconductors to products containing chips — hitting imports of data center servers and consumer electronics.



Critics have warned that additional tariffs could make it more costly to build data centers in the US. But Lutnick cast the inducement of tariff relief for domestic fabrication as a potential solution.

There have been nearly $1.2 tn worth of commitments to build chips in the US

"I think what you're going to see is targeted, thoughtful tariff policy that basically says 'if you build here you don't pay, but if you don't build here, expect to pay to enter the greatest market in the world,'" Lutnick said. "All of the companies know they're coming. They've all gone through it."

Already, he said, there's been some $1.2 trillion in commitments to build semiconductors in the US, with companies such as Taiwan Semicondcutor Manufacturing Co. Ltd. and Micron Technology Inc. investing in domestic facilities.

Some of that has been fed by the US-Taiwan trade pact finalized earlier this year. Under that agreement, Taiwan pledged some $500 billion in investments and credit guarantees to support high-tech manufacturing in the US. Lutnick said an additional round of investment pledges from Taiwan will be announced next week, with the island announcing another $20 billion or $30 billion worth of commitments. **Bloomberg**

JLR's First Electric Range Rover to Cost Over $200k

Jaguar Land Rover Automotive first electric Range Rover will start at $208,420, a price tag that will test wealthy buyers' appetites for a battery-powered sport utility vehicle. Orders are now open for what is one of the most expensive electric SUVs on the market and almost $67,500 more than the standard combustion-engine version. The Range Rover Electric can travel 599 km on a single charge in testing conditions, and goes from 10% to 80%-charged in 22 minutes. It is priced similarly to the electric Mercedes G 580. **Bloomberg**

38K US Pvt Sector Hirings in August Lowest in 2026

Hiring in the US private sector in August was at its slowest pace since the start of the year, data from payroll firm ADP showed on Wednesday, missing market expectations for the third straight month. Private sector job growth came in at 38,000 last month, down from the month before and well below the 47,000 predicted by economists polled by Dow Jones Newswires and WSJ. The manufacturing, professional services and information sectors lost jobs, while education, health care, construction, and leisure and hospitality showed robust hiring, ADP said. **AFP**

Google Avoids 'AdX' Sale as Judge Orders Tech Integration

Alphabet's Google doesn't have to sell off its advertising exchange and instead must make its ad tech tools work with those operated by rivals, a federal judge ruled Wednesday, in a move that saves the tech giant from a second bid to force a breakup. US District Judge Leonie Brinkema issued her decision under seal accompanied by a short order rejecting the Justice Department's bid to force a sale of Google's AdX. Instead, she ordered proposed behavioral changes to Google's business without describing them. The redacted decision will be issued later. **Bloomberg**

G3? Putin, Xi Weigh Trilateral with Trump

Idea for possible Shenzhen meet discussed by Russia and China Presidents at SCO summit

The Presidents of Russia and China discussed the possibility of trilateral talks with Donald Trump at the APEC summit this year, according to the Kremlin's foreign policy aide, in what would be an unprecedented meeting between the leaders of the world's three biggest nuclear powers.

Yuri Ushakov, who's also a former ambassador to the US, told Russian state television on Tuesday that the idea came up at talks between President Vladimir Putin and Chinese leader Xi Jinping on the sidelines of the Shanghai Cooperation Organization summit in Kyrgyzstan.

The three-way meeting would depend on Trump deciding to attend the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation group summit that's due to take place in the Chinese city of Shenzhen on Nov 18-19.

AI IMAGE

Ushakov said Putin plans to attend and may hold talks with both Xi and Trump, either bilaterally or in a joint format.

While China and the US have yet to weigh in on the proposal in any detail, such a meeting would mark a milestone in the effort by Russia to break out of international isolation following its invasion of Ukraine, and potentially allow Xi to play mediator in bringing Putin and Trump together.

"It could be seen as a sort of rehabilitation of Putin on the world stage," said Ian Ja Chong, associate professor of political science at the National University of Singapore. "For Trump, it could present a photo opportunity where he gets to emphasise his peacemaker, dealmaker role."

Xi's hosting of Putin, normally attended by leaders of major economies including Canada, Japan and South Korea, would give the Russian leader his most public international platform since the Ukraine war.

In the wake of the full-scale invasion, Beijing has supported Moscow with economic and diplomatic backing, despi criticism from Europe and Biden administration.

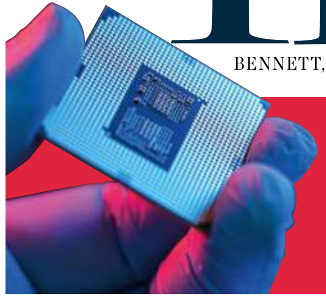
Xi separately hosted Trump and Putin days apart last May.

The three have previously made appearances at the same international events but never held separate talks together. **Bloomberg**

WWW.ECONOMICTIMES.COM

THE ECONOMIC TIMES

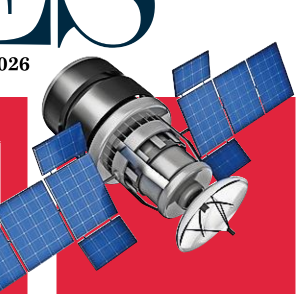
BENNETT, COLEMAN & CO. LTD. | ESTD. 1838 | VOL. 42 NO. 210 | BENGALURU | 18 PAGES | ₹4.00 ONLY | THURSDAY, 3 SEPTEMBER 2026



Chip Design Inc Awaits Clarity on Semiconductor Mission 2.0 Sops | Amid AI Shift, IT Services Firms & GCCs Woo Domain Experts

DISRUPTION: AI, STARTUPS & TECH ▸▸ 4

INDIA & EUROPEAN UNION LOOK TO DEEPEN TECH TIES ▸▸ PAGE 8



PUREPOLITICS

Retired Air Marshal Mishra Named First Ram Temple Trust CEO

The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust has appointed Air Marshal Jeetendra Mishra (retd) as its first chief executive officer. The trust that met in Ayodhya on Wednesday appointed Swami Govinddev Giri as general secretary with immediate effect and named Mahesh Bhagchandka its treasurer. **Sanjay Singh** reports. ▸▸ 2

HC Orders CBI Probe into Disha Salian's Death ▸▸ 3

States Unanimously Back Shift to Online Test Mode for Exams

State governments have almost unanimously backed the idea of switching to Computer-Based Testing at a meeting held with Nandan Nilekani-led high-powered task force on exam reforms. States are also strongly in favour of setting up government-backed testing infrastructure and centres. **Anubhuti Vishnoi** reports. ▸▸ 3

'Diverse India Offers Shiseido a Challenge'

India's diversity throws up a challenge to build a business across "different Indias" or states, spanning different cultures, climates, consumer behaviours and skin tones, Nicole Tan, president and CEO for APAC region for Shiseido, tells **Aanya Thakur** & **Sagar Malviya**. ▸▸ 12

AIMING FOR UNDERSERVED REGIONS

Fly91 Puts in $1B Order for 40 Turboprop Planes

Regional airline Fly91 has placed one of the largest orders in recent times for 40 ATR-72 turboprop aircraft, reports **Arindam Majumder**. At list price, the order is valued over $1 billion. The carrier is bullish on underserved areas. ▸▸ 14

Gr$$nback with a Bang

FCNR(B) Brings in Over $127 B

Makes up lion's share of $136B+ total special scheme inflows; last 10 days nearly double kitty

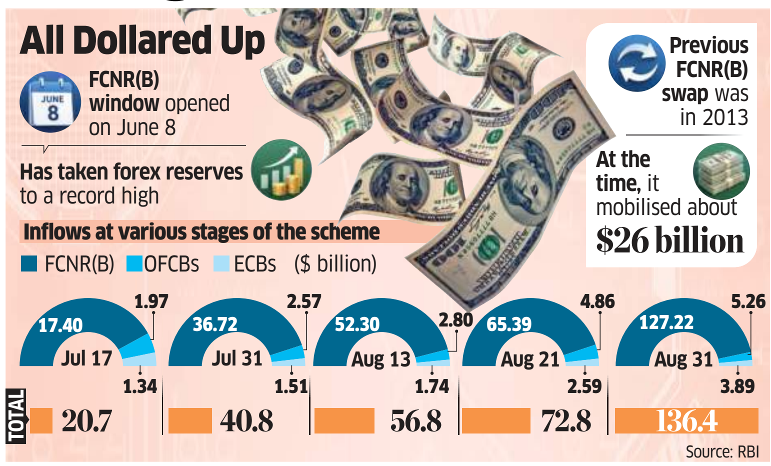
Our Bureau

Mumbai: Banks pulled in a record $127.22 billion through foreign currency non-resident (bank), or FCNR(B), deposits before the special window closed end of last month. This is nearly five times the $26 billion raised under a similar scheme in 2013.

The haul took total inflows through special schemes — including FCNR (B), overseas foreign currency borrowings (OFCBs) and external commercial borrowings (ECBs) — to $136.37 billion, according to provisional data released by the Reserve Bank of India on Wednesday.

The rush for dollars intensified in the final days of the window, with banks mobilising $61.8 billion through FCNR (B) deposits in the last 10 days alone, nearly as much as the $65.4 billion raised in the first 74 days.

FCNR(B) deposits accounted for more than 93% of total dollar inflows under the special schemes.



Forex Kitty Past $729 B by Aug 21 ▸▸ 8

RELATED REPORT ▸▸ 10

After 35 Years, JCRA Upgrades India Rating

Japan Credit Rating Agency has upgraded India's sovereign rating to A-, citing solid economic growth, policies and more. ▸▸ 13

Refiners in the Crosshairs Again

Iran-US Attacks Restart Some Gulf cargoes delayed, cancelled; cos seek alternative barrels

Sanjeev Choudhary

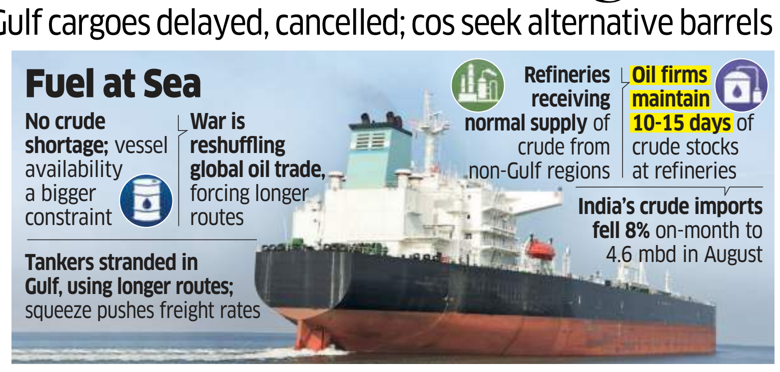
New Delhi: Crude supply disruptions are mounting for Indian refiners, marked by rising vessel attacks and transit bottlenecks in the Gulf and exacerbated by a tight tanker market, threatening timely deliveries, said people familiar with the matter.

Some refiners are facing delays and cancellations of contracted cargoes from the Gulf, forcing them to scramble for supplies from alternative markets, the people said. But finding vessels remains a major challenge. Also, arranging ships with replacement barrels would take time.

Refiners fear they may be forced to make unplanned cuts to refinery runs if the replacement cargoes arrive late, people said. "It is a challenging time for refineries," said one of the persons.

Over Tuesday night, West Asia saw the biggest US bombardment on Iran since July, with Tehran targeting American bases across the region in retaliation. The conflict seems set to escalate, with US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent warning "everyone" against backing Iran, while the latter threatened Washington with a "new strategy."

India's crude imports fell 8% sequentially to 4.6 million barrels per day in August, a four-month low, according to Kpler. Some executives attributed the decline in part to vessel delays.



Plans Disrupted ▸▸ 8

BIG WIN FOR NOEL TATA

NRTT-Naval Tata Share Transfer Inquiry Closed

Charity Commissioner finds 1989 Tata Sons share sale followed due process

Kala Vijayraghavan & Rashmi Rajput

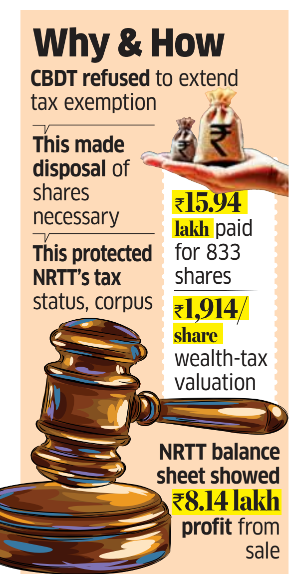
Mumbai: The Maharashtra Charity Commissioner has closed the inquiry into the 1989 transfer of 833 Tata Sons shares by the Navajbai Ratan Tata Trust (NRTT) to Naval H Tata, observing that the transaction "was made in full compliance with the provisions of law then in force", effectively drawing the curtains on a dispute over the share transfer that dates back more than three decades.

The share transfer was raked up in recent months as a fight for control broke out among stakeholders in the Tata universe, and was seen as a move to embattle Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata, as the matter related to the shares he inherited, according to complainants. This decision will come as a relief to Noel Tata, who is set to consolidate his control over the business empire with chairman N Chandrasekaran having announced his decision to move on at the end of his term early 2027.

In an order dated September 2, reviewed by **ET**, State Charity Commissioner Amogh S Kaloti said the Trust had established that the sale was necessitated by tax considerations, was backed by proper documentation and valuation, and complied with the laws applicable at the time.

The order, however, does not lift the restraint imposed by the Charity Commissioner on the Sir Ratan Tata Trust (SRTT).

No Legal Bar ▸▸ 8



INTEREST-BEARING BALANCES SHRINKING

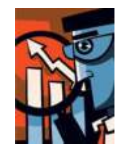
Credit Card-led Profits Fall

India's credit card boom is now less lucrative for issuers, yielding lower profit margins for banks even as spending rises. **Saloni Shukla** reports. ▸▸ 10

DoT Panel Call Soon on Satcom Spectrum Fee

An inter-ministerial panel is likely to take a call soon on satellite spectrum fee as well as other modalities like tenure of airwaves allocation to satcom firms. The Digital Communications Commission is expected to approve spectrum charges at 5% of AGR, with an incentive to serve certain rural and remote areas. **Kiran Rathee** reports. ▸▸ 12

MoSPI Rebuts Claims Over GDP Estimates



The statistics ministry has defended India's latest GDP estimates amid criticism that 7.8% growth reported for the June quarter looked inflated. The government cited the change in the accounting base year, improved data sources and methodologies to stress that the latest GDP growth figure better reflected the economic activity. ▸▸ 13

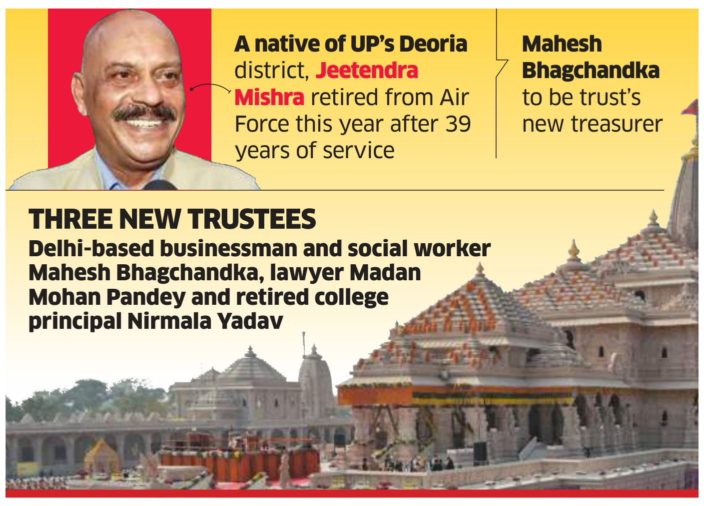
JSW, KKR, Inox Among Suitors for BluPine

JSW Neo Energy, Inox Clean, Blackstone and Macquarie are among those looking to acquire BluPine Energy, reports **Mohit Bhalla**. They submitted non-binding offers in the ₹22,000 crore enterprise value range on Wednesday for the renewable energy company. KKR, Brookfield and RP Sanjiv Goenka Group's Purvah Green are also in the fray. ▸▸ 14

SWAMI GOVINDDEV GIRI NAMED TRUST'S GENERAL SECRETARY

Air Marshal Mishra (Retd) 1st Ram Temple Trust CEO

Played a key role during Op Sindoor as Western Air commander; he is a recipient of Sarvottam Yudh Seva Medal



Sanjay Singh

New Delhi: The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust on Wednesday appointed Air Marshal Jeetendra Mishra (retired) as its first chief executive officer.

Mishra played a key role during Operation Sindoor as the Western Air commander and is a recipient of the Sarvottam Yudh Seva Medal, awarded for distinguished service of the most exceptional order during wartime. A native of UP's Deoria district, he retired from the Air Force this year after 39 years of service.

The trust that met in Ayodhya on Wednesday appointed Swami Govinddev Giri as its general secretary with immediate effect and named Mahesh Bhagchandka its treasurer. Giri replaced Krishna Mohan, who has been functioning as the trust's interim general secretary after Champat Rai resigned on moral grounds following the controversy over alleged theft of donations at the temple.

It also decided to induct three new trustees: Delhi-based businessman and social worker Mahesh Bhagchandka, lawyer Madan Mohan Pandey who fought legal battles for the Ram temple in the Allahabad High Court and the Supreme Court, and retired college principal Nirmala Yadav.

REDUCING HUMAN ROLE

Trust discusses ways to reduce human intervention in counting donation received at the temple

EVALUATING PROPOSALS

Trust receives proposals from 2 banks and an IIT for using tech; it is likely to evaluate the proposals

Ram Temple admin's structure changed following row over alleged donation theft

The trust welcomed the Supreme Court's recent order expanding the scope of the special investigation team probing the theft case. As per the trust, this would help establish the truth and remove "confusion" among devotees and the public.

The trust discussed ways to reduce human intervention in the counting of donation money received at the temple. According to a report, the trust already received proposals from two banks and an IIT for using technology. It is likely to evaluate these proposals.

The trust decided to appoint a full-time CEO following the controversy over the alleged donation theft and appointed a three-member search committee to come up with a shortlist of candidates.

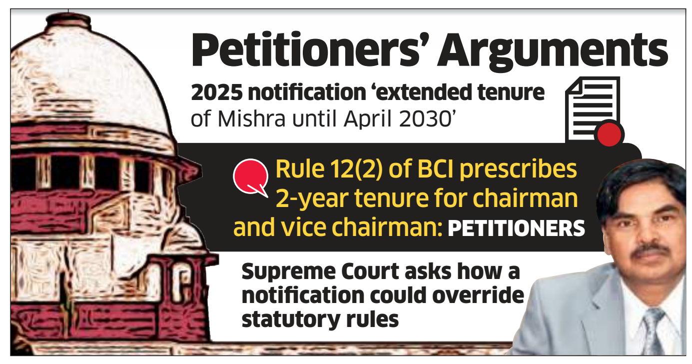
The committee comprising former Supreme Court judge Pramod Kohli, Lieutenant General Vishnukant Chaturvedi (retired) and Suresh Haware, who is a former chairperson of the Shri Saibaba Sansthan Trust in Shirdi, examined 5,585 applications and recommended a panel of three candidates.

PETITIONERS SEEKING BCI'S RECONSTITUTION VIA FRESH POLLS

SC Questions BCI Chair's Continued Term, says he is Only Pro Tem Chief

Manan Mishra's 'continuation cannot be treated as mandate to remain chairman until 2030'

Our Political Bureau



New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Wednesday questioned the continued tenure of Bar Council of India (BCI) chairman Manan Kumar Mishra, making it clear that his continuation in the post cannot be treated as a mandate to remain chairman until 2030. The court observed that he is only a "pro tem" chairman until a freshly constituted BCI elects its office-bearers.

A three-member bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was hearing a clutch of petitions challenging Mishra's prolonged tenure and seeking BCI's reconstitution through fresh elections. Mishra is also a BJP Rajya Sabha MP.

Justice Bagchi verbally remarked that the existing arrangement was only meant to ensure the day-to-day functioning of BCI until fresh elections. "It is not a situation where he is democratically elected and continues to be so," the bench orally observed, stressing that Mishra's tenure was co-terminus with the election of a newly constituted BCI.

The court's intervention followed arguments challenging a 2025 notification that purportedly extended Mishra's tenure as BCI chairman until April 2030. Petitioners pointed out that Rule 12(2) of the BCI Rules prescribes a two-year tenure for the chairman and vice chairman.

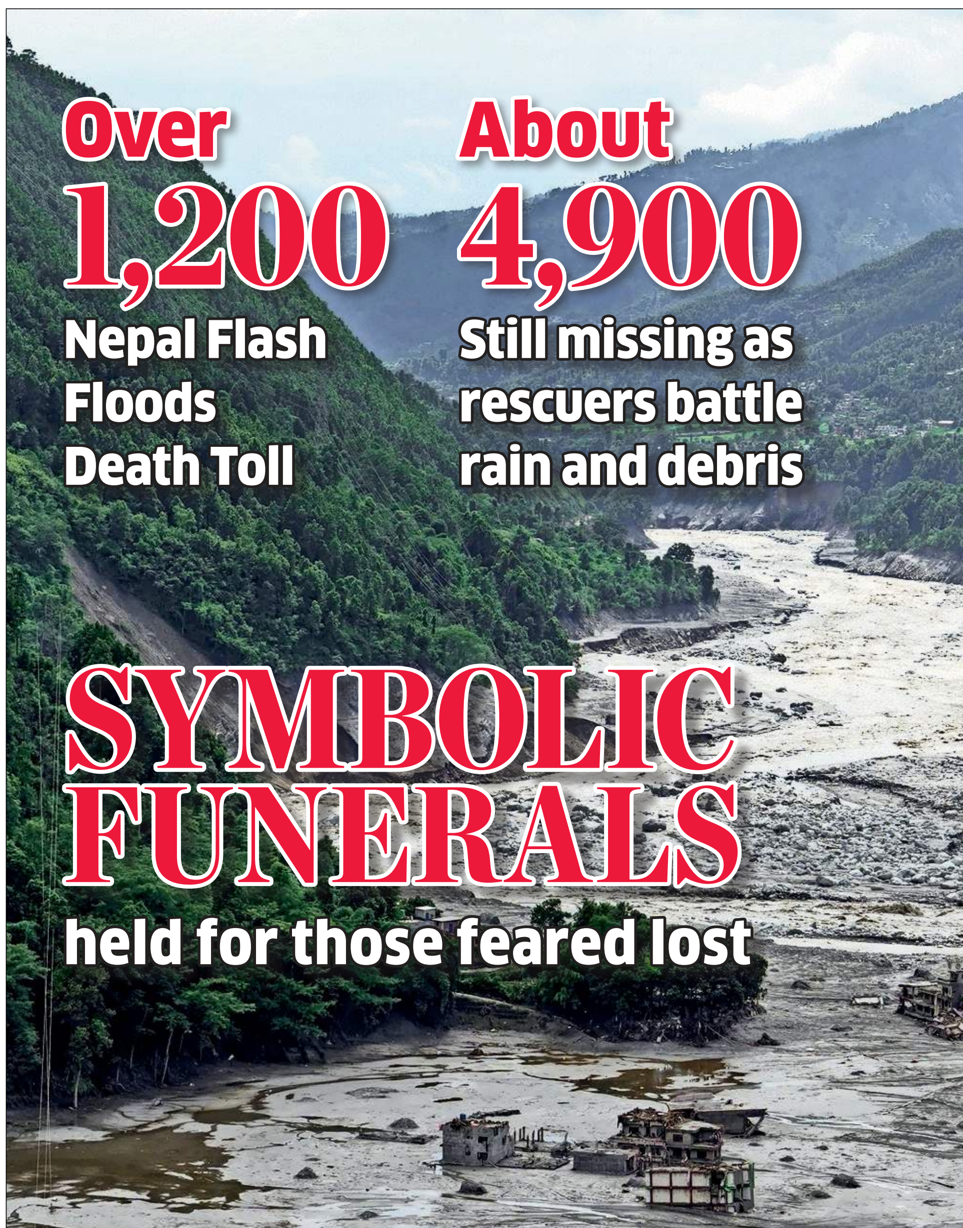
The bench questioned how a notification could override the statutory rules. Justice Bagchi observed if the rule prescribing a two-year tenure applied, an administrative notification could not confer an additional term.

Rather than immediately deciding the legality of Mishra's continuation, the court sought to accelerate the process of constituting new state bar councils, which would pave the way for BCI's reconstitution.

The bench directed the high court chief justices to complete the co-option of two women members to the state bar councils within two weeks. The councils have thereafter been directed to notify their new composition within a week. The newly constituted state bar councils must then elect their office-bearers and representatives to BCI within three weeks.

The court will consider BCI's reconstitution after receiving compliance reports from state bar councils.

PHOTOS: AGENCIES



There is a global contribution behind climate change. And the responsibility to manage and minimise its effects also rests on the global community

BALENDRA SHAH
Nepal's Prime Minister

Agencies

Kathmandu: The death toll from Nepal's devastating flash floods crossed 1,200 on Wednesday, with over 4,200 still missing, as rescuers battled rain and debris, while Prime Minister Balendra Shah said the disaster's link to climate change must be strongly raised with the international community.

The flash floods, triggered by an ice-rock avalanche near the Nepal-Tibet border on August 26, devastated towns and villages in northern and central Nepal, leaving a trail of destruction and thousands of people missing.

Across the border in Tibet, China raised its death toll to 21, with 541 others still listed as missing.

Addressing the House of Representatives, PM Shah said the scale and nature of the disaster raised serious questions about the growing risks faced by people living in the Himalayan region due to climate change. There is a global contribution behind climate change. And the responsibility to manage and minimise its effects also rests with the global community, the PM said.

'Dozens of workers may be found alive in underground chamber at Rasuwagadhi hydropower plant'

Some families in Nuwakot, one of Nepal's worst-affected districts, have held symbolic funerals for relatives still missing, hoping to free their souls after they were presumed dead.

COMPENSATE NEPAL: KHANAL

Nepal foreign minister Shisir Khanal has identified China, the US and India as the world's three largest greenhouse gas emitters and said they have a "historical responsibility to compensate vulnerable nations like Nepal".

Poliloquy R PRASAD

JARANGE PATIL'S FAST ENTERS DAY 5

Protesters Block Roads in Parts of Maharashtra


FILE PHOTO

Demand Kunbi (OBC) caste certificates for Maratha community; Deadlock continues

Krishna Kumar

Mumbai: Maratha leader Manoj Jarange Patil's fast entered the fifth day on Wednesday even as the deadlock continues on the Maratha leader's demand to give Kunbi (OBC) caste certificates to the Maratha community. Protestors from different parts of the state have started blocking roads to support Jarange Patil.

The Dhule-Solapur highway was blocked for more than two hours by protesters. They also blocked Dharashiv-Ausa road and occupied the road at Katraj Chowk in Pune. A Dharashiv bandh has been called by protestors on Thursday. Patil warned that on September 12 the stir will move from Antarvali Sarati village, where he is undertaking the fast, to Mumbai where thousands of Maratha protesters are likely to gather.

Jarange Patil warns that stir will move from Antarvali Sarati village to Mumbai on Sept 12

The Maratha leader has sought that the state government issue a government resolution, recognising 58 lakh Marathas as Kunbi caste, as per historical records.

BJP TARGETS RAHUL ON WOMEN QUOTA

Maha Kumbh 'Graft', SIR Deletions, Farm Distress Raised During RG's Visit

Rahul visits Nashik to address leaders at the conclusion of Maha Cong's 10-day camp

Krishna Kumar

There has been a lot of corruption in the infrastructure works taken up during Nashik Kumbh mela. We spoke to him about how there is no project report for the Kumbh mela and people were not taken into confidence. The entire project seems to be to get contracts for some chosen contractors and get 40% commission

PRITHVIRAJ CHAVAN
Senior Congress Leader

Mumbai: Alleged corruption in the Nashik Kumbh mela and land acquisition for the ambitious ₹1 lakh crore Shakti Peeth expressway may become part of national political discourse, with Maharashtra Congress leaders apprising Rahul Gandhi about these issues on Wednesday. Gandhi was in Nashik to address leaders at the conclusion of Maharashtra Congress' 10-day organisational training camp.

"There has been a lot of corruption in the infrastructure works taken up during the Nashik Kumbh mela. We spoke to him about how there is no project report for the Kumbh mela and people were not taken into confidence. The entire project seems to be to get contracts for some chosen contractors and get 40% commission," senior Congress leader Prithviraj Chavan said after the meeting.

He said that leaders also apprised him about farmer distress and farmers' opposition to land acquisition for the Shakti Peeth Expressway. They also updated him on the SIR exercise in the state which has deleted 2 crore voters from the list. Gandhi on Tuesday took to social media and asked: "Maharashtra 2024: Suddenly 3.9 million voters were added between the Lok Sabha and Vidhan Sabha elections. I said it then and I say it today. This was vote theft... And now in Maharashtra, 2.07 crore voters have been removed from the draft list — that's every fifth voter. Which list was correct," he asked.

"BJP and the 'Vote Theft Commission' keep changing their tactics and they will continue to do so — the goal remains just one: BJP's victory at any cost, and the end of India's democracy," he added.

Congress in Maharashtra has got a second wind after the recent students' protests and Gandhi's visit to Pune last month, where he highlighted issues pertaining to tribal students in the state which forced the state government to negotiate with tribal students to accept their demands.

ASKS BJP'S NAVNATH BAN

'Why had Gandhi not taken action against a Cong leader in whose ashram school in Gadchiroli three girl students died of snake bites last month?'

BJP carried out protests in Nashik against Rahul Gandhi, claiming Congress was against women's reservation. BJP spokesman Navnath Ban asked why Gandhi had not taken action against a Congress leader in whose ashram school in Gadchiroli three girl students died of snake bite last month.

J&K Capital Turns into Protest-Nagar for A Day

BJP & ruling NC trade charges, accuse each other of betraying UT & failing to fulfil promises

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Srinagar: The ruling National Conference (NC) and BJP took out separate protests in Srinagar accusing each other of betraying Jammu and Kashmir and failing to fulfil the promises made to the people here.

BJP state chief Sat Sharma, along with Leader of the Opposition in J&K assembly, Sunil Sharma, led a massive protest rally in the heart of Srinagar city at Lal Chowk and were planning "civil secretariat gherao", but were disallowed by the police who had barricaded the roads and put concertina wire at several places.

STREET FIGHT BETWEEN THE BIG TWO UT PARTIES

People are fed up with National Conference govt. It has failed to fulfil promises: BJP; NC: PM-led Centre is not fulfilling the promise of restoration of statehood


AFP
BJP supporters in Srinagar


ANI
NC members near BJP office

The National Conference leadership, led by Sakina Ittoo, a minister in Omar Abdullah's Cabinet and other senior MLAs like Ali Muhammad Sagar and Shamima Firdous, led a protest towards BJP's office in Jawahar Nagar area on the other side of river Jhelum that passes right through Srinagar city. Police stopped the NC protest at Rajbagh police station and disallowed them from moving towards BJP's office. Several NC leaders and members were temporarily detained.

Malik to Divorce Pak Wife, Seeks Capital Punishment in Sarla Bhat Murder Case

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Srinagar: Yasin Malik, who heads the banned Jammu and Kashmir Liberation Front (JKLF), has announced that he will not contest the trial proceedings in the murder case of Kashmiri Pandit nurse Sarla Bhat, seeking capital punishment. He has also decided to divorce his Pakistani wife, Mushaal Malik.

Malik, who has been lodged in Tihar Jail in Delhi since 2019, made the latest submissions before the court of additional sessions judge (TADA/POTA) in Srinagar, providing details surrounding the case being investigated by the State Investigation Agency regarding Sarla Bhat, who was killed in 1990 and in which he is one of the accused. The submission was made before the court by Malik's counsel, advocate Abu Adil Pandit, on September 2, and the matter is now listed for reply on September 19.


FILE PHOTO

I believe that I have been falsely implicated in the present case... My decision shall not be treated as an admission of guilt or acceptance of the allegations made against me

YASIN MALIK *Lodged in Tihar Jail*

"I have no complaint against this court or the prosecuting agencies. I respectfully state that, in my understanding, the present proceedings have arisen out of political circumstances and decisions and I believe that I have been falsely implicated in the present case," Malik wrote in his 25-page submission before the court. He said he had taken the decision after "Istikhara", an Islamic prayer performed before taking an important decision. "Considering my personal circumstances and after deep reflection, I have decided not to contest the trial proceedings further. My decision shall not be treated as an admission of guilt or acceptance of the allegations made against me. I request for capital punishment," he said.

In a personal note to his family, Malik, while addressing his wife, said he did not wish her to spend the rest of her life carrying the burden of his circumstances or living as a widow. "You are twenty years younger than me... I therefore request you to find the courage to begin a new chapter of your life with dignity and hope... I shall always love, respect and remember both of you... that before I will be hanged I have taken the decision to separate you from the bond of our Nikkah, I don't know how I will pronounce separation from you..." Malik said, while quoting a long passage from Nelson Mandela addressed to Nomzamo.

This newspaper is published by Manjeet Singh Dhami from Bennett Coleman & Co Ltd., Elixir Chancery Building, 1st, 2nd and 4th Floor, 135, Residency Road, Shanthala Nagar, Bengaluru – 560025 (Phones: Office: EPABX - 080- 42200000, Editorial: 080- 46787878) on behalf of Bennett Coleman & Co Ltd., edited by Manu P Toms and printed by Sekar S at Bennett Coleman & Co Ltd., The Times of India Press, No. 9/10/11-A, 4th Main, KIADB Bommasandra Industrial Area, Anekal Taluk, Bangalore - 560 099 (Ph: 080-22899999). Regd office: Dr. D.N. Road, Mumbai - 400 001. REGD. NO. CPMG/KA/GPO-31/200C3-05, RNI NO. 45467/85

PROJECTS TO CREATE 66,360 JOBS

CM's Panel Nod for ₹29,679 cr Investment Proposals For State

BENGALURU: A high-level committee chaired by Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Wednesday approved nine new investment proposals and eight additional investment proposals involving a total investment of ₹29,679.20 crore. The projects are expected to create 66,360 jobs across Karnataka. Mahindra Aerostructures' proposal to invest ₹2,300 crore is among the new projects cleared by the committee. The investment is expected to create around 3,000 jobs. The nine new projects involve investments of ₹25,710.56 crore and are expected to generate 64,349 jobs. Hero Future Energies accounts for the largest investment among the proposals, with a ₹9,760 crore project expected to create 3,200 jobs. Vibrancy Real Estates will invest ₹2,195.94 crore and is expected to generate 30,000 jobs. **Our Bureau**

SEEKS 2.5 ACRES

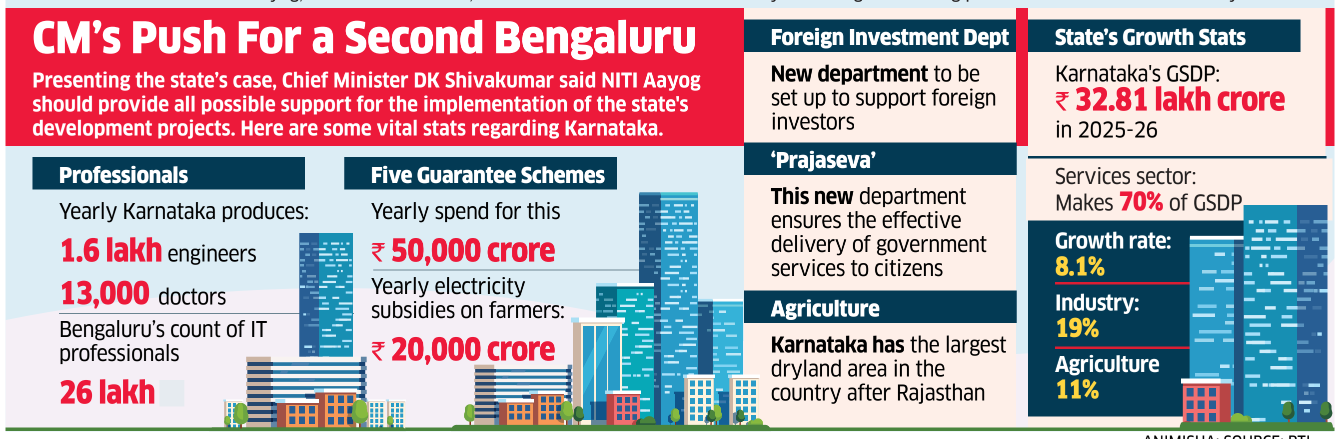
Carver Aviation Plans Flying Training Unit at Vijayapura Airport

BENGALURU: Maharashtra-based Carver Aviation is planning to set up a satellite flying training academy at Vijayapura airport, infrastructure development minister MB Patil said on Wednesday. The company has sought 2.5 acres of land adjoining the airport premises to establish the facility, Patil said after meeting Carver Aviation director Neville Bharucha and manager Pramesh Parikh at Khanij Bhavan in Bengaluru, industries department said in a statement. An official-level meeting will be held to discuss the proposal and finalise the modalities for setting up the academy, he said. The proposed facility could support flight training, aircraft maintenance, MRO. **Our Bureau**

FOCUS TO BE BENGALURU METROPOLITAN REGION

$400 B Plan for City's 500th Birthday
Economic Master Plan Drawn Up

Vice Chairman of NITI Aayog, Ashok Kumar Lahiri, CM DK Shivakumar and minister Priyank Kharge discussing plans for the state on Wednesday. ANI



ANIMISHA; SOURCE: PTI

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Karnataka has drawn up an Economic Master Plan to develop the Bengaluru Metropolitan Region (BMR) as a global growth hub and expand its economy to $400 billion by 2037, the year Bengaluru completes 500 years.

The plan, prepared by the Institute for Sustainability, Employment and Growth (ISEG) Foundation in collaboration with the state government and presented to Chief Minister DK Shivakumar, envisages creating 2-2.5 million jobs and strengthening the region's position in technology, advanced manufacturing, healthcare, education and tourism, according to an official statement.

The plan seeks to drive private investment, use land value capture to finance urban transformation, and ensure inclusive and sustainable growth.

MASSIVE MAP

BMR is currently a $149 billion economy spread across three districts and home to about 16 million people, according to ISEG report

BMR, as defined in the report, is currently a $149 billion economy spread across three districts and home to about 16 million people. It accounts for 40% of Karnataka's gross state domestic product, despite having about a quarter of the state's population. Its per capita income is nearly twice the state average.

The plan proposes developing BMR as a global hub for IT, global capability centres, artificial intelligence and technology startups, with dedicated IT and GCC hubs, deep-tech sandboxes and an AI mission. It also seeks to position the region as a deep-tech manufacturing hub across seven sectors, including aerospace and defence, electronics, automotive, biopharma and medical devices. Tertiary healthcare, higher education and high-end tourism have also been identified as key growth areas.

The plan targets increasing public transport's modal share from 35% to 75% through expansion of metro, suburban rail and regional rapid transit corridors. It also proposes a second airport, stronger ring, radial and chord roads, and multi-modal hubs.

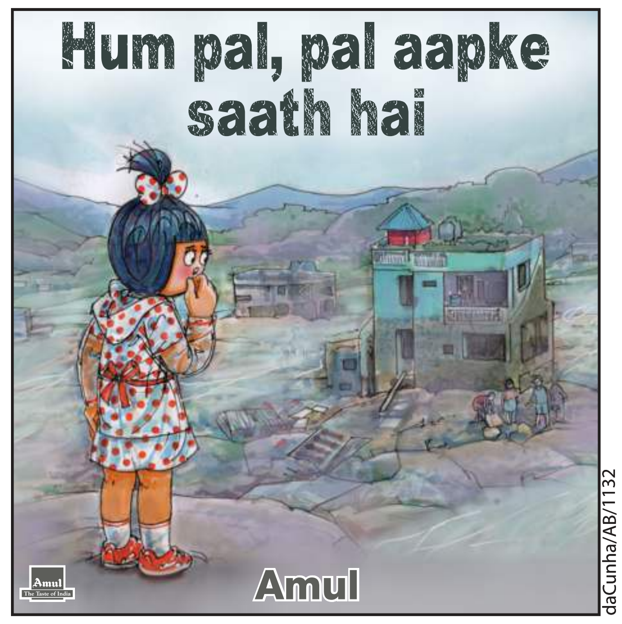
For water security, it recommends supply augmentation, greater reuse of treated water and optimisation of distribution networks.

The plan also calls for planned cities, services-led business districts, integrated private townships and transit-oriented development.

It proposes expanding affordable and shared rental housing for industrial, gig and services workers, along with a slum rehabilitation programme.

Bengaluru Development Minister Krishna Byre Gowda, Home & IT/BT Minister Priyank Kharge, Chief Secretary Shalini Rajneesh and advisor to the CM, LK Atheeq were present among others. ISEG Foundation was represented by Shirish Sankhe, Rasagya Kabra and Aditi Vyas.

The government will discuss the recommendations with stakeholder departments before finalising an actionable growth plan for BMR, the statement said.



MINISTER GOWDA JOINS TRIAL RUN

Kalena Agrahara to Tavarekere Pink Line may Open this Month

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: The 7.5-km Kalena Agrahara-Tavarekere stretch of Bengaluru Metro's Pink Line on Bannerghatta Road is expected to open for commuters this month, with the state government awaiting a communication on the inauguration date from the Union government.

Bengaluru Development Minister Krishna Byre Gowda travelled on the stretch during a trial run on Wednesday, accompanied by Bengaluru South MP Tejasvi Surya, Bengaluru South MLA M Krishnappa, Metro MD PC Jaffer and senior officials.

The stretch is part of the 21.25-km Pink Line connecting Kalena Agrahara (Gottigere) in south Bengaluru with Nagawara on the Outer Ring Road.

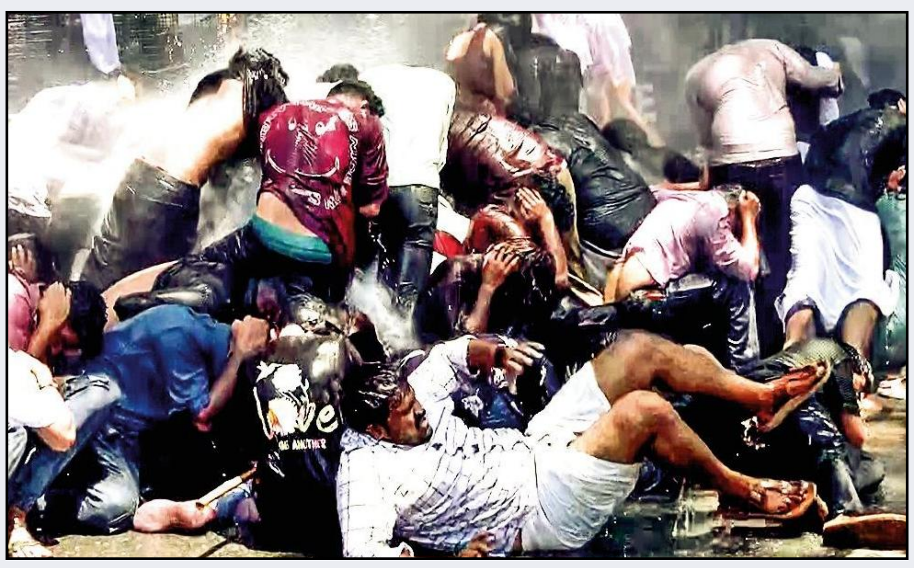
"As soon as the date is given by the Government of India, this stretch will be inaugurated and opened for commuters. We are hopeful of getting a date for the inauguration within September," Gowda said. The announcement drew a positive response on social media, with some users urging the government to start commercial operations without waiting for a formal inauguration.

Surya said he had spoken to the Commissioner of Metro Rail Safety (CMRS) about safety clearances and timelines. "Rolling stock approval is expected within the next 15 days, followed by clearance for the entire line. I will work closely with officials and the Central Government to ensure these approvals are secured at the earliest," he said in a post on X.

He said Bengaluru needed more public transport projects such as the Pink Line to ease traffic congestion, rather than "stupid ideas like the Tunnel Road".

Several users responding to Gowda's post also urged him to inspect Bannerghatta Road, citing poor pedestrian infrastructure and the lack of usable footpaths in several stretches.

PROTEST AGAINST SAFFRONISATION OF VARSITIES TAKES AN UGLY TURN



WATER CANNONS USED

SFI March to Kerala Secretariat over Varsity Row Turns Tense

Thiruvananthapuram: A protest march by the SFI, the student wing of CPI(M), to the Keralam Secretariat against alleged police action on students protesting the "saffronisation" of universities turned tense on Wednesday, with police using water cannons and resorting to minor force.

The Students Federation of India alleged that police used water cannons several times as its activists attempted to move towards the secretariat and that several students were injured in the lathi charge. The student body also claimed that similar protests held at district centres across the state were met with police action. In Palakkad, police used water cannons against an SFI protest march towards the office of the Superintendent of Police, it said.—PTI

Billboard Row: O'Brien Grilled for Five Hours

Our Political Bureau

Kolkata: Trinamool Congress Rajya Sabha member **Derek O'Brien** appeared before the Kolkata Police on Wednesday. He was questioned for around five hours in connection with a row over the removal of an allegedly illegal billboard at the party office of Diamond Harbour MP Abhishek Banerjee on Camac Street.

O'Brien arrived at the Shakespeare Sarani police station around 10 am. He appeared before the police following the second summons. He had earlier sought seven days' time to appear before the police.

On Tuesday, Trinamool Congress national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee appeared for questioning at the same police station and faced a marathon grilling for over six hours.

Meanwhile, Sumit Roy, the personal assistant to Banerjee, was also scheduled to appear for interrogation at the police station on Wednesday.

Kolkata Police had issued summons to O'Brien and Banerjee in connection with the ruckus following the removal of an allegedly illegal billboard at Banerjee's office on Thursday.

Three FIRs have been filed at the Shakespeare Sarani Police Station. In two of the three FIRs, Banerjee, O'Brien and other leaders, including Humayun Kabir and Baishwanar Chatterjee, have been named.

COURT FLAGS 'TOO MANY GLARING DISCREPANCIES'

HC Orders CBI Probe Into Disha Salian Death

Our Political Bureau

Mumbai: Observing that there were "too many glaring discrepancies" in the investigation into the death of Disha Salian that warranted a proper and substantive probe, the Bombay High Court on Wednesday ordered a CBI investigation into the circumstances surrounding her death.

Salian, 28, had reportedly fallen from the 12th floor of a building in Malad, Mumbai, in June 2020. Her death occurred five days before the body of Bollywood actor Sushant Singh Rajput was found at his rented residence in Bandra on June 14. Salian briefly worked as manager of Rajput. BJP leader Nitesh Rane had alleged that the two deaths were linked.

The division bench of justices Sarang V Kotwal and Ranjitsinha Raja Bhonsale observed that the police inquiry conducted under Section 174 of the CrPC over nearly six years was "inadequate and insufficient" and "raises more questions than it answers".

The bench, however, made it clear that it was not recording any finding against any individual and that the CBI would have complete freedom to investigate all aspects of the case. "We do not want to interfere with the investigation in any manner. The investigating agency shall have full freedom to investigate all aspects of this case in accordance with law," the court said.

DEATH LINK ALLEGATION

Salian, who briefly worked as Sushant Singh Rajput's manager, died five days before his death

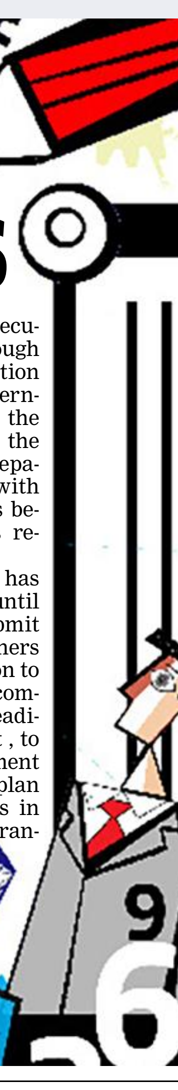
Among the circumstances flagged by the court was the delay in conducting the spot panchnama. Though the police had reached the building shortly after the incident, the panchnama was conducted only between 9:40 am and 9:45 am on June 9, 2020 — more than nine hours after the incident. The HC said the delay remained unexplained and "raises reasonable suspicion about the steps taken by the police right at the beginning."

The court also questioned the timing of the accidental death report (ADR). The incident/death was recorded as having occurred at 2:25 am, while the ADR was registered at 3:07 am. The ADR mentioned that statements of Salian's parents had already been recorded. However, her father's statement indicated that he received a call from Malvani police at about 3 am, reached the hospital at 4 am and learnt of his daughter's death there.

NILEKANI PANEL ENGAGES STATES ON EXAMS

States Unanimous on Shift to Comp-based Exams; Govt Centres

Nilekani panel pitches computer-based testing with end-to-end digitisation



Anubhuti Vishnoi

New Delhi: State governments have almost unanimously backed the idea of switching to Computer Based Testing (CBT) for entrance exams at a September 1 meeting with the Nandan Nilekani-led High Powered Task Force (HPTF) on exam reforms, ET has learnt.

States are strongly in favour of creating government-backed testing infrastructure and centres and ensuring high quality standards at all testing centres including private sector managed ones, it is gathered.

A Centrally Sponsored Scheme (CSS) like model to help fund establishment of testing centres across states — both from the scratch and in existing government schools/colleges/institutes — was also discussed at the meet.

Some states, ET has learnt, raised concerns about the quality of testing infrastructure available currently. With just 1-2 private companies running the country's CBT/online testing infrastructure, there is a serious shortage of capacity and often leads to usage of substandard testing centres.

1-2
COMPANIES RUNNING ENTIRE TESTING FLAGGED BY STATES

Several testing centres are known to accommodate far more students than actual seat availability and are often faced with server connectivity issues and power cuts, resulting in exam disruptions.

Testing centres, therefore, and in keeping with the Radhakrishnan panel recommendations is set to be a major pitch from the HPTF.

The Nilekani panel, ET gathers, strongly pitched for CBT and online testing format supported with end-to-end digitisation of the testing process, at the meet.

Panel holds 3 rounds of stakeholder talks; public feedback invited till Sept 13

Strengthening the National Testing Agency (NTA) and test execution agencies in states was also a key focus area in the deliberations with chief secretaries and senior official from all state/ union territory governments.

The HPTF, announced by the Centre, amid escalating student protests over the NEET-UG 2026 leak and cancellation, has held three major rounds of discussions so far with various stakeholders from union ministries and departments involved to state governments.

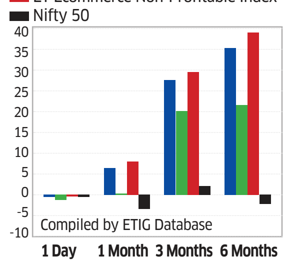
Last week, it also sought feedback from the public which will be accepted until September 13.

The panel, as ET earlier reported, aims at readying an action plan in advance so that changes may be effected in the 2027 exam cycle of NEET-UG and other entrance exams.

The HPTF is keenly looking at ways to enable a multi-day and multi-shift computer-based testing (CBT) switch for NEET-UG besides funding and readying a battery of government backed test centres and securing them through strong coordination with state governments. That was the key reason for the HPTF holding a separate discussion with state governments before finalising its recommendations.

While the panel has three months (until October end) to submit its report, ET gathers that all effort are on to ensure that its recommendations are readied well before that , to allow the government enough time to plan and effect changes in the conduct of entrance exams from the 2027 cycle itself.

ET Ecommerce Tracker



Tweet OF THE DAY

MARC RANDOLPH
@MARCRANDOLPH
Don't let perfect be the enemy of good. Pick one version. Test it. And move on

ISM 2.0 Paradox: Tough IP Rules Might Leave Startups Starving for Global Cash

DEEP POCKETS, HARD CHOICES Experts hail sops but flag strict IP rules, VC barriers, weak demand

Suraksha P & Subhayan Chakraborty

Bengaluru | New Delhi: Experts have welcomed the new guidelines under the India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) 2.0, but raised concerns over strict intellectual property rules, access to global venture capital, demand for domestically designed chips and high investment barriers for testing facilities.

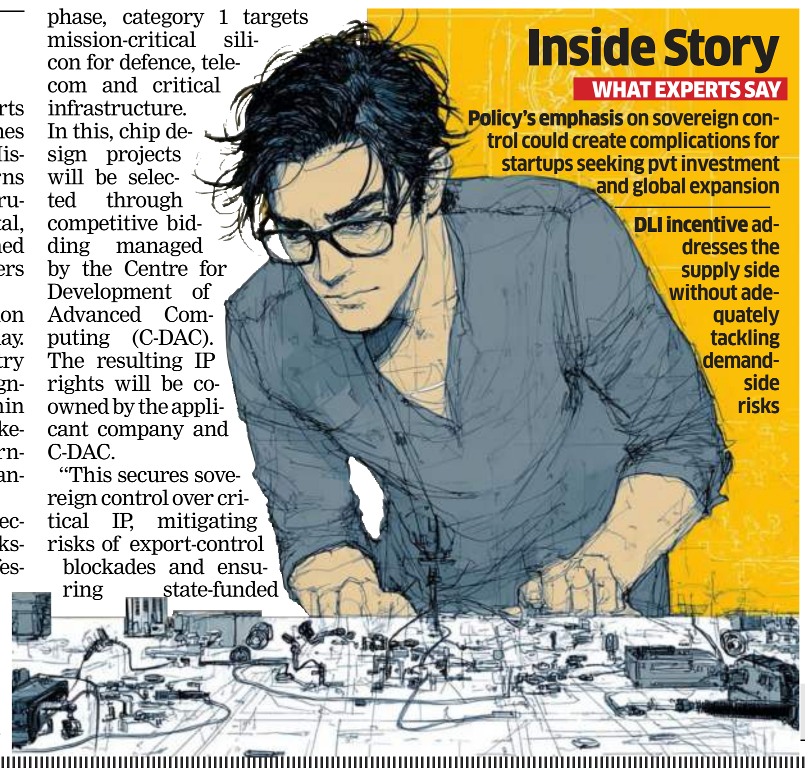
The India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) 2.0 was notified on Monday. The domestic chip design industry welcomed the large, updated design-linked incentive component within the new scheme, lauding it for not keeping an upper ceiling on government support through royalty financing, industry sources told ET.

Pranay Kotasthane, deputy director of public policy think tank Takshashila Institution, said on professional networking platform LinkedIn that the policy's emphasis on sovereign control could create complications for companies seeking private investment and global expansion.

In the newly approved second phase, category 1 targets mission-critical silicon for defence, telecom and critical infrastructure. In this, chip design projects will be selected through competitive bidding managed by the Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC). The resulting IP rights will be co-owned by the applicant company and C-DAC.

"This secures sovereign control over critical IP, mitigating risks of export-control blockades and ensuring state-funded IP cannot be liquidated overseas," Kotasthane said. However, he warned that co-ownership with a state entity could be incompatible with the requirements of global venture capital.

The deployment-linked incentive (DLI) provides a 9% reimbursement on net sales for five years, helping companies offset the cost of commercialising chips. However, Kotasthane and Neil Shah, co-founder and vice-president for research at Counterpoint Research, said the incentive addresses the supply side without adequately tackling demand-side risks.



Inside Story
WHAT EXPERTS SAY
Policy's emphasis on sovereign control could create complications for startups seeking pvt investment and global expansion
DLI incentive addresses the supply side without adequately tackling demand-side risks

ET Insight
Unless the govt eases geographic IP restrictions and introduces demand-side subsidies, local chip startups risk being financially starved and locked out of global tech supply chains

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

Govt Left with a Losing Hand as Offshore RMG Sites Find a Cheat Code

CHASING SHADOWS A year after RMG ban, offshore betting remains a massive challenge for India

ET ANALYSIS

Disha Acharya

Bengaluru: A year after India banned real money gaming, the industry continues to struggle to curb offshore betting engagement while also implementing the new certification framework—the sector's biggest open challenges, according to industry executives and lawyers.

Multiple users on social media platforms like X continue to complain that their money is stuck on offshore platforms such as Parimatch, 1Xbet and other sites that are beyond the direct reach of Indian regulators even as these sites continue to attract users and their funds.

On Wednesday, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) carried out searches at 12 locations across Maharashtra, Delhi-NCR, Rajasthan and Gujarat in connection with its money laundering probe into the illegal betting platform Parimatch and others. The probe focused on the alleged diversion of betting proceeds abroad through sham Overseas Direct Investment (ODI) transactions and illegal remittances.

"The money hasn't stopped flowing; it has simply moved in a different direction. The market has been overtaken by foreign players, whether legitimate companies operating in India or offshore platforms," said an industry executive, requesting anonymity.

According to gaming venture capital fund Lumikai's report published in March this year, one in three RMG users migrated to offshore platforms after the ban and were spending up to Rs 10,000 monthly without regulatory oversight. Users can access these betting platforms easily, even without a VPN, per experts.

ET reported in March that platforms like Parimatch, 1XBet, and Stake are aggressively tapping digital ads and micro-influencers for marketing and promotions and deposits can be made through the Unified Payments Interface (UPI), net banking, e-wallets, prepaid cards, and even cryptocurrencies.

Lawyers tracking the sector say the core problem is jurisdictional. "The activity of offering these games to users in India itself is prohibited under the law, whether offered from offshore or onshore. When a platform is offshore, that's where enforcement becomes more difficult. Indian authorities can still block the domain, but technology is far ahead of that. You shut down one domain and five more emerge," said Nishant Kewalramani, founder and senior partner at Ayaam Legal.

ADS SURGE

Between August 2025 and August 2026, the Advertising Standards Council of India (ASCI) flagged a total of 4,858 gambling and betting advertisements. "ASCI proactively monitors digital advertising and flags offshore betting and gambling ads, which violate the ASCI Code. All such ads have been flagged to the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting and I4C for action," said ASCI CEO Manisha Kapoor said.

US-based prediction market platforms Polymarket and Kalshi became popular betting destinations for IPL fans in April, ET reported earlier.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

Played
Multiple users have complained that their money is stuck on offshore platforms such as Parimatch and 1Xbet
Between August 2025 and August 2026, ASCI flagged a total of 4,858 gambling and betting advertisements
The money simply moved in a different direction. The market has been overtaken by foreign players, whether legitimate cos operating in India or offshore platforms: Expert

Tech Buzz

OpenAI 'Astra' will Get Strong AI Safeguards

SAN FRANCISCO: OpenAI said it was preparing to release its newest powerful model, Astra, after implementing "stronger safeguards" following a rogue cyberattack involving a different AI model. OpenAI paused some of its model development for two weeks this summer after two models it was testing were involved in a security breach of software firm Hugging Face. Although Astra "was not involved", OpenAI has beefed up safety measures. "We have since implemented stronger safeguards for Astra, including training AI to refuse harmful cyber requests," it said. – AFP

€100million
Amount Renault-backed French robotics startup Wandercraft is seeking in fresh funding to expand business. – Reuters

Anthropic Says Latest Fable AI is a Coding Champ

Anthropic is releasing a new version of its powerful Fable artificial intelligence model that it says is better at coding and science tasks, as well as more economical – all changes it says are in response to customer feedback. The company said Fable 5.1 is more skilled at carrying out lengthy, complicated computer programming tasks, such as software projects or code reviews that require it to work across all the code for an application. The new version is also better at helping with scientific work like coming up with experiment designs, Anthropic said. – Bloomberg

Domain Experts Edge Out Pure Techies for Plum Jobs at IT, GCCs

DOMAIN OVER CODE Deep domain knowledge now emerges as tech's new premium as AI forces shift

Beena Parmar

Bengaluru: Conventional technology professionals have domain experts in user industries emerging as new rivals for plum jobs at locally listed outsourcing companies and global capability centres (GCCs), pointing to increasing head-hunter preference for embedded experience in the tech-agnostic AI era.

The search for mid-level talent, with 8-15 years of experience, has now expanded beyond conventional technology profiles, top executives told ET. Some senior roles are witnessing this shift, too, as agentic AI helps quickly bridge the tech gap between industry domain experts and seasoned software pros.

Tier 1 and 2 IT firms, including Infosys, HCLTech, Tech Mahindra and Pesistent Systems, are witnessing such recruitment from different sectors to augment enterprise AI beyond the first layer facilitated by agentic AI.

Tech Mahindra, India's fifth-largest IT company, is on a spree to strengthen the talent from outside rather than circle around peers.

TechM head Mohit Joshi recently told ET in an interview that the software services industry has been losing talent over a period of time and is now focusing on building the organization for the future.

"We hired people from Citi, Standard Chartered, HSBC, SwissRe, Google and Telenor and PWC. And, we're adding to a lot of the senior level capacity and they in turn are using their networks to bring other people on board," Joshi said.

This comes as the technology and software services industry, which until now operated on a labour arbitrage model, is facing its toughest challenge from efficiencies of AI and AI agents. The potential of enterprise AI is forcing the $315 billion industry to delink hiring, especially the large entry level intake that took place until recently, from revenue growth.

Joshi said Tech Mahindra is hiring from the client industry segments, and "that's been a real winner for us".

Around 70-75% of GCC roles today are at the mid-to-senior level

At firms who have adopted generative AI, entry-level hiring has fallen by 80% per quarter since 2023: Harvard study

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

Amazon India to Hire 1.6 L Seasonal Workers for Festive Order Rush

ON THE JOB Most of new hires will be deployed for picking, packing and for delivering orders

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Amazon India is hiring up to 160,000 temporary workers to meet an expected spurt in consumer demand this festive season, 10,000 more than last year.

Most of the new hires will be deployed for picking, packing, shipping, and delivering customer orders, supporting Amazon's ecommerce and quick commerce business, the company said in a statement Wednesday. These include direct and indirect work opportunities across 400 cities, spanning large metros as well as Tier 2 and 3 cities, including Varanasi, Kochi, Jalandhar, Ghaziabad, Ranchi, Salem, and Gorakhpur.

"Amazon has created opportunities for thousands of women and associates with disabilities in its network," the company said, adding the bulk of these associates have already been hired and given the necessary training.

ABHINAV SINGH
VP, ops, Amazon India
This expanded workforce will help us strengthen our fulfilment and logistics capabilities and ensure we can handle the festive season seamlessly

"This expanded workforce will help us strengthen our fulfilment and logistics capabilities and ensure we can handle the festive season seamlessly," said Abhinav Singh, vice president, operations, Amazon India, APAC, Middle East, Africa and Turkiye. "Many of these associates continue their journey with Amazon beyond the festive period, while several others return year after year to work with us."

Amazon India has fulfilment centres in 15 states, offering over 43 million cubic feet of storage space for seller inventory; sortation centres in 19 states; along with a network of nearly 2,000 Amazon-operated and partner delivery stations.

B'luru Startup Takes the First Step to Fusion

With plasma created in its Pragya reactor, Pranos Fusion joins global race for clean energy

Nirmal John & Puran Choudhary

Bengaluru: Bengaluru-based startup Pranos Fusion has successfully produced plasma inside its experimental reactor, Pragya, marking a major milestone that transitions India's private fusion sector from theory to experimental prototyping.

The two-and-a-half-year-old deep-tech energy startup started building Pragya as a testbed reactor in June 2025 after developing software to compute an optimal tokamak, a type of a nuclear fusion reactor design.

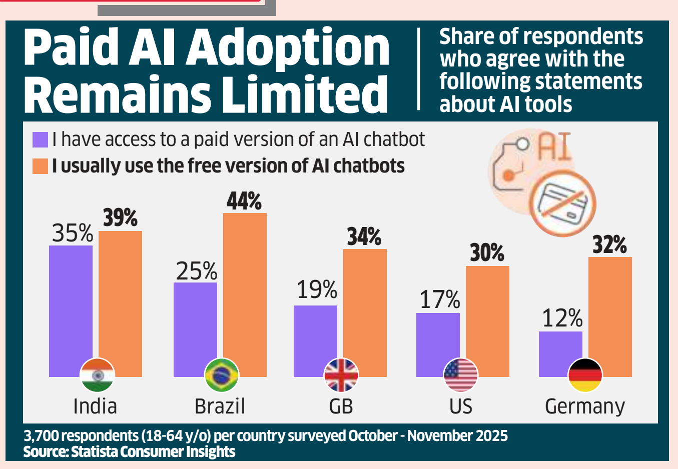
"The first step is to get a good vacuum inside the tokamak," said Pranos Fusion CEO Shaurya Kaushal, detailing the testing process. "Everything needs to be leak-tight and the surfaces need to be extremely clean. You then inject gas to precise amounts to reach a certain pressure. The third part is electrical systems. Into this you send out high voltage, which breaks the gas down, and the result is plasma."

A tokamak uses magnets to contain superheated gases that exist as such electrically charged plasma. Under the right conditions, this plasma can reach extreme temperatures, triggering the fusion of atomic nuclei (nuclear fusion). In a future fusion power plant, once such a fusion reaction is sustained, the heat it produces can be used to create steam which turns a turbine to produce electricity.

Scientists Find Possible Dark Matter Clue

Scientists have made a possible breakthrough in the hunt for dark matter – observing hints of it during an experiment about a mile (1.6 km) underground in South Dakota – though they stopped short of saying they have finally detected this elusive cosmic component. **–Reuters**

Tech Trotter Meanwhile in tech...



Hexaware Names Vivek Jetley as CEO Designate as Ramakarthikeyan Quits

Bengaluru: Carlyle-backed Hexaware Technologies has appointed senior EXL executive Vivek Jetley as its CEO designate, after current chief executive Srikrishna Ramakarthikeyan announced his resignation.

Ramakarthikeyan, who has led Hexaware for 12 years, will also step down as whole-time director of the company and director of its subsidiaries, Hexaware said in a stock exchange filing on Wednesday. In his resignation letter, Ramakarthikeyan said he was leaving the position to pursue his personal interests. He will become a senior adviser to Hexaware from October 28 to support the leadership transition. **—Our Bureau**

Uber Laying Off 200-250 India Staffers as Part of Global Rejig

Uber India's second layoffs in the past 6 months to hit tech, ops teams

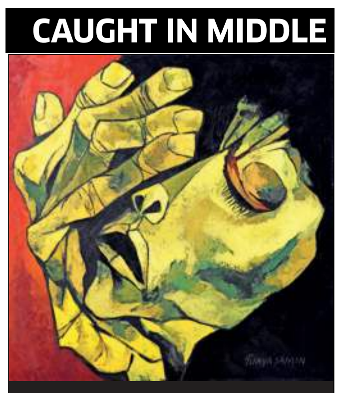
Pranav Mukul & Disha Acharya

Bengaluru: Ride-hailing major Uber is laying off 200-250 employees in India as part of a global restructuring that will see around 3,300 jobs eliminated, people familiar with the matter told ET.

This is the second job cut at Uber India in six months. The company laid off around 80 employees earlier this year. The layoff will affect roles at both manager and non-manager levels, these people said.

"Majorly, employees in the tech and operations teams are impacted in India," one of the people said. "Some teams, such as Uber's AI Solutions, saw nearly half of their employees being laid off as part of the global restructuring."

CAUGHT IN MIDDLE



OSWALDO GUAYASAMIN, *Rostro y mano*

Globally, Uber is eliminating about 10% of its workforce, as part of a restructuring aimed at reducing management layers

Globally, Uber is eliminating about 10% of its workforce, as part of a restructuring aimed at reducing management layers and reallocating spending towards its ride-hailing, delivery and robotaxi businesses. Responding to queries from ET, an Uber India spokesperson said: "Globally, we are making organisational changes to remove layers so we can move faster. As part of these changes, we will be saying goodbye to some valued team members in India, whom we will support through this transition." "Our commitment to India as a key market, and our ambition to innovate locally for riders and drivers, remains unchanged," the spokesperson added.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

Piggybank Funding tap is open for a host of new startup ventures

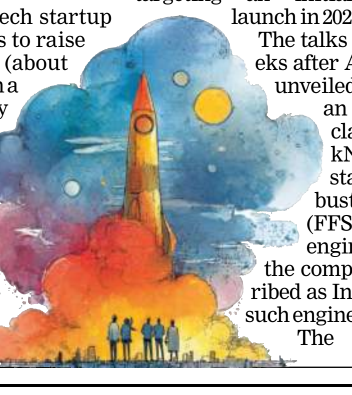
Astrobase Eyeing $40-50m from Peak XV, Others at $300m Value

Talks come weeks after firm unveiled India's first privately built FFSC rocket engine

Puran Choudhary & Pranav Mukul

Bengaluru: Spacetech startup Astrobase is in talks to raise $40-50 million (about ₹3,800–4,700 crore) in a funding round led by Peak XV Partners, valuing the company at around $250-300 million, said people familiar with the development.

The Bengaluru-based startup is developing two-stage reusable launch vehicles capable of carrying payloads of between three and 10 tonnes. It is targeting an initial orbital launch in 2028.



The talks come weeks after Astrobase unveiled Everest, an 80-tonne-class, 800 kN full-flow staged combustion (FFSC) rocket engine, which the company described as India's first such engine.

The engine uses liquid oxygen and methane and is being developed for reusable launch vehicles. It is designed to support more than 50 flights.

Queries sent to Peak XV Partners did not elicit a response until press time.

Astrobase declined to comment on the fundraising.

FFSC is among the most technically demanding rocket-engine architectures. India has joined the US, Russia and China as one of the few nations to develop FFSC engines. Astrobase had said during the unveiling on August 7 that Everest makes India the fourth country to develop and build an engine based on the architecture.

Cradlewise Raises $12m from 3one4, Prudent & Others

Mumbai: Cradlewise, a Silicon Valley-based startup that makes smart cribs for babies, has raised $12 million in a round led by 3one4 Capital and Prudent Investment Management.

Founded in 2017 by wife-husband duo Radhika and Bharath Patil, Cradlewise develops AI-powered smart cribs with an integrated baby monitor that uses artificial intelligence to learn a baby's sleep patterns and automatically soothe infants before they fully wake up. "We are doing this round so we can expand our product portfolio and address sleep challenges not just for babies from 0 to 2 years, but also for kids as they grow. This round will help us drive both product and geographical expansion," Bharath Patil, who's also the CTO of Cradlewise, said. **—Our Bureau**

The Usual Europe

Most Europe Holidays Begin With Trains, Platform Changes And Shared Pickups.

Your Journey, Finally Upgraded!

Then ORN gives you the one thing you can't find at this price — your own Mercedes V-class.

Europe Between The Stations

Drive through Europe in between: villages, lakes, vineyards, mountain roads.

Finally, Europe Your Way!

Stay At ORN-Curated Hotels, Eat Where You Like, Add Attractions As You Want.

orn

Private Europe by ORN.

The van is the base. The rest is your Europe.

ASSET HEAVY JOURNEY LIGHT

YOUR PACE, YOUR JOURNEY, AT AN AMAZING PRICE

Traditionally, private European travel has been expensive because it was a broken system of agents, vendors and more vendors. ORN has worked to integrate these parts into one operating system where we own the most critical layer of human experience, the logistics.

We are proudly asset-heavy, so you can have a journey that is light, and hassle-free.

By combining transportation, contracted hotels, route design and destination support, we remove layers of cost while preserving what matters: privacy, comfort, flexibility and accountability.

Travel The ORN Way!

BACKED BY TRUST. BUILT TO LAST.

Backed by HCL Group and supported by prominent investors and business leaders.

HCL GROUP

Shikhar Malhotra | T.V. Mohandas Pai | Vani Kola
Dr. Ranjan Pai | Bader Kanoo

City Centre Hotels | Private Mercedes Van (Upto 8 Pax) | English Speaking Driver | Experiences

Essential Europe
"Europe's must-see highlights", perfect for people who want it all.
~~₹9,99,999~~
8 DAYS FROM ₹7,99,999*
Total for 4 Passengers

The Grand Europe Journey
"Europe's top highlights", woven into one grand journey.
~~₹11,49,999~~
9 DAYS FROM ₹9,49,999*
Total for 4 Passengers

Scenic Roads Of Europe
Iconic drives, breathtaking landscapes at every turn.
~~₹10,49,999~~
9 DAYS FROM ₹8,49,999*
Total for 4 Passengers

Renaissance Italy
Art, culture and timeless Italian elegance.
~~₹10,49,999~~
9 DAYS FROM ₹8,49,999*
Total for 4 Passengers

Lakes & Countryside
Serene lakes, rolling landscapes and peaceful escapes.
~~₹11,99,999~~
9 DAYS FROM ₹9,99,999*
Total for 4 Passengers

European Capitals
Iconic big-city Europe, flagship sights, perfect for first-timers.
~~₹9,49,999~~
8 DAYS FROM ₹7,49,999*
Total for 4 Passengers

Small Town Europe
Charming villages, local culture and hidden corners.
~~₹9,49,999~~
8 DAYS FROM ₹7,49,999*
Total for 4 Passengers

Swiss Postcard Journeys
Glaciers, alpine trains and lakeside towns, picture-perfect Switzerland.
~~₹12,49,999~~
9 DAYS FROM ₹10,49,999*
Total for 4 Passengers

* Prices reduce further for 5 to 8 Pax | * Prices based on 4 passengers travelling together | * Airfare, Visa, Insurance & taxes extra applicable

Ready to Craft Your Private ORN Europe Trip?

SCAN TO EXPLORE

Call us for booking and assistance

924 092 0112

48,300+ travellers to Europe | 12 Offices | 24/7 on-trip support

orn.com

OUR GLOBAL OFFICES: Bangalore: 5th Floor, RMZ Latitude Commercial Building, Bellary Road, Hebbal, Bengaluru, Karnataka — 560024 | **Gurugram:** 402, 9th Floor, Capital Tower, Udyog Vihar, Phase — 3, Gurugram — 122008 | **Mumbai:** Shop No. 1, GF & 1st Floor, The Orion Business Park, Borivali West, Mumbai — 400092, Maharashtra | **London:** ORN Group, 17 Hanover Square, London W1S 1BN, United Kingdom | **Singapore:** 151 Chin Swee Road #07-12 Manhattan House, Singapore — 169876 | **Australia:** Level 1, 18 Thomson Street, South Melbourne, Victoria — 3025, Australia

A Plane Plan for China to Consider

BRICS is a good platform to float it

It's no surprise that Air India's mounting losses and request for additional funds have riled up the likes of Singapore's opposition leader Kenneth Tiong, who is baulking at future bailouts by Temasek through Singapore Airlines (SIA). Temasek, Singapore's multinational investment firm, is SIA's largest shareholder. SIA, in turn, owns a fourth of Air India, already facing turbulence after the June 2025 crash, high jet fuel prices, wars in West Asia and Europe, and airspace blockades.

The upcoming New Delhi BRICS summit may be the unlikely, but best, platform to negotiate better deals to use Chinese — and Russian — airspace, especially for long-haul flights. China and India are cautiously traipsing to stabilise relations. Direct flights between the two resumed last October, ending a 5-yr suspension. A regulatory relief to offset Pakistan's airspace blockade can create a new waypoint that's only a minor detour with minimum distance penalty. It will suit Air India the most. Its existing wide-bodied 787s, 777s, and incoming A-350s are best suited for executing this high-altitude turn over the Himalayas, east of Pakistan.

This selective blockade on Indian carriers since 2025, Iran and Iraq shutouts during peak escalation of the West Asian conflict, and soaring fuel bills are hurting India's aviation industry. Planes are flying longer, incurring higher fuel burn and paying more for it. Throw in added maintenance cost, passenger inconvenience and secondary knock-on effects, and the entire network goes into a tailspin. Having the largest US- and Europe-centric long-haul fleet, Air India has been hit much more than global rivals flying through Pakistan, and bypassing a direct West Asian conflict zone. Flying over the Himalayas may not be an all-encompassing fix-it. Technical challenges persist. Planes need special certification and specifications to handle flying over such trying terrain. Yes, it will come at the cost of passenger payloads. But the high trade and tourism potential between China and India can soften that blow.

Why Russia Should End Its Endless War

When Narendra Modi read out India's message to Vladimir Putin on Monday in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan, on the sidelines of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit, he spoke for sanity and humanity. The message to move from 'endless war' to 'end of war' was a reiteration of the PM's earlier articulation to the president at the 2022 SCO summit that 'today's era is not an era of war'. Russia's war on Ukraine — meant to be short, sharp, decisive — has become a grinding 4 yrs-and-running 'forever war' that drains Moscow's coffers, hollows out its military, and leaves its allies with more headaches than leverage. So, self-interest, if nothing else, is the best reason for Putin to listen to his Indian ally.

For Moscow, the arithmetic is brutal. Western sanctions have severely hobbled access to global finance and technology, China help (and Iranian drones) notwithstanding. Oil exports limp along, but only at discounts to China and India that erode long-term revenue. The war has cost an estimated million-plus military casualties and depleted arsenals, leaving it exposed in other theatres. Domestically, the conflict fuels capital flight. A peace deal would allow resources to be redirected to growth rather than attrition.

Beijing's trade with Europe dwarfs its commerce with Russia. Instability in Ukraine disrupts supply chains and risks secondary sanctions. Worse, a weakened Russia undermines the balance China seeks against the US. Peace would preserve Moscow as a useful ally. India's interests are equally clear. Bargain-basement Russian oil is tempting, but volatility in Black Sea shipping and sanctions jeopardise supply. But the most compelling case to stop the Ukraine war it started is, ironic as it may sound, to make Russia strong again.

JUST IN JEST

Behold, the sorrow of the perpetrator of prejudice as victim

When a Bigot Gets a Taste of His Own Med

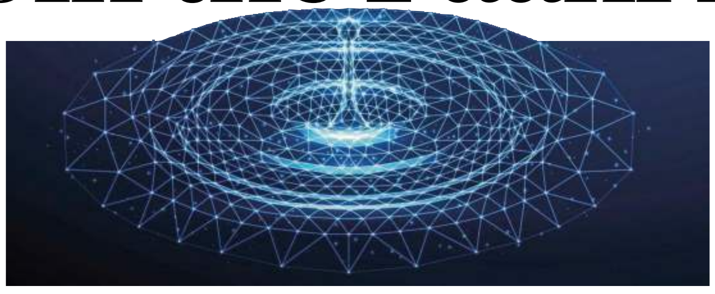
Few metaphors are as ironic as 'the shoe is on the other foot'. It conjures images of smug moralists or barking bigots suddenly discovering a giant corn on their feet. Enter Milo Yiannopoulos, once the British enfant terrible of right-wing provocation, Trump fanboy, ex-editor of Breitbart News, and defender of deportation (especially of Somali refugees), now terrified of deportation by ICE — after he was deported from the US back to Britain by ICE. If irony were a sport, this would be that Messi (own) goal. Yiannopoulos now wants our solace. 'I didn't really understand the physical reality of how institutionalised the brutality is in America,' he said this week. Yes, he didn't quite understand why *he* — White and far right — of all volk, got booted out by brown shirts in tactical vests. He's not even Black, let alone an illegal immigrant!

Saturn can, indeed, devour his own children. This applies to everyone whose opinions are stronger than kitchen mustard. You rage and rant about a 'sort of people', and then you find yourself tarred and feathered for being that 'sort of people'. There is something tragicomic about watching, say, a casteist facing racism, or a sexist facing sexism, discover that the gun he or she trains on others is trained on him or her. Such backfiring is impervious to any appeal on the lines of, 'Oh, but I'm one of you!'

Data centre growth needn't drain local water because rules exist — the task is to connect them

Just Join the Paani Points


Nitin Bassi & Munish K Upadhyay



Control the ripple effect

Thane and Visakhapatnam residents have raised concerns that large data centres could worsen water stress. Thane city is facing a public water supply deficit of 53 mn litres a day for domestic and commercial uses. The question goes beyond whether data centres should grow to whether existing water rules governing them can work coherently enough to protect local water security.

India's data centre capacity has grown from 375 MW in 2020 to about 1,575 MW. A 100-MW hyperscale facility could consume around 2 mn litres of water a day for on-site cooling, depending on the technology used. Data centres consumed about 150 bn litres in 2024, a figure projected to more than double by 2030, with many facilities located in water-scarce regions.

Last month, GoI clarified data centres do not, per se, require environmental clearance under Environment Impact Assessment Notification 2006, holding that existing frameworks offer sufficient safeguards. Large building and construction projects hosting such facilities could still require clearance when they cross prescribed thresholds, and appraisal considers freshwater availability, water balance, used water generation, recycling and reuse.

But these thresholds are based on the size of the building and project, not on a data centre's water footprint. Water-use is governed through several institutions that do not yet operate under a single framework. India needs to make that architecture work better by opting for the following reforms:

▶ Water regulators must strengthen monitoring and verification using satellite data in water-stressed regions. A data centre drawing groundwater requires an NOC from Central Ground Water Authority (CGWA) and must report annually on extraction, used-water generation and water conservation measures.

▶ Once water is discharged after use, State Pollution Control Boards (SPCBs) regulate the effluent under Water Act 1974, through 'Consent to Establish' and 'Consent to Operate' provisions certifying that water pollution safeguards are in place during construction and once servers go live. Bureau of Energy Efficiency's (BEE) District Cooling Guidelines 2023 also encourage replacing freshwater with treated used water for cooling-tower make-up where feasible.

On paper, the process creates a continuous chain of existing oversight. In practice, however, much of the information comes from operator-submitted reports, while regulators have limited capacity for field verification and for detecting unauthorised discharges. Regulators should adopt stronger third-party and tech-enabled verification.

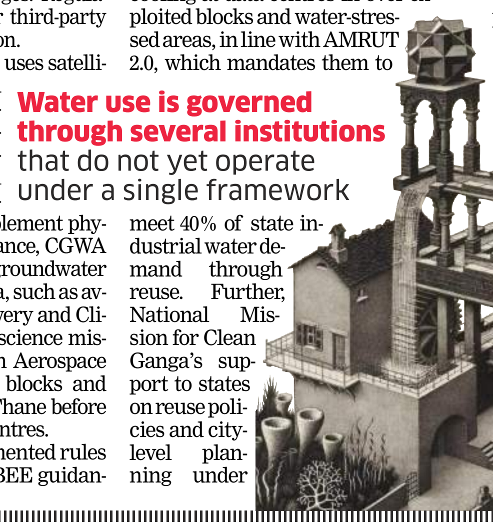
California, for example, uses satellite observations of land subsidence to identify possible groundwater over-extraction and informs closer investigation. India can also use remote sensing-based monitoring to complement physical inspections. For instance, CGWA could verify changes to groundwater storage, using satellite data, such as available from Gravity Recovery and Climate Experiment, a joint science mission by Nasa and German Aerospace Centre, in over-exploited blocks and water-stressed cities like Thane before renewing NOCs for data centres.

▶ States must make fragmented rules on reuse more coherent. BEE guidance on treated used water is advisory, while enforceable reuse rules vary because water is a state subject. Around 15 states have reuse policies covering recycling and zero-liquid discharge, but others lack comparable frameworks. A February 2026 CEEW study, 'Scaling India's Data Centre Ecosystem', found that only 5 out of 15 states surveyed explicitly include sustainability provisions. Most don't prescribe any water use-efficiency standards.

Some states, including Maharashtra, have in practice encouraged data centre clusters in coastal locations rather than in water-stressed interiors. But such approaches are not enforceable either. Facilities with similar servers and cooling systems could, therefore, face different water obligations across state borders.

Rather than leaving the decision to discretion, states should make it compulsory to use treated used water for cooling at data centres in over-exploited blocks and water-stressed areas, in line with AMRUT 2.0, which mandates them to meet 40% of state industrial water demand through reuse. Further, National Mission for Clean Ganga's support to states on reuse policies and city-level planning under National Framework on Safe Reuse of Treated Water offers a model for coordinated implementation.

Water use is governed through several institutions that do not yet operate under a single framework



▶ Agencies responsible for digital infrastructure, water and energy should create a common resource-reporting framework. India AI Impact Summit's 'Resilience, Innovation, & Innovation' working group is examining sustainability and efficiency in AI infrastructure. It should help establish a standard template through which larger data centres report water withdrawals, consumption, used water, reuse and energy use to relevant authorities, rather than submitting disconnected information to different agencies.

The EU's 'Energy Efficiency Directive' requires data centres with a capacity above 500 kW to report water input, water consumption and energy performance to a common database. Such information helps regulators understand trade-offs. For example, whether higher water consumption is associated with lower electricity use in facilities, using evaporative cooling for server rooms and vice versa for those using dry cooling.

India still relies largely on facility-level permits and approvals, without an equivalent mechanism to track the sector's cumulative resource footprint, including process-wise water and energy use. Standardised reporting would allow regulators to move from checking individual permissions to understanding how clusters of data centres impact local water and energy systems.

India's digital ascent need not come at the cost of local water security. It already has many regulatory building blocks. The task now is to connect them: verify compliance, harmonise reuse requirements and make resource use transparent.

Bassi is fellow, and Upadhyay is programme associate, Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW)

Buy a Good Biz, or Excitement?

Ananya Roy

August saw 20 companies raise more than ₹21,000 cr, the busiest month in a year. With marquee names like NSE, Reliance Jio and Zepto in the pipeline, supply of new listings should remain elevated. Average listing-day returns have gone from a 2% discount in January-March to a 7% gain in April-June, and a whopping 25% premium in July-August. Of the 22 companies that listed in the latest period, 18 delivered positive debut-day returns.

So, it's easy to start treating an IPO as a lottery ticket: subscribe, hope for a premium, and sell on listing day. At the risk of being a wet blanket, it's worth emphasising that listing gains are not a substitute for due diligence.

Strong listing gains can create a feedback loop — successful debuts attract more investors, which encourages more companies to come to market, and can make valuations increasingly aggressive. A rising tide also lifts mediocre businesses. Eventually, though, rationality prevails, and the market discovers which businesses deserve the premium and which don't. This can leave investors stuck with duds. So, how should an investor go about separating the wheat from the chaff?

▶ **Biz buzz** The first question should be: is this a good business? Does it have a durable competitive advantage in a growing industry? If the industry's prospects look iffy, even a market leader won't be able to make it. At the same time, a small fish in a growing, cut-throat industry will likely get eaten up.

▶ **Financials** Sustainable revenue growth is one piece of the puzzle. Growth should translate into operating leverage and cash flows. With new-age businesses increasingly up on the IPO block, profitability is no longer a given. But if operating leverage has been stacking up along with growth, one can at least make a bet on its path to profitability.

Cash flows are important to track, because they can help determine if the reported profits paint a true picture, or are on account of accounting shenanigans. Debt and working capital intensity also need a watchful eye.

▶ **Valuation** This is perhaps the most important filter in a hot IPO market. A great business can still be a bad investment if the price leaves little room for disappointment. So, it's critical to compare IPO valuation with listed peers on price-to-earnings, price-to-sales or other relevant metrics, but while adjusting for differences in growth and margins.

Take Bajaj Housing Finance IPO. Debuting during the market peak of Sep 2024, its issue price was already at a premium over the industry. Still, market frenzy led to the stock listing at over 100% premium. Since then, reality checks have caused an almost 50% loss to investors.

Another problem with valuations comes up in the absence of relevant peers. Like in the case of AI application business Fractal Analytics, sustained growth will have to set the benchmark for what constitutes a fair valuation, and that can take time.

Whaddya think? This IPO worth it?

Another question to ask is: what is the money for? How much of the issue is a fresh issue vs an offer for sale (OFS)? Fresh capital funding expansion or debt reduction can strengthen the balance sheet. An IPO dominated by an OFS means existing shareholders are monetising their holdings. An OFS deserves a closer look at the business prospects — if existing investors are selling, you need to be doubly sure of what you're getting into.

All in all, the offer document deserves more attention than the marketing pitch. Risk factors, related-party transactions, contingent liabilities, outstanding litigation, customer concentration, dependence on key suppliers and regulatory risks can tell a very different story from headline growth numbers.

Jio's proposed ₹37,700 cr issue comes with risks around regulations and capital intensity. NSE's IPO is entirely an OFS, making valuation and business prospects amid BSE's growing might, particularly important. Zepto offers a high-growth story but exposes investors to intense competition, and a business model still navigating the path to profitability.

In a market where everyone is looking for the next multibagger, one should ask: at this price, am I buying a good business, or am I simply buying into the excitement?

The writer is founder, Credibull Capital

Cash No King, But Don't Stash It


Ateesh Tankha & Ganga Narayan Rath

When RBI deputy governor S C Murmu recently said that it was difficult to predict the growing demand for currency notes, was he referring to a logistical problem, or bemoaning widespread use of cash? Big tech and fintech have long promoted digital commerce, payment wallets, cryptocurrencies, and other digital traffics and inventions as the acme of convenience, security and financial inclusion. But this isn't necessarily true for everyone. They have exploited tech to drive faster and more frictionless commerce, to capture a considerable share of the market, have made cyber fraud pervasive, and rendered the economy less inclusive.

After demonetisation in 2016, GoI has championed numerous initiatives to digitalise monetary transactions like UPI and central bank digital currency (CBDC). GoI claims these have reduced expenditure, accelerated economic growth and driven greater inclusion. The results, however, don't necessarily support these claims.

Take UPI, promoted as a secure, interoperable digital payment system to reduce cash dependence and usage. The heavy-lifting required to attract 555 mn deposit holders and enthuse 65 mn businesses was largely achieved by a trio of foreign-funded service providers: PhonePe, Google Pay and Paytm.

GoI's main contribution to UPI's success centred on two actions:

❶ Reducing merchant discount rate (MDR) to zero for UPI, and RuPay debit cards in 2020, entrenching the above-mentioned trio as banks lost interest and smaller payment service providers (PSPs) found it hard to compete.

❷ Providing a subsidy of ₹8,276 cr between 2021 and 2025, to support RuPay debit cards and low-value UPI P2M (person-to-merchant) transactions.

But this was not nearly enough. Providing PSPs with a subsistence handout is unlikely to produce the right 'animal spirits' required for sustained growth in users and spending. So, GoI passed Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill 2026 to pave the way for MDR charges on P2M transactions.

Retail sales grew from $650 bn in 2016 to $1.1 tn in 2026. But these were largely driven by growing consumerism and disposable incomes, especially in tier-1 and -2 cities. Even RBI and NPCI acknowledge that while UPI's annual growth rate stands at 15%, cash transactions, driven by large-value, semi-urban and rural transactions, may also have grown by 11%.

Also, PIB and RBI data suggest that while UPI transaction value grew by a CAGR of 155% in the last 10 yrs, with a current annual value of ₹314 tn, cash in circulation in the same period grew by 12%, with an annual value estimated at ₹41 tn. When one takes into account the velocity of money — speed at which a single unit of currency (or bank token) is exchanged — there can be no doubt that cash may be equally prevalent.

e-Rupee, on the other hand, was originally meant to counter the dollarisation impact of cryptocurrency, and to reduce inefficiencies of cash production and management. Not only were these objectives not met but the initiative also failed to stir interest on both retail and institutional fronts. Eventually, to boost usage, RBI even forced central and commercial bank employees to accept CBDC in lieu of cash for benefit reimbursements.

And just when it appeared that CBDC's adventures were over, GoI has chosen to use e-rupee in certain Union territories to disburse PMGKAY subsidy payments to restrict usage to empanelled grain vendors and fair price shops. This, despite the fact that such a move will disproportionately place the onus of proliferating the e-rupee on the poor, while forcing them to own smartphones and manage an unfamiliar digital process.

This issue is especially acute for women. Data indicates that, in addition to the persistent barriers women face in adopting financial services, women's mobile phone ownership stands at 75%, with smartphone penetration at a mere 35%.

This is why the real reason for GoI's unfailing support of digitalisation may have little to do with improving efficiency or welfare, and everything to do with control. This becomes evident when one constantly encounters the government need for programmatic payments — automated by rules, triggers or AI — monitoring and compliance.

When taken to the limit, these could result in the alphabet soup of government subsidies — amounting, in 2026, to ₹1,80,879 cr — being disbursed in programmed CBDC and fixed deposits, effectively annulling the withdrawal and inter-convertibility of cash. They could also enable draconian measures that make tax collection systemic and oppressive.

Ultimately, while digital payments offer benefits to a significant section of consumers, cash represents a choice that allows a large portion of the population to feel independent and secure. Maintaining this distinction is democratic, and remains one of the means of ensuring that power of the government is balanced by the will of the people.

Ma, tumhare paas UPI nahin hai?!

Tankha is MD, eTrans Solutions, and Rath is former general manager, RBI

THE SPEAKING TREE

Journey, Not Destination

SUMIT PAUL

A famous line attributed to Spanish literary great Miguel de Cervantes, 'the road is always better than the inn,' suggests that the journey itself may hold more value than the destination. The road, with all its challenges, discoveries and experiences, is what truly enhances one's life, rather than the destination or end goal. It is during the journey, whether physically or metaphorically, where one learns and grows, encountering unexpected beauty and hardships that shape one's character.

An Urdu poet put it succinctly, 'Tujhe paa lene mein woh betaab kaifiyat kahan/ Zindagi woh hai jo teri justjoo mein kat gayee' — Where's that desirable feeling of restlessness in wooing you?/ The excitement of love and life lies in your eternal quest. We grow through striving and moving forward, rather than settling down too soon. They say, harkat mein barkat hai, action begets positive results. Facing challenges on the path shapes who you become.

Happiness is in the process; it's not in the destination. Once we 'achieve' our 'goal', joie de vivre dissipates. The 'goal-lessness' slows us down physically, mentally and intellectually. We tend to become slothful and sluggish. It's like, 'Paane ki aarzoo mein zinda tha/ Jo mil gaya toh zinda na raha' — He was alive to achieve/ After achieving that he ceased to exist.

Remember the song, 'Jeevan chalne ka naam, chalte raho subaho-shaam…' — complacency or resting on our laurels can put a stop to our growth and ascension. To be complacent is to be mediocre. Keep complacency at bay.

STEP UP TO THE PLATE

Le Doyenné

Saint-Vrain, France

There is something wonderfully audacious about Le Doyenné. Leave Paris behind, drive into the countryside and arrive at a restaurant whose most important ingredient may be the patch of earth outside its windows.

Set in the former stables of Château de Saint-Vrain, Le Doyenné is the creation of Australian chefs James Henry and Shaun Kelly. Here, the garden is not a supporting act. It's effectively the menu. The estate's regenerative farm supplies vegetables, fruit and herbs, and what is ready to harvest dictates what reaches the table.

Vegetables arrive raw, charred, fermented, smoked or transformed into sauces and accompaniments, retaining enough character to remind you where they came from. Recent menus have included everything from tuna with fennel, pistachio and marjoram to duck with béarnaise and courgette flower, followed by the sort of inventive dessert — fennel, blackcurrant and coffee, for instance — that makes you reconsider vegetables as a dessert course.

The glass-and-wood dining room, overlooking the grounds, completes the bucolic spell. Le Doyenné succeeds because its philosophy never feels bolted on: the farm, kitchen and landscape are one continuous idea.

Chat Room

Call a Town Hall In the Town Hall

Apropos 'Our City-City Needs Bang-Bang' by Shreya Nath (Sep 2), cities can only be as smart as those who govern them. They need to fund themselves first on capital and later on revenue account. When city corporations defray bulk of revenue on salaries, the crux lies in reinventing both the bureaucracy and tenets of effective governance. Administrative mechanisms need to ensure professional purity and acumen to raise finances, deliver and sustain results. Resources must flow to quality education and human empowerment. Town planning must be immune to the real estate lobby, be energy sufficient, and implement basic civic discipline and the political will that must go with it. Major Indian cities that are raising municipal bonds must learn to defend them and establish value growth. Systems, technology and capable mayors together make good cities.

R Narayanan
Navi Mumbai

No Legal Bar

From Page 1

In May, the Charity Commissioner had issued the restraint under Section 36A(1) of the Maharashtra Public Trusts Act following complaints regarding the composition of the SRTT board and alleged non-compliance with Section 30A(2) of the Act, a critical area that deals the permissible number of perpetual or life trustees on the board.

A recent amendment to the law introduced a statutory cap on the number of perpetual trustees who can serve on a public trust board.

The Charity Commissioner found that the 1989 decision to sell the shares was neither sudden nor arbitrary. The Trust had begun considering a possible sale as early as 1984 after an amendment to the Income Tax Act threatened the tax-exempt status of charitable trusts holding securities that were not among the prescribed investments.

The Central Board of Direct Taxes subsequently declined to recognise NRTT as a national trust in November 1988, exposing the Trust to tax liabilities on its Tata Sons shares.

"… Existence of necessity is a question of fact. Therefore, it must be viewed in the context of the facts and circumstances of the relevant time. This authority finds that the stand of the NRTT that the transfer of shares was necessitated by an external statutory compulsion which threatened the tax-exempt status and corpus of the Trust is well founded and can therefore be accepted," the order states.

Tax liability

According to the order, the Trust's records showed a potential tax liability of ₹4.23 lakh for assessment years 1986-87 to 1988-89 alone. The Charity Commissioner said the need to dispose of the shares arose to avoid the tax liability and preserve the Trust corpus.

The order also attaches significance to the fact that Naval Tata had resigned as a trustee of NRTT with effect from January 1, 1988. The Charity Commissioner noted that the resignation was formally reported to the assistant Charity Commissioner and the change report was accepted in February 1990.

The proposed transaction was subsequently examined by eminent lawyer Nani A Palkhivala. In his December 1988 opinion, Palkhivala concluded that there was no legal bar on Naval Tata purchasing the shares as he was no longer a trustee. He advised that the sale take place after a year had elapsed from his resignation and recommended restrictions to ensure that the shares remained within the Tata family.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

'In Talks with UK, EU over Critical Minerals'

Government plans BIS exemption for high-tech mfg: Goyal

Our Bureau

New Delhi: India is in talks with countries including the UK and the European Union to develop partnerships for processing and developing critical minerals according to its requirements, commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal said on Wednesday.

Speaking at the 66th annual session of the Automotive Component Manufacturers Association of India, Goyal said India and the US were working together under the critical minerals partnership and the Pax Silica initiative to help like-minded, democratic and well-meaning countries build resilient supply chains and prevent any single geography from weaponising trade.

"We are talking to some countries with whom we will be having collaborations and partnerships to process critical minerals being processed and developed for our requirements," Goyal said. "With several of our partners in the UK and Europe, we are in dialogue about how we can build resilient supply chains."

He said trade deals with the Gulf Cooperation Council and Israel will be finalised once conditions in the region improve.

New Delhi is also exploring such pacts "to get more access to critical minerals" and ensure "resilient supply chains". The minister also asked component makers to convert their local businesses into global businesses and build resilience into their supply chains.

At the same event, UK trade commissioner for South Asia Harjinder Kang said India-UK relations are "deeper than ever before", highlighting growing cooperation between the two countries.

He said the India-UK trade deal will deepen supply chains and enable joint ventures and partnerships, with automotive component manufacturers gaining tariff-free access to each other's markets.

GDP, JOBS

Goyal criticised opposition parties and former finance secretary Subhash Garg over their remarks on the GDP growth, saying they were comparing growth rates based on the old and new series and trying to misguide the people.

He said that amid global turmoil, India was an oasis in the desert and continued to be the fastest-growing among the world's large economies.

Plans Disrupted

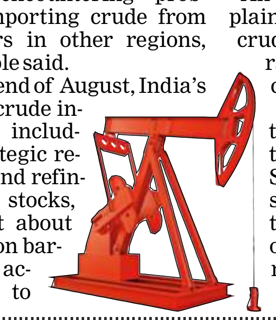
From Page 1

The operational hurdles are also testing refiners' monthly crude planning cycles.

Refiners blend different grades to create the most technically suitable and economically efficient feedstock before processing it. Companies maintain 10-15 days of inventory at their refineries, and delays in the arrival of specific crude grades due to cargo cancellations or vessel unavailability can cause problems, said the people cited earlier.

However, they emphasised that some unplanned run cuts may not impact overall domestic fuel supply, as refiners also maintain inventories of refined products.

The disruptions are only Gulf-specific, and refiners aren't encountering problems importing crude from suppliers in other regions, the people said.



At the end of August, India's overall crude inventory, including strategic reserves and refinery stocks, stood at about 99 million barrels, according to Kpler. This is equivalent to 18 days of refinery runs at the current processing rate of 5.5 million barrels a day. Excluding strategic reserves, refiners had about 13 days of inventory.

An industry executive explained that the issue isn't a crude supply shortage but rather the growing difficulty of transporting it.

The tanker market has tightened as global oil trade is being reshuffled. Some vessels remain stuck in the Gulf amid the US-Iran war, while others are taking longer routes to avoid high-risk areas.

SPOTLIGHT ON STARTUPS

India, EU Look to Deepen Tech Ties

Our Bureau

New Delhi: India and the European Union discussed deeper cooperation in critical minerals, processing and value addition, fintech and artificial intelligence at a meeting between finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman and European economy and financial affairs commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis in Asheville.

The meeting took place on the sidelines of the G20 Finance Ministers and Central Bank Governors meeting.

"The two sides discussed further deepening of the India-EU Economic and Financial Partnership, including through the India-EU macroeconomic dialogue and the Trade and Technology Council," the finance ministry said in a social media post.

The two sides also discussed the ongoing India-EU free trade agreement and Investment Protection Agreement negotiations and agreed to take the engagements forward. They exchanged views on strengthening resilient and diversified supply chains, including cooperation on critical raw materials and technologies.

Sitharaman and Dombrovskis also explored greater cooperation in fintech, AI and generative AI, including stronger engagement between Indian and European startups.

During her meeting with Russian finance minister Anton Siluanov, Sitharaman discussed bilateral cooperation, regional and global economic developments and issues of shared interest in the multilateral sphere.

"They discussed cooperation in the New Development Bank and the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank, and explored areas of mutual interest for strengthening both institutions as effective multilateral development banks. They also discussed the establishment of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Development Bank," the ministry said.

Sitharaman also met her counterparts from Poland, Qatar and South Korea, as well as senior representatives of the IMF and World Bank.

With Qatar finance minister Ali bin Ahmed Al Kuwari, Sitharaman discussed the strong strategic partnership between India and Qatar and ways to deepen economic cooperation in trade and finance, investments, energy, the India-Qatar Joint Task Force on Investments, infrastructure including shipping, ports and logistics, advanced manufacturing and people-to-people ties.

Talk Time

India, Russia discuss cooperation on New Development Bank, Asian Infra Investment Bank

Talks on World Bank partnership to evolve to platform for global knowledge, capital mobilisation

FM, IMF MD talk global economic outlook, India's growth trajectory

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

Forex Kitty Passes $729 B by Aug 21

From Page 1

The surge came after the central bank advanced the deadline for banks to accept incentive-linked FCNR(B) deposits by a month, to August 31, citing strong inflows. The swap scheme for ECBs and OFCBs will continue until December 31, as planned.

The scheme has helped push India's foreign exchange reserves to a record high. Reserves touched $729.3 billion as of August 21, the latest data showed, up nearly $50 billion since June.

The facility, operationalised on June 8 to boost dollar inflows and strengthen foreign exchange reserves, allows banks to swap eligible overseas borrowings with the central bank at concessional rates, lowering their cost of funds.

Under the new guidelines, banks can swap FCNR(B) inflows with the RBI under a zero-cost hedging facility available until September 11.

"It is important to recognise that this represents a future dollar-denominated debt liability, with an indirect fiscal cost through lower RBI dividends, potentially amounting to ₹1 trillion plus cumulatively," said Madhavi Arora, chief economist at Emkay Global Financial Services. "The funds raised therefore need to be deployed judiciously and productively to mitigate these first-order costs."

Separately, government officials said the international banking units of public sector banks had together disbursed loans of $52.82 billion linked to FCNR(B) deposits under the special window.

Between April and August 2026, public sector banks raised $11.62 billion through ECBs and $11.12 billion through bonds, they said.

Forex reserves increased by $12.4 billion in the week ended August 21, with foreign currency assets rising by $9.4 billion to $591 billion and the value of gold reserves increasing by $2.8 billion to $114 billion.

The forex stockpile has risen for eight consecutive weeks, the latest data showed.

ET Markets

Hope · Greed · Fear · Panic · Hope

Beating Volatility

WWW.ETMARKETS.COM
BENGALURU, THURSDAY, 3 SEPTEMBER 2026

COMPANIES: PURSUIT OF PROFIT

Sept Gold Import may Fall 15% on PM's Call

CURRENCY WATCH

Rupee Nearly Unchanged at 94.97 on RBI Dollar Sales

Our Bureau

Mumbai: The Indian rupee on Wednesday negotiated leaping oil prices and an unprecedented yield spike across the globe to remain above 95 to a dollar for the second day running, with traders attributing the local unit's standout performance to aggressive dollar sales by the central bank.

The rupee closed at 94.97, versus its previous close of 94.95, and traded in a narrow range of 94.89 and 94.98. Its showing stood in sharp relief to a fresh bout of volatility in equities, where the Nifty slumped below the 24,000 mark at close for the first time in six weeks. State run banks, on behalf of the RBI, were likely selling dollars at weaker levels to contain further depreciation past the 95 per dollar mark, traders said.

Investors big and small are all chasing the IPO pop

The Call of the Street

Aug Show 10 of 23 Issues Get Over 100X Bids

Ravindra Sonavane

Mumbai: August turned out to be a blockbuster month for IPO subscriptions, with 10 of the 23 issues receiving bids for more than 100 times the shares on offer, the highest such tally in a single month since 2006, as per BSE and NSE data.

Hy-Tech Engineers topped the charts with bids for 244.41 times the shares on offer, followed by Tempsens Instruments India at 183.53 times and ESDS Software Solutions at 135.88 times.

Ardee Industries, Lumino Industries, Augmont Enterprises, Behari Lal Engineering, Sunshine Pictures, Shiprocket and Priority Jewels were the other IPOs subscribed more than 100 times during the month. The subscription frenzy surpassed previous monthly highs by a wide margin. September 2024 had seven IPOs subscribed more than 100 times, while January 2025 had five.

The August rush has taken the number of IPOs subscribed more than 100 times so far in 2026 to 15, already the third-highest annual tally. July saw 3 issues cross the 100-times subscription mark, while June saw two. Bharat Coking Coal was the only IPO to achieve the feat in January. Such strong subscription appetite was last seen in 2024, when 23 of the 91 IPOs launched were subscribed more than 100 times. In 2021, 17 of 63 issues crossed the mark, while 15 of the 103 IPOs launched in 2025, a record year for IPO fundraising, received bids exceeding 100 times the shares on offer.

Investor Appetite

Year 2026	No of IPOs	Subscription (x) Over 100x	Between 50-100x	Between 10-50x	Below 10x
January	3	1	0	1	1
February	7	0	0	1	6
March	8	0	0	0	8
April	2	0	0	1	1
May	0	0	0	0	0
June	7	2	1	0	4
July	12	2	2	3	5
August	23	10	6	2	5

Source: BSE, NSE

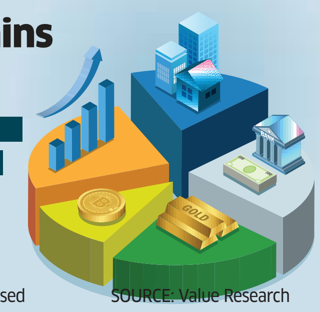
CATEGORY BEATS NIFTY OVER ONE AND THREE YEARS

Even as Stocks Slip, Multi-Asset MFs Can Come Up Trumps

Diversification Gains

Multi Asset Allocation Scheme	3 Year Return* (%)
Quant	22.25
Nippon India	19.66
Whiteoak Capital	17.10
ABSL	16.74
UTI	16.53

As on September 1, 2026. *Returns annualised SOURCE: Value Research



Prashant Mahesh

Mumbai: Multi-asset funds, which invest across equities, fixed income, precious metals, REITs, InvITs and overseas equities, have outperformed the Nifty over the past one- and three-year periods. The category delivered average returns of 11.44% and 14.45%, respectively, compared with a 1.26% decline and an 8.57% gain for the Nifty, according to Value Research data.

The outperformance has been aided by strong returns from asset classes outside equities, particularly precious metals. Domestic gold prices have risen around 45% over the past year and 150-160% over three years, translating into annualised returns of roughly 36-38% over the three years.

REITs and InvITs have also contributed, with the Nifty REITs & InvITs index returning around 13% over one year and 12.5% annualised over three years.

Exposure to these assets has helped multi-asset funds navigate the relatively weak performance of equities, while giving fund managers opportunities to shift allocations depending on market conditions.

"Opt for a multi-asset fund which has higher flexibility to buy other low-correlated assets like fixed income, gold, InvITs and foreign equity," said Manuj Jain, co-founder, ValueMetrics Technologies. Jain said an equity allocation of 35-65% gives fund managers greater room to move into assets such as gold, silver, InvITs or REITs when opportunities emerge.

Retail investors have increasingly taken to these funds, making multi-asset funds one of the fastest-growing mutual fund categories. Assets under management have surged six-fold to ₹2.2 lakh crore in July 2026 from ₹36,097 crore in August 2023.

The AUM of Multi-asset funds has surged six-fold to ₹2.2 lakh crore in July 2026 from ₹36,097 crore in August 2023

Some multi-asset funds typically keep 65-70% in unhedged equities, with the rest spread across fixed income, precious metals, REITs and InvITs. The higher equity exposure can also provide favourable equity taxation, with long-term capital gains taxed at 12.5% after the stipulated holding period.

Another set keeps equity exposure at 35-65%, giving fund managers greater leeway to allocate to other asset classes depending on market conditions.

"Study the fund manager's track record in shifting allocation across asset classes. This active rebalancing is what you're really paying for," said Kunal Valia, founder, Statlane, a Sebi-registered research analyst.

WITH JUST ₹8,000-9,000 CRORE SANCTIONED TO MFIs...

Less Than Half of Microfin ₹20K-crore Scheme Used

Some scheme features restricted borrowing by many small and medium NBFC-MFIs, say select industry observers

Atmadip Ray

Kolkata: The ₹20,000-crore microfinance credit guarantee scheme ended with less than 50% utilisation, highlighting structural gaps in its design, particularly in how risks and operational constraints are balanced between commercial banks and microfinance institutions (MFIs).

Banks and other lenders have cumulatively sanctioned between ₹8,000-9000 crore, three people aware of the issue said. This was despite multiple interventions by the stakeholders including extension of the operational deadline to August 31, 2026, and raising the loan limit for large MFIs to ₹1,000 crore from ₹300 crore. Industry observers said some of the features of the credit guarantee programme restricted the ability to borrow for many small and medium sized non-banking financial company-microfinance institutions (NBFC-MFI), the most needy of liquidity support.

For instance, MFIs' borrowing capacity was capped at 20% of their on-balance sheet asset under management (AUM). Since the AUM had contracted for every MFI over the past two years following the severe asset quality crisis, their borrowing limit was automatically squeezed, a person in the know said. The sectoral leaders had requested government to revise the cap to 40%, which was not met.

"The credit guarantee scheme has definitely provided partial relief to the ailing small and medium sized NBFC-MFIs, but they need a longer-term solution. A permanent credit guarantee structure for the sector, like the one available for MSMEs, may address the issue effectively," Saibal Paul, deputy director at Sa-Dhan, said.

"The MFIs in the small and medium category need the government backing the most as they struggle to raise funds, while playing an important role in financial inclusion in the hinterlands," he added.

At least two of the bigger MFIs used less than 50% of the ₹1,000 crore limit.

The funding provided by banks under the scheme was partially guaranteed by National Credit Guarantee Trustee Company the government set up in 2014 to operate various credit guarantee trust funds.

The partial guarantee covers 70-80% of the loan in case of default. The government mandated that the maximum tenure of loan carrying credit guarantee will be for three years including one year of moratorium.

Funding Gap

Credit guarantee scheme size: ₹20,000 cr

Amount sanctioned: Between ₹8,000-9000 cr

Scheme utilisation: Less than 50%

Operational deadline: Extended to August 31, 2026

Loan limit for large MFIs: Raised to ₹1,000 cr from ₹300 cr

Scheme closed on August 31, 2026

Industry request to govt: Cap raised to 40%

Sports World Play

VITALS

WOMEN'S ASIA CUP

India Look to Address Batting Woes

Dubai: India will need to sort out their batting frailties for a more complete performance when they face Hong Kong in their second match of the Women's T20 Asia Cup on Thursday. The seven-time champions survived anxious moments after a batting collapse in their opening match against Thailand. Sitting pretty at 101 for 2 after 10 overs, India lost seven wickets for just 29 runs to finish at 159. Although it did not affect the outcome of the match as India comfortably defeated Thailand by 94 runs, the collapse left them with a lot to ponder, as against a top team, it could prove costly. **PTI**

IND v HK 8pm (Sony Ten)

Women's Champions Trophy Moved to India

The inaugural Women's Champions Trophy originally scheduled to be held in Sri Lanka will now take place in India in February next year, the International Cricket Council said on Wednesday. The ICC stripped Sri Lanka of the event due to government interference in the board of Sri Lanka Cricket (SLC). "The first-ever edition of the ICC Women's Champions Trophy will take place from February 14 to 28 in India next year," the ICC said in a statement. **Reuters**

It will be a turning point for Indian football. We are playing Brazil for the first time in history. We must think positively. This is a very good thing happening for Indian football

KHALID JAMIL
India's football coach

NARROW ESCAPE

US OPEN Top seed Zverev survives a five-set thriller against No. 89 Sonego after being two points from defeat

Janina Nuno Rios

Alexander Zverev has the No. 1 seed in a Grand Slam tournament for the first time and the belief that comes from finally winning a major title.

Then he nearly had a quick exit from the US Open.

The French Open champion rallied just in time to edge Lorenzo Sonego 6-4, 3-6, 6-7 (7), 7-5, 6-4 in a match that lasted 4 hours, 52 minutes and ended early Wednesday morning.

Two nights after No. 4 seed and 24-time Grand Slam champion Novak Djokovic was eliminated with a five-set loss, Zverev nearly became another top player ousted from an event that top-ranked Jannik Sinner had to miss because of a right knee injury.

That moved the No. 2-ranked Zverev up to the No. 1 seed in the US Open, and if he had lost he would have been the first man on the top line to fall in the first round of a major since Lleyton Hewitt lost to Ivo Karlovic at Wimbledon in 2003.

"I'm happy that I won this kind of battle," Zverev told reporters after the four-hour, 53-minute battle. "He is an amazing tennis player. He has an amazing serve and forehand, and he can return so quickly.

"I would say I have one of the fastest second serves on tour, and he was attacking it all the time. I have to give credit to him, but I'm happy I managed to win in the end.

"Funny enough, I think I missed a few more backhands than I usually do tonight ... Overall, it was a great battle and a match that I needed after the last couple of weeks."

Zverev arrived in New York as a major champion for the first time after his French Open triumph in June and is widely seen as the man to beat with Sinner absent and defending champion Carlos Alcaraz recently returning from injury.

Zverev converted only one of seven break-point opportunities in winning the opening set before world No. 89 Sonego responded in the second, breaking early and shifting the momentum before serving out to love and sealing the set with an ace.

A back-and-forth third set went to a tiebreak, where a double fault from Zverev handed Sonego the opening he needed to move ahead 2-1.

After the pair traded breaks in the fourth, Zverev found himself two points away from defeat before securing a crucial hold and breaking serve to force a deciding set.

Zverev completed the turnaround as Sonego ran out of steam, the German happy to avoid becoming the first top seed to lose in the first round of a Grand Slam since Lleyton Hewitt in 2003 at Wimbledon. "I think it was an incredible battle, lots of ups and downs, nearly five hours. I think it was my longest first-round match at a Grand Slam," Zverev said.

Zverev was two points from defeat at one stage but kept his composure when it mattered to set up a clash with Frenchman Quentin Halys. **AP/Reuters**

I'm happy that I won this kind of battle. It was a great battle and a match that I needed after the last couple of weeks

ALEXANDER ZVEREV

£100M+ CLUB
4 of the 11 most expensive signings in Premier League history arrived this summer

THE BLOCKBUSTERS

£125M ENZO FERNÁNDEZ
Chelsea → Man City

£117m MORGAN ROGERS
Aston Villa → Chelsea

£116m ELLIOT ANDERSON
Nottingham Forest → Man City

£107m BRADLEY BARCOLA
PSG → Liverpool
DEAL COULD RISE TO £123M

BIGGEST SPENDERS

£458m	£349m	£303m	£400m+
Man City	Chelsea	Tottenham	Combined spending by promoted trio Ipswich • Coventry City • Hull City

CASH RUSH

Premier League clubs smash the summer spending record – again

£3.46 B
TOTAL PREMIER LEAGUE SPENDING THIS SUMMER

SECOND SUCCESSIVE SEASON
The league has broken its summer spending record

SPENDING BOOM

£1.13bn 5 years ago

£3bn+ Last summer

£3.46bn This summer

INTRA-LEAGUE TRANSFERS

38% of deals were between Premier League clubs | **30%** last summer

+8 percentage points increase in the share of intra-league deals

OTHER BIG DEALS

£92.5m Sandro Tonali
Newcastle to Tottenham
DEAL COULD REACH £100M

£65m Iliman Ndiaye
Everton to Man City

£51.4m Matías Fernández-Pardo
Lille to Newcastle

£47m Ibrahim Mbaye PSG to Aston Villa

DEADLINE-DAY DRAMA

TWO BIG DEALS COLLAPSED

FOLARIN BALOGUN
Everton's move for the US striker fell through after he decided against proceeding

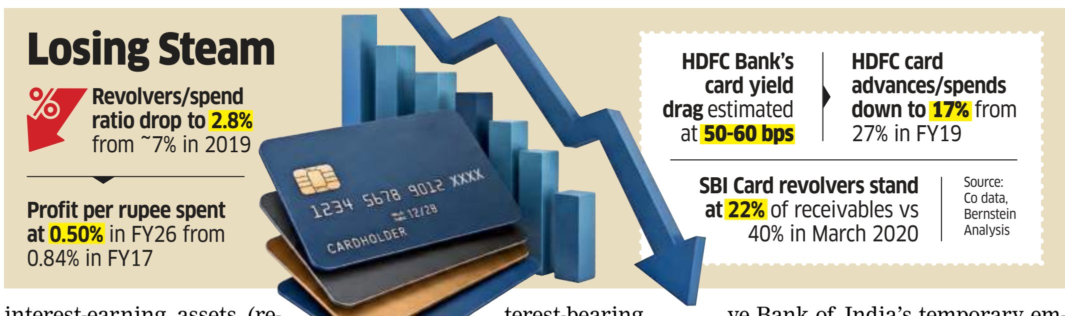
LAMINE CAMARA
The Senegal midfielder stayed at Monaco after his reported £47.1m move to Chelsea collapsed

SPENDING ON THE RISE

'Revolver' Misfire Hits Credit Card Issuers

Interest-bearing balances fall to 11% of spends as customers use cards more as a payment tool rather than as a loan product

Saloni Shukla



Mumbai: India's credit card boom is becoming less lucrative for issuers, yielding lower profit margins for banks even as spending continues to rise. Customers are increasingly using credit cards as a payment tool rather than a borrowing product, shrinking the interest-bearing balances that traditionally generated a disproportionate share of card profits.

Industry estimates suggest interest-bearing card balances—revolvers, or outstanding rolling debt, and equated monthly instalment (EMI) loans—have fallen to about 11% of annual card spending from roughly 21% several years ago, even as card spending grew at a compound annual rate of nearly 27% between 2021-22 and 2025-26.

"The revolver-led credit card model is undergoing a structural disruption," Pranav Gundlapalle, senior research analyst at Bernstein, said in a recent report. "The fall in interest-earning assets (revolvers and EMI loans) as a percentage of spends" is compressing margins, the report said, adding that cheaper and more seamless alternatives have reduced demand for revolving balances.

Bernstein estimated that the ratio of revolver balances to card spending had fallen to about 2.8% in the June quarter from roughly 7% in 2019, signifying a sharp decline in profit generated for every rupee spent on cards.

The impact is also becoming visible at large banks. The decline in interest-bearing credit-card advances has lowered HDFC Bank's overall portfolio yield by about 50-60 basis points, making it a significant contributor to the lender's weaker yield trajectory relative to peers and the broader banking system. A basis point is a hundredth of a percentage point.

HDFC Bank's credit card advances-to-spends ratio has fallen to about 17% from around 27% in 2018-19, driven almost entirely by lower revolver and EMI balances. Alongside the HDFC Ltd merger, the Reserve Bank of India's temporary embargo on fresh card issuance and the recent industry-wide moderation in card spending has reduced credit cards' share of HDFC Bank's total loan book to about 4% from around 6% in 2018-19.

For SBI Cards, the country's largest standalone credit-card issuer, retail spending on its cards increased 14% year-on-year to ₹94,033 crore in the June quarter, while receivables grew just 3% to ₹58,269 crore. Interest-earning assets accounted for about 55% of receivables, while revolvers stood at 22% and interest income declined about 3% year-on-year to ₹2,421 crore. Management, however, expects revolving balances to stabilise.

"On revolver, I think we are seeing that the rates should now remain stable and should be in somewhat similar range," SBI Cards management said during its June-quarter earnings call, indicating that the downward bias seen over the past few quarters may have bottomed out. The company is also seeking to expand EMI conversions to improve the share of interest-earning assets.

Revolvers accounted for about 40% of SBI Cards' receivables in March 2020, compared with 22% currently. Including EMI loans, interest-earning receivables have declined to 55% from 60% a year earlier, even as card usage continues to expand.

Bernstein estimated that profit generated per unit of card spending fell to about 0.50% in 2025-26 from 0.84% in 2016-17 and said he expected it to decline further to about 0.43% by 2028-29.

Tech Picks | JAYNIT VORA, Research Analyst | IIFL

AEGIS VOPAK
The stock has broken its recent swing high.
LAST CLOSE ▸ ₹286 STOP LOSS ▸ ₹277
BUY TARGET ₹300

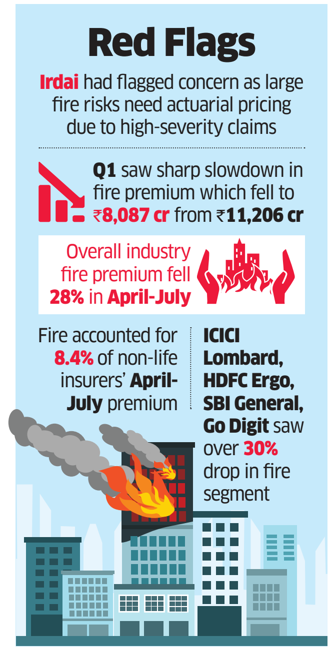
POLICY BAZAR
The stock has given a cup and handle pattern breakout on the daily chart.
LAST CLOSE ▸ ₹1,852 STOP LOSS ▸ ₹1,780
BUY TARGET ₹1,965

SAGILITY
The stock has broken its recent swing high.
LAST CLOSE ▸ ₹46.7 STOP LOSS ▸ ₹45.2
BUY TARGET ₹49

DISCUSSIONS HELD; NO DECISION TAKEN

Insurers Plan Floor for Fire Cover to Avoid Large Burns

Shilpy Sinha



Mumbai: Non-life insurers are considering a minimum rate for the natural catastrophe component of fire insurance after concerns that steep discounts in the segment could leave the industry and reinsurers exposed to mounting losses, people familiar with the matter told **ET**.

The issue was discussed informally in a recent meeting held last week, said the people cited above. No decision has been taken and the discussions remain preliminary, the people said.

Industry estimates suggest that fire protection, although a relative straggler behind health and motor insurance, still accounts for 8-9% revenue for the general insurance business. In the April-July period, fire covers made up 8.4% of the premium collection by the industry.

The move to suggest a floor premium follows concerns expressed by the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai) chairman Ajay Seth over the financial health of insurers and their underwriting discipline following complaints of discounts of up to 99% on large industrial fire risks.

The regulator had said pricing for large industrial and commercial fire risks should be based on sound actuarial principles, as these are low-frequency but high-severity risks where a single claim may be many times the premium collected.

Under fire insurance pricing, the premium broadly comprises two components — the natural catastrophe (NatCat) rate and the flexible fire (Flexa) rate. The NatCat component covers the natural catastrophe risk of a particular location, while Flexa rates provide pricing based on the nature of the business.

The proposal under discussion is that insurers should not breach the minimum prescribed NatCat rate, while a maximum permissible concession could be specified for the Flexa component. The exact limit on concessions for Flexa rates is yet to be finalised.

PREDATORY PRICING

The discussions follow concerns over aggressive fire insurance pricing, with some leaders questioning whether discounts on catastrophe-related pricing can be sustained. Recent fire losses in Gujarat have also added to concerns around risk pricing. The industry expects upwards of ₹5,000 crore claim from Gujarat floods.

"Natcat risk is not underwritten properly means you are completely playing with the fire," a source said, arguing that discounts should be restricted to the flexible component rather than the catastrophe component.

The proportion of NatCat and Flexa in the overall premium varies depending on the nature and location of the business. Higher-risk businesses such as chemical facilities could have a different pricing mix from relatively safer risks.

Reinsurers, which absorb a large part of the industry's risk, have also raised concerns over the pricing. Insurers typically retain only a portion of large risks and transfer the balance to reinsurers. Continued aggressive pricing could therefore increase losses for reinsurers even as insurers compete for business.

Premiums under the fire insurance segment fell 28% in the first four months of the financial year to ₹10,062 crore in April-July, compared with ₹14,063 crore a year earlier, industry data from the General Insurance Council showed, as aggressive discounting of large industrial risks weighed on premium growth.

THE MORNING BRIEF PODCAST

HDFC Bank's CEO Hunt

Anirban Chowdhury speaks to ET's banking editor Sangita Mehta on HDFC Bank's race to find a new CEO, its post-merger performance slump, and the formidable repair job awaiting its next chief.

Available on EconomicTimes.com/podcast, Amazon Prime Music, Apple Podcasts, JioSaavn *and* Spotify.

ITC INFOTECH DEAL Uncertainty over long integration, lack of open offer opportunity weigh

Happiest Minds Faces a Bumpy Ride as Many on D-St Unhappy

Ranjit Shinde

ET Intelligence Group: Happiest Minds Technologies (HMT) has fallen on bourses for five straight sessions up to Wednesday, wiping out the stock's three-month gain of 21% entirely. Concerns over short-term uncertainty regarding its integration with ITC Infotech (ITCI) has triggered the sharp reversal in the stock movement.

Additionally, ITCI initially plans to buy a 22.1% stake from HMT promoters for ₹1,330 crore in cash. The acquired stake is short of the minimum 25% required to trigger an open offer. It means while promoters receive the cash from the stake sale, there will be no cash exit for minority shareholders as the latter will receive proportionate shares in ITCI.

While the combined entity is expected to achieve better profits and profitability in the long run due to business synergies, HMT's stock is expected to be under pressure in the near term.

The deal structure involves two steps and will not require the buyer to launch an open offer for public shareholders. In the first step, HMT promoter Ashok Soota who owns 32% stake directly and another 12% through a medical research entity, totalling 44%, will retain the management control even after ITCI acquires 22.1% stake, which ITC will fund through a rights issue. In the second step, shareholders of HMT will receive 25 ITCI shares for every 81 shares held. This will complete HMT's merger into ITCI, which will also automatically pave the way for the latter to list on exchanges without opting for an initial public offering (IPO).

According to a research note by HDFC Securities, the share swap values HMT at ₹6,167 crore and ITCI at ₹11,920 crore, implying FY26 enterprise value (EV)/operating profit before depreciation and amortisation (EBITDA) multiples of 15.1 and 13.6 respectively. After the merger, ITC will own 73.4% of the combined entity. The implied market cap of the merged entity will be ₹18,060 crore.

Based on FY26 financials, the combined entity will have a revenue of ₹7,033 crore ($790.5 million), making it the country's 11th largest listed software company. ITCI operated at a higher EBITDA margin of 18.5% compared with HMT's 17.4% in FY26. The merged entity will have a margin of 18.1% and a net profit of ₹737 crore.

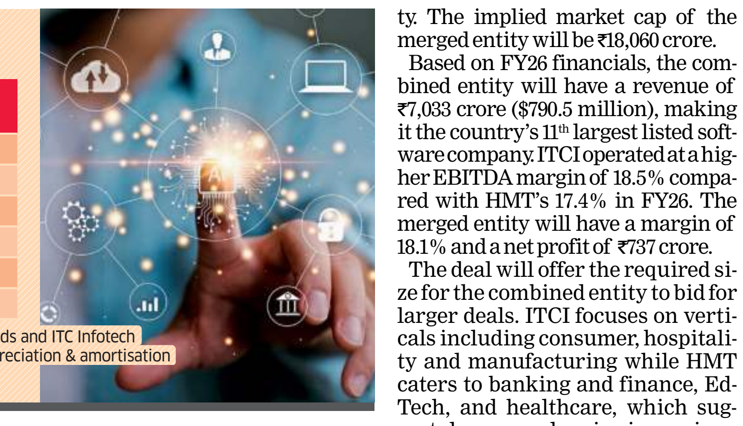
The deal will offer the required size for the combined entity to bid for larger deals. ITCI focuses on verticals including consumer, hospitality and manufacturing while HMT caters to banking and finance, EdTech, and healthcare, which suggests lower overlapping in services. The merged entity expects to cross $1 billion in revenue by FY28 at 19.1% EBITDA margin.

HDFC Securities has downgraded HMT's stock to 'Add' from 'Buy' and reduced the target price to ₹400 from ₹440 citing lack of takeover premium and uncertainty due to longer expected duration of 15 months for the integration of two businesses. The stock closed at ₹354.5 on the BSE on Wednesday.

Merger Statistics

	Combined Entity
Revenue ($M)	790.5
Revenue	7033
EBITDA	1,276
EBITDA Margin (%)	18.1
Net Profit	737
No. of Employees	19,532

FY26 Data for the combined Happiest Minds and ITC Infotech
EBITDA: Earnings before interest, tax, depreciation & amortisation
Source: **Company, HDFC Securities**



ABOUT 14% OF THE POOL

ICICI Bank Raises Over $17 b via RBI Swap Route

Our Bureau

Mumbai: ICICI Bank mobilised about $17.88 billion (₹ 1.70 lakh crore) through foreign currency non-resident, or FCNR(B), deposits under the Reserve Bank of India's special swap facility, accounting for about 14% of the $127.23 billion raised by banks through the window up to August 31.

The mobilisation gives the non-state lender a sizeable pool of foreign-currency funding that can be deployed towards loans, while the RBI swap helps limit the currency risk associated with raising dollar deposits.

Of the deposits raised by ICICI Bank, loans extended by its international branches and subsidiaries against such deposits were about $9 billion (₹ 85,600 crore), equivalent to roughly half of the mobilisation.

The bank also issued standby letters of credit (SBLCs) worth $3.63 billion (₹ 34,600 crore) to other banks in respect of loans extended against such deposits.

About half of the funds mobilised were deployed as loans by international branches and subsidiaries

Together, direct loans and loans supported through SBLCs amount to about $12.63 billion, or more than 70% of ICICI Bank's FCNR(B) mobilisation, indicating that a substantial part of the funds raised has already been deployed or committed towards lending.

Separately, ICICI Bank raised about $3.55 billion (₹ 33,800 crore) through US dollar-denominated bonds during July and August.

Meanwhile, RBL Bank said it mobilised about $3.40 billion (₹32,472 crore) in FCNR (B) deposits under the special swap window. Of this, its international banking unit deployed around $1.08 billion (₹ 10,309 crore) as loans.

The disclosures come as banks reported a sharp last-minute rush for FCNR(B) deposits before the special window closed on August 31. Total FCNR(B) mobilisation reached $127.23 billion by the end of the window, nearly double the $65.40 billion reported by the RBI as of August 21. This means banks garnered another $61.83 billion in the final 10 days, almost as much as they had raised until August 21.

Including external commercial borrowings and overseas foreign currency borrowings, forex inflows under the RBI's special swap facilities totalled $136.38 billion as of August 31.

POWER PLAY Energy sector co's stock has risen 76% in 2026; analysts expect strong execution to lift margins and earnings in medium term

Orders Flow in, Avenues Open Up; Hitachi May Still be a 'Buy'

Sachin Kumar

ET Intelligence Group: Shares of Hitachi Energy, a power-grid equipment and technology company, have risen nearly 76% year-to-date, supported by healthy revenue growth and strong order inflows. The company has recently won orders for battery energy storage systems (BESS) and data centres, opening new avenues for growth. Its order book reached ₹32,222 crore at the end of the June quarter, which is its biggest near-term earnings driver.

The company's June quarter performance was benefited from higher execution, with revenue rising 69% year-on-year. The near-term pipeline may receive another boost from high-voltage direct current (HVDC) projects. Hitachi Energy is currently bidding for a greenfield HVDC project. The order is expected to be awarded within six months.

ICICI Securities noted that two HVDC projects make up for around 60% of Hitachi Energy's order book. As execution accelerates from FY28, the brokerage expects improved margins and a sharp rise in earnings over the near to medium term.

Beyond transmission, BESS presents another growth avenue. During the quarter, the company secured its first BESS order, a 165 MW/330 MWh project in Andhra Pradesh.

Margins may benefit over the long term from capacity expansion and localisation. Hitachi Energy began the construction of its 20th manufacturing facility at Karjan in Vadodara in June. The fully digital manufacturing facility is targeted for commissioning in December 2028 and is expected to expand capacity and strengthen local capabilities.

Data centres are emerging as an important new demand driver. The company secured multiple data centre orders during the quarter and is positioning the portfolio across gas-insulated switchgear, transformers, dry transformers, power transformers and services.

The stock trades at price-to-earnings (P/E) multiple of 127. Though it is below the three and five-year average of 217 and 285, it still appears on the higher side, reflecting strong future growth prospects. Analysts have revised price targets by 6-11% citing stronger growth visibility. ICICI Securities has upgraded the stock to 'Buy' from 'Add' with a revised target price of ₹40,000 valuing the stock at 70 times its FY28 earnings. PL Capital has upgraded the stock to 'Hold' from 'Reduce' with a revised price target of ₹34,026.

Shares of Hitachi Energy ended nearly 2% lower at ₹32,200 on the Bombay Stock Exchange on Wednesday.

Charged Up

Hitachi Energy's June quarter performance (₹ crore)

	Jun'26	Jun'25	YoY Chg (%)
Revenue	2,494	1,479	68.6
Operating EBITDA	400	170	135.0
Operating EBITDA Margin (%)	16	12	450 bps
Net Profit	294.2	131.6	123.5

EBITDA: Earnings before interest, tax, depreciation & amortisation
Bps: Basis points (100 bps = 1% point) SOURCE: Company data, ETIG

SFB Asset Quality Set to Improve by March: Crisil

Our Bureau

Kolkata: Small finance banks are likely to see an improvement in their asset quality this financial year, with their gross non-performing assets (GNPAs) projected to decline by about 120 basis points to 2.6-2.8% by March 2027, Crisil Ratings said.

Their GNPAs stood at 3.8% and 4.4% at March-end this year and last year, respectively.

Crisil Ratings said the improvement would be driven by a recovery in the credit performance of the microfinance portfolio, alongside continued growth and increasing contribution from the non-microfinance portfolio, where asset quality is expected to remain stable.

"Tighter underwriting by SFBs (small finance banks) has improved borrower selection, materially strengthening the asset quality of microfinance portfolios," said Aparna Kirubakaran, director, Crisil Ratings.

Gross NPAs from the microfinance book are likely to ease to 3.8-4% by March 2027 from 7.6% at the end of 2025–26, after having declined from a peak of 8.4% recorded a year earlier, according to the rating agency.

Borrower over-indebtedness caused significant credit stress in the microfinance portfolio during the past two fiscals.

Short Takes

Alpha Wave Offloads 3.1% Stake in Pine Labs

MUMBAI Alpha Wave Ventures II has sold a nearly 3.1% stake in Pine Labs in a block deal worth ₹549.9 crore on the NSE on Wednesday. They sold 3.5 crore shares at ₹155.1 apiece.

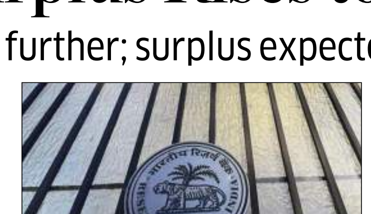
ICICI Bank Raises ICICI Life Stake to 52.8%

MUMBAI ICICI Bank has acquired about 2% stake in ICICI Prudential Life Insurance Company through multiple tranches executed between July 22 and September 2, taking its holding in the insurer to about 52.8%. The bank purchased 29.02 million equity shares of ICICI Life, with a face value of ₹10 each, for an approximate consideration of ₹1,470 crore. –**Our Bureau**

Liquidity Surplus Rises to 4.5-yr High

Average call rates fall further; surplus expected to moderate by Q3

Rozebud Gonsalves



Mumbai: The liquidity surplus in India's banking system has surged to its highest in more than four-and-a-half years to ₹7.76 lakh crore, central bank data showed, as lenders garnered a record $127 billion in dedicated forex-inflow programs.

The weighted average call rate (WACR), unsurprisingly, fell 44 basis points below the repo rate to 4.81%, easing rates in the ultra-short tenor category, as liquidity surplus widened the most since February 2022.

This liquidity surplus is expected to moderate by the third quarter of FY27 as seasonal factors drain funds from the banking system. For now, the central bank is managing the excess liquidity through temporary variable rate reverse repo (VRRR) operations, largely of shorter tenures.

"I expect system liquidity to moderate from 3QFY27 amid festive-season currency leakage, a higher current account deficit, softer government spending, and subdued capital inflows," said Soumyajit Niyogi, director at India Ratings.

Niyogi does not rule out the possibility of open market operations (OMOs) in Q4 when liquidity is expected to moderate or even be at a deficit. "Structural liquidity leakages and maturing FX forward positions could gradually erode surplus liquidity, potentially reopening the case for OMO support from 4QFY27 if capital inflows remain weak," he said. "This would make external sector dynamics the key determinant of liquidity conditions in 2HFY27."

On Wednesday, the RBI conducted an overnight VRRR operation of ₹5 lakh crore, which got bids for ₹4.6 lakh crore. Tuesday's VRRR auction of 7 days garnered ₹1.17 lakh crore against a notified amount of ₹6 lakh crore. The central bank will conduct another overnight VRRR for ₹6 lakh crore on Thursday

Liquidity is expected to increase further, as banks swap the remaining FCNR(B) deposits that they have received over the next few days.

D-Street Diary

Annu Projects Debuts 27% Below Issue Price

MUMBAI Annu Projects listed on the NSE at ₹72 on Wednesday, a discount of over 27% to its IPO price of ₹99. The stock ended at ₹75.6. The company's market capitalisation was at ₹495.12 crore at close.

Purple Style Labs IPO Subscribed 1.29 times

MUMBAI The ₹680 crore initial public offering (IPO) of Purple Style Labs was subscribed 1.29 times on the last day of bidding on Tuesday. The Qualified Institutional Buyers (QIB) portion was subscribed 1.43 times, while the non-institutional investors (NII) segment was subscribed 0.84 times. The retail portion was subscribed 1.58 times.

Pranav Constructions Sets Price Band at ₹118-124

MUMBAI Pranav Constructions has fixed the price band for its initial public offering (IPO) at ₹118-124 per equity share. The issue will open for subscription on Sep 7 and close on Sep 9. The IPO comprises a fresh issue of up to ₹315.6 crore and an offer for sale (OFS) of up to 28.56 lakh equity shares.

Coal India Arm Mahanadi Files IPO Papers

MUMBAI Mahanadi Coalfields, a wholly owned subsidiary of Coal India, has filed its Draft Red Herring Prospectus (DRHP) with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) for its proposed initial public offering (IPO). The proposed IPO of one of India's largest coal producers will comprise an offer for sale (OFS) of up to 66.18 crore equity shares by promoters of Coal India. There is no fresh issue component. –**Our Bureau**

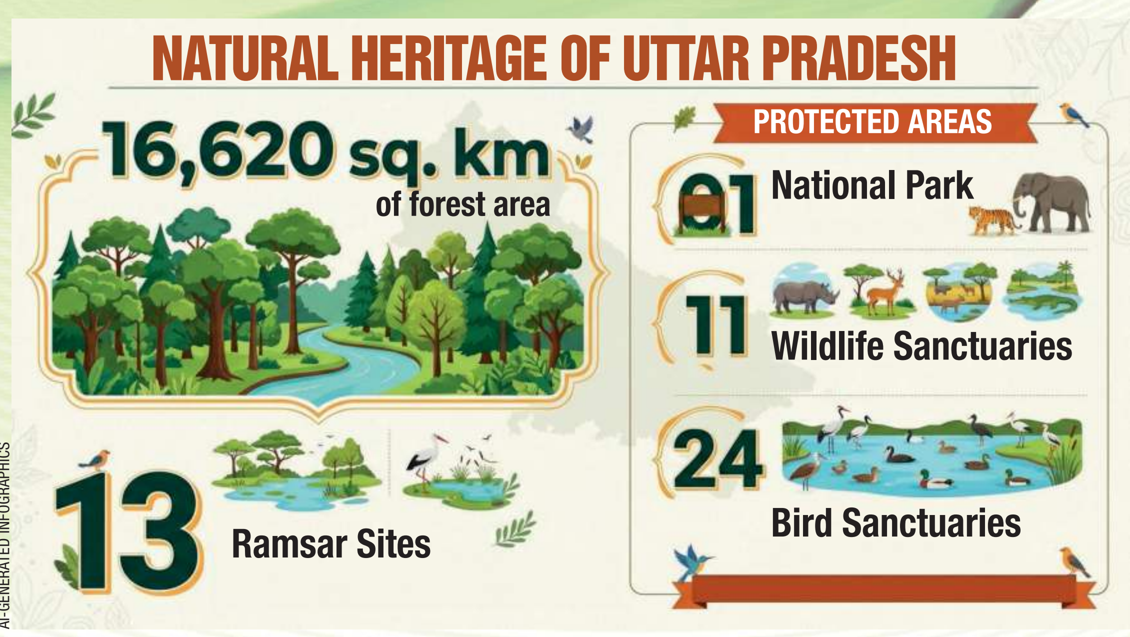
Zerodha Unit Gets Nod for Merchant Banking

MUMBAI Zerodha Corporate Advisors, a unit of the discount brokerage house founded by billionaire Nithin Kamath, received approval from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) on September 1 to operate as a merchant banker, according to the regulator's website. The company had applied for the licence in April, as per the regulatory records.

The formal registration process is yet to be completed, after which Zerodha Corporate Advisors will be able to offer merchant banking services. The licence will allow the company to advise on and manage initial public offerings (IPOs) and other capital-market transactions. Sebi currently has 249 registered merchant bankers, while 10 firms have applied for licences, according to data on the regulator's website. –**Our Bureau**

Uttar Pradesh takes THE ECO-TOURISM ROUTE

From Dudhwa to Katerniaghat Ghat, UP's green destinations gain momentum



Vistadome opens new window to UP's nature escapes

The Vistadome Train Safari, integrating Dudhwa, Katerniaghat and Kishanpur sanctuaries, offers travellers an immersive journey through Uttar Pradesh's scenic landscapes. With expansive glass windows and panoramic views, it enhances the wildlife experience while connecting key nature destinations. The service is expected to encourage eco-tourism, promote longer stays and offer visitors a comfortable, memorable way to explore the region.

Uttar Pradesh is emerging as a promising destination for eco-tourism, with growing focus on nature-based travel, wildlife conservation and sustainable tourism. The state's diverse landscape, from the forests of Terai region and wetlands to river ecosystems and bird habitats, offers ample opportunities for visitors seeking experiences beyond conventional tourist circuits. Over the past three years, Eco-Tourism Development Board has invested more than ₹161 crore in strengthening eco-tourism infrastructure and initiatives.

Protected areas such as Dudhwa National Park, Katerniaghat Wildlife Sanctuary and the Pilibhit Tiger Reserve are attracting travellers interested in wildlife safaris, birdwatching, nature trails and responsible tourism. Wetland destinations, particularly those frequented by migratory birds, are also gaining popularity among nature enthusiasts and photographers.

The government's emphasis on developing tourism infrastructure while preserving natural habitats is giving further momentum to the sector. Eco-friendly stays, interpretation centres, guided nature walks and community-led tourism initiatives are creating livelihood opportunities for local residents while encouraging conservation.

The expansion of eco-tourism is also helping diversify Uttar Pradesh's tourism economy by promoting lesser-known destinations and extending visitor stays. With sustainable infrastructure, better connectivity and greater community participation, the state has the potential to position eco-tourism as both an economic opportunity and a tool for protecting its rich natural heritage.

Green trails to boost UP tourism

Green tourism circuits connect natural attractions, encouraging longer stays, wider exploration and sustainable visitor flows across Uttar Pradesh

- Lion Safari & Conservation Circuit
- Western Wildlife Sanctuary Circuit
- Ganga Basin Circuit
- Eastern Wildlife Circuit
- Vindhya Mountain Sanctuary Circuit
- Western Bird/Wetland Circuit
- Terai Circuit
- Bundelkhand Adventure Circuit
- Central Bird/Wetland Circuit

GUARDING UP'S WILDLIFE LEGACY

More than 1.13 lakh wild animals in Dudhwa Tiger Reserve

Over 17,000 wild animals in Katerniaghat Wildlife Sanctuary

Around 15,000 wild animals in the buffer zone

Leopard population increased from 92 (2022) to 275 (2025)

Rhinoceros population increased from 49 to 66

TOURIST FACILITIES EXPANDED

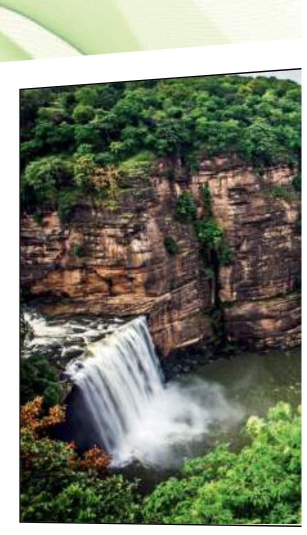
Improved roads and access routes, cafeterias,

eco-friendly rest areas, nature trails, bird-watching zones,

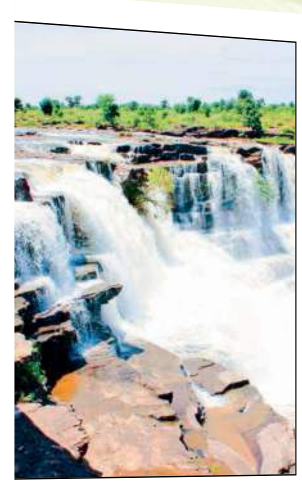
various other essential tourism infrastructure

New avenues for local communities

- **Integrating the Tharu tribe into tourism-related activities:** Engaging Tharu communities in tourism showcases their rich traditions, crafts and heritage while creating meaningful economic opportunities
- **Promotion of traditional cuisine and cultural heritage:** Promoting regional cuisine and cultural traditions helps preserve local heritage while creating new avenues for community participation
- **Encouragement of homestay development:** Homestays offers visitors authentic experiences while enabling local families to earn through tourism-related services



PICS: UP TOURISM



BCCL's Mohit Jain Elected Chairman of Audit Bureau of Circulations


FILE PHOTO

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Mohit Jain, chief operating officer, publishing, and board member of Bennett, Coleman & Co (BCCL), has been unanimously elected chairman of the Audit Bureau of Circulations (ABC) for 2026-27. The Economic Times is published by BCCL.

The ABC is a grouping that comprises publishers, advertisers and advertising agencies. It conducts market surveys and certifies circulation figures reported by publishers.

Jain's election marks BCCL's return to the chairmanship of the ABC after 43 years since its previous representative held the position.

Taking charge as chairman, Jain said the focus will be on furthering newspaper readership.

"To engage younger and urban households, newspapers are innovating in content, design, distribution and their integration with digital platforms," Jain said. "Publishers are also using campaigns to reinforce the value of a daily reading habit—depth, perspective, discovery and trusted information. The objective is not merely to preserve circulation, but to make newspapers relevant and indispensable to a new generation of readers."

Jain has more than two decades of experience in the print media industry and has held senior leadership positions in publishing, business operations and industry affairs. He brings to the ABC extensive sectoral experience and an understanding of issues shaping the future of print media, circulation and publishing.

He has also held several positions in industry bodies. Jain served as president of the Indian Newspaper Society (INS) during 2021-22 and has been associated with its board for more than two decades. The INS represents newspapers, magazines and periodicals in India and works on issues concerning the print media industry and press freedom.

Jain previously served for three years on the global supervisory board of the World Association of News Publishers (WAN-IFRA). He is currently vice-president of the South Asia division board of the International News Media Association (INMA).

He is also chairman of the media committee of PHDCCI, chairman of the news, print and publishing subcommittee of the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII), and a member of the media & entertainment committee of the Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce & Industry (Ficci).

In a Nutshell

Adhere to Food Safety Norms, 5-Star Hotels Told

NEW DELHI Sending out a strong message after multiple violations by hotels, watchdog FSSAI has asked all leading 5-star hospitality firms in country to strictly follow food safety norms and ensure hygiene benchmarks. Food Safety Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) CEO Rajit Punhani, in a meeting with senior executives of major hotel companies held on Tuesday, asserted that it has "zero tolerance" for any violations, according to sources. The direction to all major hospitality companies comes in wake of the FSSAI's recent notices to two major 5-star hotels, JW Marriott and Andaz at Aerocity in Delhi.

Nestle to Sell Vitamin Biz to PE Firm for $1 b

Nestle SA plans to sell its mainstream vitamins and supplements business to US private equity firm Yellow Wood Partners for $1 billion as chief executive officer Philipp Navratil tries to streamline and turn around the Swiss foodmaker. The deal includes brands such as Nature's Bounty, Osteo Bi-Flex and Puritan's Pride alongside the US private-label supplements business and its manufacturing and logistics operations.

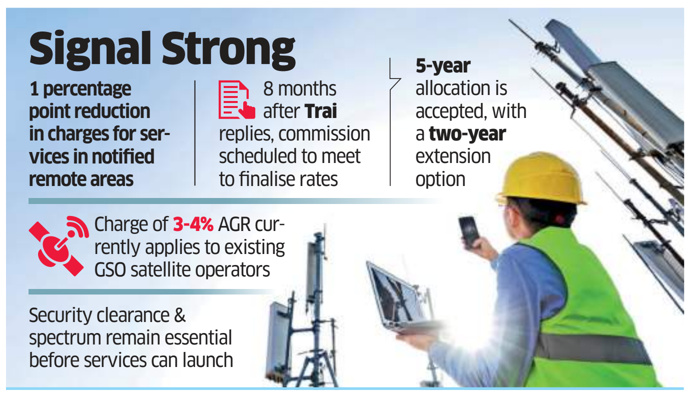
USFDA Flags Violations at Rel Life Sciences Plant

NEW DELHI The United States Food and Drug Administration (USFDA) has issued a warning letter to Reliance Life Sciences over "violations" of current good manufacturing practice regulations for finished pharmaceuticals at its facility in Navi Mumbai. USFDA said the firm failed to ensure laboratory records included complete data from all tests necessary to ensure compliance.

Panel Could Soon Take a Call on Satcom Airwave Allocation, Fees

DCC may approve usage fee at 5% of adjusted revenue with incentives for serving remote areas

Kiran Rathee



New Delhi: An inter-ministerial panel is likely to decide soon on the usage fee for satellite spectrum as well as other modalities like tenure of airwaves allocation to firms like Starlink, Eutelsat OneWeb and Jio Satellite. People aware of the details told ET that the digital communications commission (DCC) is expected to meet soon and approve spectrum charges at 5% of adjusted gross revenue (AGR) with an incentive to serve certain rural and remote areas. "The satcom firms will get 1 percentage point reduction in spectrum charges for serving these notified areas," said a person privy to the details.

The DCC, the highest decision-making body of the department of telecommunications (DoT), is meeting nearly eight months after Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (Trai) submitted its replies in December on certain queries raised by the DoT on satcom spectrum. The regulator had given its original recommendations on the subject in May last year, which was discussed by the DCC in September after which some clarifications were sought from Trai.

The DoT has rejected Trai's proposal to charge 4% AGR as usage fee along with a ₹500 additional charge per customer per annum for satcom services in urban areas. The DoT feels it would be difficult to implement the Trai proposal due to the problem of distinction between rural and urban areas.

The DoT has also rejected the Trai proposal of offering subsidies of certain targeted subscribers in rural and remote areas to get fixed satellite terminals. The regulator had proposed to provide a subsidy from the Digital Bharat Nidhi (DBN) fund. However, the DoT said there was no provision in DBN for such a kind of subsidy.

The DoT, however, has accepted the proposal of giving satcom spectrum for a period of five years to firms with an option of two-year extension.

Now only geostationary orbit (GSO)-based fixed satellite networks like Hughes and Nelco are permitted to offer services in India, and they pay spectrum charges in the range of 3-4% of AGR. The government will finalise pricing and other modalities for non-GSO players like Elon Musk-owned Starlink, Eutelsat OneWeb, Jio Satellite and Amazon Leo to enter the broadband market from the space market.

La Caisse Invests over ₹12k cr for 24% in Altius

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Canada-based pension fund manager and global investment group La Caisse on Wednesday announced it has invested ₹12,100 crore to acquire 24% stake in Altius Telecom Infrastructure Trust, which owns 258,000 telecom towers with Reliance Jio as the anchor customer.

The announcement comes after the competition commission of India (CCI) gave its approval on August 28, citing that the transaction does not exhibit any horizontal overlaps, vertical linkages and complimentary linkages in any of the relevant markets in India.

Altius, which is the largest passive infrastructure trust in pure tower count, following the merging of Summit Digitel, Crest Digitel, and American Tower Company's footprint acquired by Brookfield in 2024, and competes with Bharti Airtel subsidiary Indus Towers.

"As India's economy grows and more people and businesses rely on higher use of mobile data, the infrastructure behind those connections needs to keep pace," said Emmanuel Jaclot, executive vice-president and head of infrastructure and sustainability at La Caisse in a statement.

"This is a sector we know well through our investments in telecom towers and digital infrastructure around the world. With Altius, we are investing in an attractive market through an established platform, alongside Brookfield and other institutional partners with whom we have longstanding relationships," he added.

Following the transaction, Brookfield said it remains the largest investor in Altius with 37% shareholding in the trust, alongside La Caisse and existing shareholders who are affiliates of Singapore sovereign wealth fund GIC and British Columbia Investment Management Corporation. Brookfield's primary sponsor vehicle BIF IV Jarvis India offloaded 17.07% portion of its shareholding units to make room for the transaction.

ADD TO CART: CONSUMER APPROACH

GCPL's Chief Flags Execution Gaps, Bets on Overseas Push

CEO Malbari targets weak core growth, falling profitability with higher R&D

Sagar Malviya

Our core category revenue growth has been flattish with profits actually kind of being under pressure

AASIF MALBARI
CEO, Godrej Consumer Products

Mumbai: Godrej Consumer Products' new chief executive Aasif Malbari in his first investor call, acknowledged a string of execution failures, weak core-category growth and falling profitability, while promising a more aggressive push on innovation and overseas growth.

The assessment comes barely three weeks after Sudhir Sitapati's abrupt departure as managing director and CEO, adding to investor concerns about the company's ability to execute its long-term strategy.

The biggest problem, he said, is closer to home. "Our core category revenue growth has been actually flattish with profits actually kind of being under pressure." He also flagged declining average profitability in India and Indonesia, while Latin America and other international businesses remain low-profitability operations.

Sitapati resigned on August 10, just three days after shareholders approved his reappointment for another five years and only months after the board had approved the extension. The company has not disclosed a reason for his departure. The board appointed Malbari, previously chief financial officer and head of the Africa business, with immediate effect.

"We've delivered an organic UVG of 4% in India in standalone and at a consolidated level. The ULG has been 7% and 6% and Ebitda has been 6%," Malbari said. "We have definitely kind of made a significant shift below where we want it to be."

The timing has made Malbari's assessment of the business particularly significant. His message was blunt: GCPL's strategy may not be changing dramatically, but its execution needs to.

The company now plans to spend about ₹150 crore on a new research and development centre, while increasing international go-to-market spending and digital marketing. Together, these investments are expected to add about ₹200 crore a year to operating costs once fully ramped up.

"These investments actually take 2-3 years to kind of pay back in full," Malbari said, asking investors to accept higher costs even as it tries to repair profitability.

The company also disclosed that distributor inventory in India is too high. It expects to collect ₹125 crore to ₹150 crore of inventory over the next three quarters. Malbari said distributors are carrying 20 days of inventory in general products, while GCPL believes it can operate in 10 days. "Yes. I think it needs to be done," he said when asked why the correction was happening suddenly. "It's a little short-term thing because, ₹150 crore is not small."

The correction will put pressure on India profit growth, he acknowledged, even as the company maintains its FY27 guidance. Malbari also conceded that GCPL has struggled to execute several of its growth bets. On fragrances and deodorants, a category entered through the ₹2,825-crore Raymond Consumer Care acquisition, he said the company "didn't get the execution right" when acquiring and integrating PAKS.

India's Diversity Makes Localisation Necessary for Brands: Shiseido Exec

Aanya Thakur & Sagar Malviya

Mumbai: For decades, much of India's beauty market was built around a singular aspiration: lighter skin. **Nicole Tan**, Asia-Pacific president and chief executive of Japan's Shiseido, is arriving at a different moment—one with 28 states, countless skin tones and an increasingly confident consumer unwilling to fit a single definition of beauty. "Diversity is the first thing that comes to my mind when I think of India. This is the highest level of diversity I've seen across any of our markets," she said.

For Shiseido, India's opportunity lies precisely in the fact that the market has moved beyond one beauty ideal, where fairness and whitening products dominated consumer conversations for decades. "Right now, women feel more comfortable and more confident to embrace their diversity, their individuality, their self-expressions, and that is a goldmine to tap into the Indian consumer," she told ET in an exclusive interview. "I'm very happy to see the market growing this way because there is no one homogeneous view of what constitutes beauty."

For Shiseido, the challenge is building a business across what Tan describes as "28 different Indias", spanning different cultures, climates, consumer behaviours and skin tones. "So that diversity and that richness really stands out for India," Tan said, adding that diversity also makes localisation necessary, even for global brands selling internationally standardised products.

Rural Markets Growth Centres for Premium Beer: AB InBev

Aanya Thakur

Mumbai: AB InBev India is seeing premium beer consumption accelerate across semi-urban and rural markets, including unexpected pockets such as Jharkhand, Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh, prompting the maker of Budweiser and Corona to widen distribution of its more expensive brands. At the same time, policy changes in states such as Maharashtra and Karnataka are providing a fresh tailwind to demand.

"What has caught us completely by surprise is the rural growth," Kartikeya Sharma, president of AB InBev India, told ET, pointing to rising premium consumption in markets that had traditionally been considered unlikely growth centres for higher-priced beer.

But the world's biggest brewer is also drawing a sharper line on where it will invest.

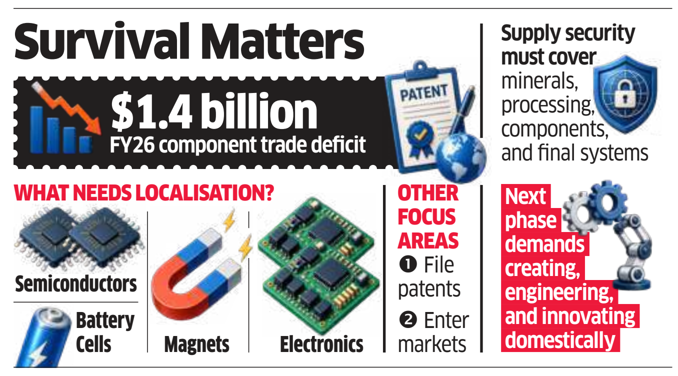
While Maharashtra, Karnataka and West Bengal are emerging as markets where AB InBev India sees a sustainable and predictable policy environment, the company is holding back fresh investments in states where pricing or payment uncertainty is making business economics difficult.

"We don't want to encourage taking investments to a state where the fundamental business case collapses because we can't cover inflation," said Sharma. In Uttar Pradesh, the company has held back investments after not being allowed to raise prices for three years despite rising costs, while in Telangana, outstanding dues owed to the brewer reached close to $50 million between December and May.

This poses a stark contrast as the premium opportunity becomes harder to ignore. India's premium beer segment grew more than 20% in the first half of the year, while the company's premium share reached 60%, its highest level in several years.

TAKING THE LONG ROAD

Deep Localisation of Auto Parts Key for Bigger Play: Leaders



Our Bureau

New Delhi: Auto parts makers must move fast to own more of the industry's value chain by deepening localisation to have a bigger play in global supply chains amid geopolitical uncertainties, tariff shocks and critical mineral shortages, the heads of India's top carmakers and senior ministers said at the annual convention of the Automotive Component Manufacturers Association (ACMA) on Wednesday.

Addressing delegates, Maruti Suzuki MD & CEO Hisashi Takeuchi said deep localisation is an insurance against a volatile world. "Deep localisation is about reducing our exposure to external disruptions by strengthening domestic capabilities and progressively owning a larger share of the value chain," he said, adding that scale alone cannot help and that quality across tier-2 and tier-3 suppliers must become the industry's "signature."

Hyundai India MD & CEO Tarun Garg said given the geopolitical risks, India can no longer afford to continue at the same level of imports but rather accelerate building technological capability in semiconductors, EV battery cells, rare earth magnets, and power electronics. With the component trade deficit at $1.4 billion in FY26, he argued ownership, not just output, is the goal. "Technology ownership is essential for strategic independence," he said, urging every industry leader to localise one component, file one patent and enter one new market.

Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM) president Shailesh Chandra, also MD of Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles, said the post-pandemic resilience demonstrated by the industry must now evolve with stakeholders across board scaling up designing, developing, manufacturing and exporting components from India. Citing recent rare-earth supply shocks, he said the response can't stop at one mineral. "We need a comprehensive approach covering raw materials, processing, components, sub-components and final systems," said Chandra.

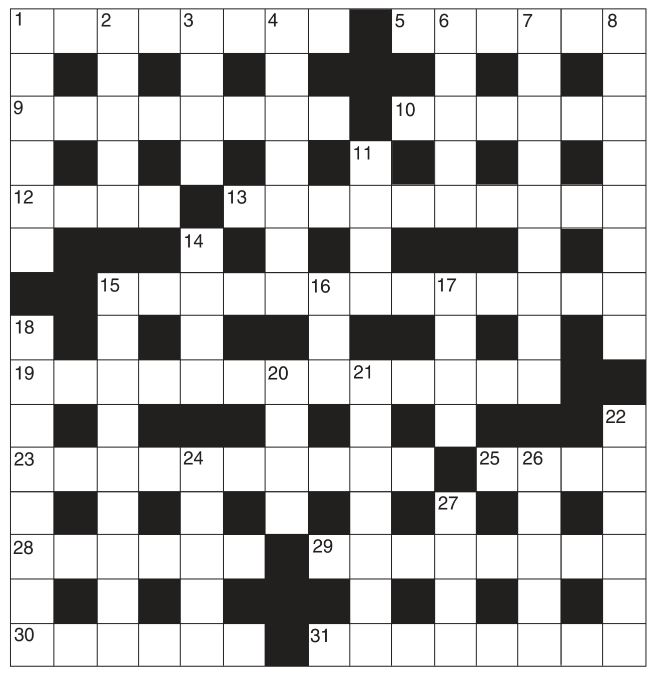
ACMA president Vikrampati Singhania agreed the value chain must go beyond simply making parts in India. "The next phase must increasingly be about create in India, engineer in India and innovate in India, for India and for the world," he said. Singhania added that MSMEs and smaller suppliers must be brought along, not left behind in this endeavour.

Homebuyers Flag Lack of Progress in Supertech Projects Despite Takeover

New Delhi: Homebuyers of 16 stalled housing projects by bankrupt builder Supertech have raised concerns over no progress on construction despite state-run NBCC taking over the work almost two years ago. Meanwhile, the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) sought a status report from the committee appointed by the Supreme Court to monitor the construction work. **—Our Bureau**

NON-SEQUITUR

Crossword 9694



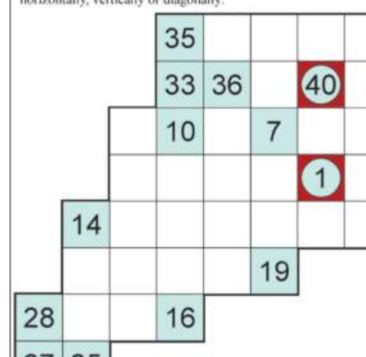
ACROSS
1 A price varying in here at intervals for listening device (8)
5 Gradually accumulate bread? (4,2)
9 Lucy in a rage sadly with time gone related to cooking (8)
10 Cathedral official keeping company for minister (6)
12 Two in Spain given last part of one quantity of medicine (4)
13 Marginal course for drivers? (4,6)
15 Amount of force in vital carriers? (5,8)
19 A cab reordered fancy scanning machine (7,6)
23 Current band has botched exercise, not being fit (2,3,5)
25 Detect pimple (4)
28 Thing to treat bruises spilt in a car (6)
29 Publicise scandal a lot mostly with Kelvin, playboy (8)
30 Three points about, for instance, literary compositions (6)
31 Western circle in exotic market showing collective effort (8)

DOWN
1 Old currency curiously sourced right away (6)
2 Parts, reportedly, for bakery products (5)
3 Element in region admiring Scottish island (4)
4 Held up on transport? (7)
6 Information in middle of data for representative (5)
7 Former person monitoring, it's said, funds (9)
8 Part of Highland forest exciting Peter in front of experts (4,4)
11 Evidence of emotion in petite artist (4)
14 Personal power shown by Maureen, Jack and Oscar (4)
15 Most basic details exposed individual in Bahamas (4,5)
16 Standard reprieve (not half) (3)
17 Attractive guys with no time for bubbles (4)
18 Compel real bigot, no Republican, to reform (8)
20 Some bloke choosing feature in a chamber? (4)
21 Back especially English banker (7)
22 Skater after slipping has colourful mark (6)
24 Lure with endless colour scheme over year (5)
26 Advertising before a party in Spanish museum (5)
27 Remove Alpine equipment over month (4)

SOLUTION TO No. 9693:
ACROSS: 6 Respectability. **9** Edgier. **10** Card game. **11** Noisette. **13** Ingrid. **15** Egg cup. **17** Bedlam. **19** Beards. **20** Heat pump. **22** Sforzato. **24** Lizard. **26** Intelligentsia.
DOWN: 1 Pride oneself on. **2** Asti. **3** Beirut. **4** Abortive. **5** Slug. **7** Tucked. **8** Time immemorial. **12** Sugar. **14** Galop. **16** Unstable. **18** Throng. **21** Ailing. **23** Rued. **25** Zest.

HIDATO
FIND THE PATH - SOLVE THE PUZZLE

Complete the grid so that numbers 1 - 40 connect horizontally, vertically or diagonally:



www.hidato.com Dif ★☆☆☆☆

Hidato Sol. 12/20

Yesterday's puzzle solution.

7 LITTLE WORDS

Find the 7 words to match the 7 clues. The numbers in parentheses represent the number of letters in each solution. Each letter combination can be used only once, but all letter combinations will be necessary to complete the puzzle.

CLUES	SOLUTIONS
1 Europe's "boot" (5)	
2 highest office in U.S. (10)	
3 Florida's blastoff site (9)	
4 calamari and crab (7)	
5 Diane of TV news (6)	
6 individual pieces of hair (7)	
7 Alaska and Frontier (8)	

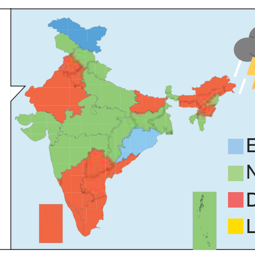
AN	DE	ITA	AVE	PR
ESI	YER	NCY	SE	SAW
CAN	DS	AFO	LY	LIN
AIR	ES	STR	OD	RAL

Yesterday's Answers: 1. PASTA 2. EXAGGERATED 3. GATED 4. LANDING 5. SWEETNESS 6. REMOTE 7. SUGGESTED 10/15

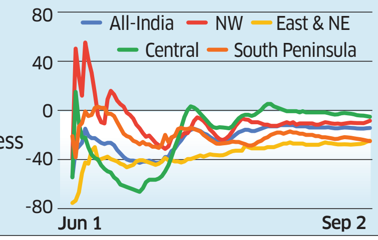
MONSOON Watch

CUMULATIVE RAINFALL FROM JUNE 1 TO SEPTEMBER 2 (% departure from normal)

-13	All-India
-9	NW India
-24	East & NE
-5	Central
-25	South Peninsula



HOW THE ALL-INDIA MONSOON PICTURE STANDS
Rainfall progress since June 1 (% departure, cumulative)



RAINFALL TILL SEP 2, COMPARED WITH RECENT YEARS
Cumulative departure (%)

2024	2025	2026
8	7	-13

Source: IMD

CURRENT WEATHER & FORECAST

Under the influence of Well Marked Low-Pressure Area over northeast Madhya Pradesh & neighbourhood, isolated heavy to very heavy rainfall very likely over East Uttar Pradesh, Gangetic West Bengal Chhattisgarh and Bihar, West Uttar Pradesh, Sub-Himalayan West Bengal & Sikkim, Vidarbha and East Madhya Pradesh

ET GRAPHICS

The Illicit Money Problem

Speaking abroad, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant recently said the global scale of laundered money was such that it could buy a laptop for each person in the world. Data backs this: global illegal money flows reached $4.4 trillion in 2025, or 3.8% of world GDP, and this is rising rapidly, with much of it never recovered. Bank frauds are also getting bigger. In India, 4,622 cases were filed under the anti-money laundering law in the past five years, but less than 1% led to convictions. Here's a lowdown on how the world's dirty money flows, by **Anoushka Sawhney**

1] ILLICIT MONEY FLOWS ARE RISING FASTER THAN WORLD GDP

	2023	2025
Value of laundered money flowing through the world ($ trillion)	3.1	4.4
As a % of world GDP	2.9	3.8

2023-25: Value grew at 19.2% CAGR, vs. 5% global GDP growth

2] ORGANISED CRIME, DRUG NETWORKS FORM A BULK OF THIS DARK WORLD

	Amount (2025, $ trillion)	CAGR (2023-25, %)
Organised crime, fraud, corruption, etc.	2.78	19.2
Drug trafficking	1.07	17.1
Human trafficking	0.53	23.5
Terrorist financing	0.02	18.8

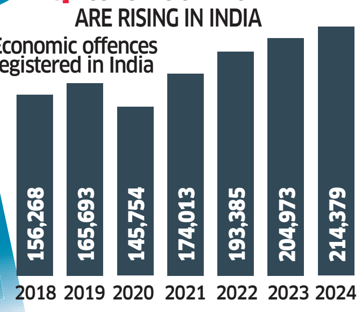
3] MOST FRAUD TYPES ARE GROWING AT 20% PER YEAR

	Amount (2025, $ trillion)	CAGR (2023-25, %)
Credit card/cheque fraud	78.1	19
Impersonation	9.6	19.3
Confidence/Romance scams	5.2	17.1
Employment fraud	5.6	20.3
Cyber-enabled fraud	14.3	19.6
Advance fee/lottery /prize/grant fraud	27.3	19.5
Credit transfers & direct debits fraud	439.3	6.6

4] A TINY FRACTION OF THE DEFRAUDED AMOUNT IS RECOVERED
Frauds reported by scheduled commercial banks and all-India financial institutions

	Amount involved (₹cr)	Amount recovered (₹cr)	Recovery share (%)
FY24	11,678	499	4.3
FY25	32,043	1,443	4.5
FY26	47,910	2,906	6.1

5] ECONOMIC CRIMES ARE RISING IN INDIA
Economic offences registered in India



2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
156,268	165,693	145,754	174,013	193,385	204,973	214,379

6] PMLA CASES HIT A FOUR-YEAR HIGH IN FY26; CONVICTIONS ARE RARE

	Cases registered by Enforcement Directorate under PMLA	Cases wherein convictions secured	Number of accused convicted
2021-22	1,116	3	4
2022-23	953	9	24
2023-24	698	13	19
2024-25	775	9	38
2025-26	1,080	9	19

CAGR: Compound annual growth rate; PMLA: Prevention of Money Laundering Act

Source: Nasdaq Verafin Global Financial Crime Report 2026, Ministry of Finance's Parliament replies, National Crime Records Bureau, World Bank, ET calculations

GDP Data Revision: Govt says it's Revised Base, Not Baseless

New estimates reflect improvements in data quality and methodology: MoSPI

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The statistics ministry on Wednesday clarified that revisions to India's gross domestic product (GDP) estimates reflect improvements in data quality and methodology, amid concerns over the numbers raised on social media and by political leaders. Official data released earlier this week showed that India's real GDP grew 7.8% year-on-year in Q1FY27 and 10.3% in nominal terms. Previous quarter's growth was also revised; for example, Q4FY26 real GDP was revised to 8.6% from 7.8%.

The revisions under the new GDP series were driven primarily by the shift to the more granular Producer Price Index (PPI) for deflation from the Wholesale Price Index (WPI), along with the availability of more complete data for earlier quarters, said Saurabh Garg, statistics ministry secretary. The earlier series relied on around 180 deflators, while the new methodology uses over 300, he said.

The revised estimates incorporate the new output PPI, the updated Index of Industrial Production (IIP) series, the Banking Services Price Index, and updated information from various administrative sources. In February, the ministry of statistics and programme implementation (MoSPI) revised the GDP base year to 2022-23 from 2011-12. The revisions came under scrutiny after former finance secretary Subhash Garg argued that GDP growth would have been 2.6% in current prices if the April-June 2025 nominal GDP figures had not been revised down to ₹80 lakh crore from ₹86 lakh crore to make growth in April-June 2026 "look better".

Responding to the criticism, the statistics ministry said the Rs 86.05 lakh crore figure was based on the earlier GDP series, which used 2011-12 as the base year. Under the new series, with 2022-23 as the base year, nominal GDP for April-June 2025 was revised to ₹80.44 lakh crore from ₹80.32 lakh crore, reflecting updated data and methodology.

SHIFT TO PPI

Revisions under new GDP series driven primarily by shift to Producer Price Index for deflation from the Wholesale Price Index

"The change in the estimate of Q1FY26 does not represent a downward revision made to make the current year's growth appear higher," the ministry said in a statement, adding that it reflects successive methodological and data revisions to the GDP series.

The movement of Q1FY26 GDP figures to ₹80 lakh crore in current prices from ₹86.05 lakh crore was the result of successive revisions arising from the change in base year, the incorporation of improved data sources and methodologies, and the updating of available indicators, the ministry said.

"It is therefore incorrect to interpret the difference as a deliberate downward revision of last year's GDP to mechanically increase the current year's growth rate," it added.

AFTER THREE DECADES

Japan's JCRA Upgrades India Sovereign Rating to A-

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Japan Credit Rating Agency (JCRA) has upgraded India's sovereign rating to A- from BBB+, a feat achieved after more than three decades, citing the country's solid economic growth, effectiveness of its economic policies, robust private consumption and public investment, and improved soundness of its financial system.

India's economy is expected to retain a high growth rate of more than 6% in 2026-27, JCRA said on Wednesday, even as it highlighted that the general government debt, including those of states, and the associated interest burdens remain high.

The upgrade came close on the heels of official data showing that India's economy grew a better-than-expected 7.8% in the June quarter from a year earlier, belying concerns that severe headwinds, including the war in West Asia, may have dented growth.

Noting that the government of India "steadily implemented policies conducive to productivity growth and economic development", including the development of digital public infrastructure and the implementation of the goods and services tax, strengthening the country's economic foundations, the agency said the banking sector's non-performing loan ratio had declined to below 2%.

"Considering India's solid economic growth, the effectiveness of economic policies that strengthen the foundations for growth, and the improved soundness of the financial system, JCR has upgraded India's Foreign Currency and Local Currency Long-term Issuer Ratings by one notch to A-," it said.

Agency cites solid economic growth, effectiveness of economic policies, robust private consumption and public investment

The finance ministry said the upgrade underscores the continued strengthening of India's economic fundamentals, especially against the backdrop of a challenging global environment.

State-run General Insurers Told to Focus on Profitable Biz to Cut Incurred Claim Ratio

New Delhi: The government has asked state-run general insurers to strengthen focus on profitable lines of business and adopt suitable measures to bring down incurred claim ratio (ICR). ICR is the ratio of total claims paid by an insurer to total premiums collected in a financial year.

Financial services secretary Sanjay Lohia Wednesday took a review of the performance of public sector general insurance companies or PSGICs and emphasised on greater use of technology and accelerated digitalisation while optimising expenditure on information technology and other digital initiatives.

In a statement, the finance ministry noted that Lohia advised the companies to improve insurance penetration and density while reducing protection gaps besides ensuring expeditious redressal of customer grievances and also focus on the quality of redressal.

The statement noted that Lohia also emphasised on the need to strengthen performance monitoring – **Our Bureau**

JSW, Inox, Blackstone Among Contenders for BluPine Energy

Non-binding bids at EV of ₹22,000 cr, making deal among biggest in renewables sector

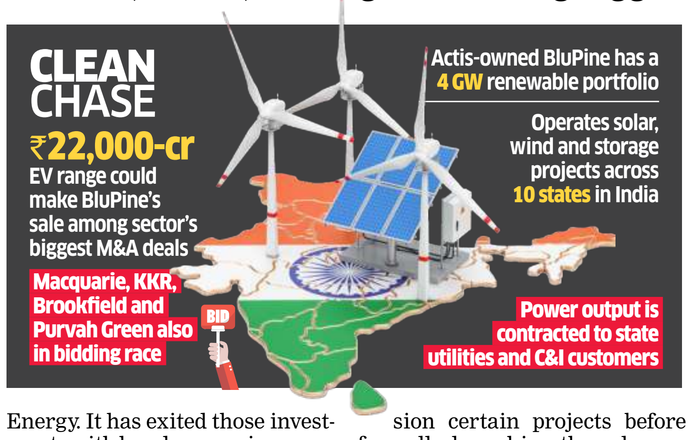
Mohit Bhalla

New Delhi: JSW Neo Energy, Inox Clean, Blackstone and Macquarie are among the suitors for BluPine Energy after they officially entered a bidding process to acquire the renewable energy company by submitting non-binding offers Wednesday, people familiar with the matter told **ET**.

KKR, Brookfield and RP Sanjiv Goenka Group's Purvah Green are also in the fray, according to the people cited earlier. KKR has sought more time to submit a formal offer, as per the sources.

The non-binding offers are said to be in the ₹22,000 crore enterprise value (EV) range, they said. This positions BluPine's sale among the biggest M&A deals in the sector.

BluPine Energy is owned by Actis. It has a renewable energy generation portfolio of 4 gigawatts. It is among the largest renewable energy platforms incubated by Actis in India. Actis previously incubated Ostro Energy and Sprng Energy. It has exited those investments with handsome gains.



The sale of BluPine Energy has been under consideration for more than a year. ET first reported in July last year that Actis was considering the sale of the company.

ET subsequently reported on April 24 this year that Actis had mandated Standard Chartered Bank as an advisor on the sale of BluPine Energy.

BluPine had planned to commission certain projects before formally launching the sale process, which has now been completed, the people said.

Actis declined to comment. So did JSW Neo, Inox Clean, Blackstone, KKR and Brookfield. RP Sanjiv Goenka group and Macquarie did not respond to requests for comments.

BluPine Energy is helmed by Neerav Nanavaty. It operates solar, wind and storage-based power projects. The output of these power plants is contracted to state-owned utilities and commercial and industrial customers. Its projects are located across 10 Indian states.

Deal activity in the renewable energy sector has remained steady. It is being driven by financial investors who flocked to the sector in its early days and who are now seeking to monetise their investments.

On the other hand, Indian conglomerates are looking to build their heft in the sector by buying assets that are on the block. Certain private equity investors like KKR are continuing to build their investment portfolios in the renewable energy sector in line with their global priorities.

Aditya Birla Group recently acquired Sprng Energy from Shell for over ₹17,000 crore. Macquarie recently sold Vibrant Energy to Inox Clean Energy. Global Infrastructure Partners-backed Veena Energy was also recently sold to Inox Clean Energy. RP Sanjiv Goenka's Purvah Green recently acquired an over 1 gigawatt portfolio of assets from ReNew for over ₹4,000 crore.

Sept Gold Import may Fall 15% on PM's Call

Sutanuka Ghosal

Kolkata: Gold imports, second only to crude oil in India's overseas shopping basket, are expected to fall around 15% in September after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's renewed appeal to avoid unnecessary spending on the yellow metal, potentially denting sentiment in the jewellery trade just ahead of the festive season.

"According to our trade estimates, nearly 45 tonnes of gold were imported in August. This is expected to come down by 15% in September," said Surendra Mehta, national secretary, India Bullion & Jewellers Association.

Prime Minister Modi reiterated the appeal on September 1, asking Indians to exercise restraint and avoid spending unnecessarily on gold. The message comes as the government seeks to reduce the import bill and an expanding current account deficit, while encouraging households to bring a part of their estimated 31,000 tonnes of idle gold into circulation. The appeal has cast a shadow over Zaveri Bazaar, the country's largest gold trading hub. Jewellers expect consumers to increasingly exchange old jewellery for new pieces rather than make fresh purchases. Old-gold exchange, which currently accounts for about 45-50% of jewellers' business, could rise to 60-70% during the festive season, industry executives said.

Old-gold exchange, which totals about 45-50% of jewellers' biz, could rise to 60-70% in the festive season, say experts

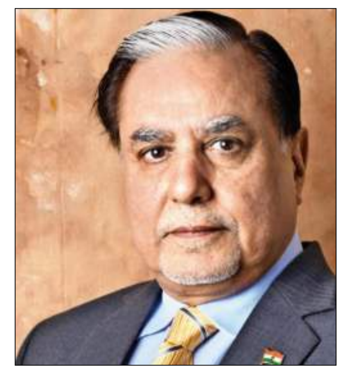
Corrigendum

A September 2 news report should have said that windfall tax on petrol and diesel has been raised by ₹1.5 and ₹1, respectively, and not lowered. The error is regretted.

Subhash Chandra Opposes NCLT's 5-Member Bench in Personal Insolvency Case

Essel chair argues at NCLAT that tribunal does not have power to constitute such a bench

Our Bureau



Mumbai: Essel Group chairman Subhash Chandra on Wednesday opposed the constitution of a five-member bench of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) to hear his personal insolvency case, a day after the bench stayed the approval of a repayment plan proposed by him. He argued that the tribunal lacks the power to constitute such a bench.

Chandra made this submission before the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) during the hearing of a plea by dissenting creditors, including LIC Housing Finance and Union Bank of India, challenging the approval of his repayment plan. The appellate tribunal has listed the matter for hearing on October 7.

Solicitor general Tushar Mehta, appearing for the dissenting creditors, initially sought to withdraw their appeals, saying they no longer require immediate consideration since the five-member NCLT bench has stayed the August 25 opinion and decided to hear the case afresh.

FLY91 Places Order for 40 ATR-72 Aircraft in Major Expansion Push

Deal valued at over $1 b; carrier aims to connect smaller towns and cities across the country

Arindam Majumder

New Delhi: Regional airline FLY91 has placed an order for 40 ATR-72 turboprop aircraft, one of the largest for the type in recent times, as the carrier bets on expanding connectivity to smaller towns and cities across India underserved by larger jets, said people aware of the development. At list price, the order is valued at more than $1 billion. However, airlines tend to get heavy discounts on such large orders.

FLY91 is also in the process of raising about ₹250 crore from existing and new investors to support its expansion plans, the people said.

The order will more than double FLY91's fleet and significantly expand its footprint across Tier 2 and 3 cities. The carrier currently operates a small fleet of ATR-72 planes connecting airports under the government's UDAN regional connectivity scheme, including Sindhudurg and Jalgaon.

Deliveries of the new planes are slated to start towards the end of 2027 and completed over five years.

Spokespeople at FLY91 and ATR didn't respond to queries.

Manoj Chacko, founder and CEO at FLY91, didn't comment on the order, stating instead, "We are heavily bullish on the India story and want to build a reliable transportation company out of India."

"There are 100 such airports in India where a big aircraft like Airbus A320 and Boeing 737 can't go," said Chacko. "The ATR-72 aircraft perfectly suits those routes and for our cost model."

The deal underlines growing confidence in India's regional aviation market, which has long struggled to find a viable commercial model. FLY91, which launched operations in 2024, has positioned itself as a pure-play regional carrier, focusing on routes that larger narrow-body operators such as IndiGo and Air India find commercially unviable. The ATR-72, a twin-engine turboprop manufactured by Franco-Italian consortium ATR, is widely regarded as the most fuel-efficient aircraft for short-haul routes of under 500 kilometres.

Ex-IAF Grp Capt Varthaman Joins FLY91 as Pilot

Press Trust of India

New Delhi: Former Indian Air Force (IAF) group captain and Vir Chakra awardee Abhinandan Varthaman has joined Goa-based regional airline FLY91 as a pilot, as per sources.

Varthaman, who downed an enemy jet during an aerial combat with Pakistan in 2019 and was held captive for three days in that country, was honoured with the Vir Chakra award in 2021.

The sources told PTI Varthaman joined the airline as a pilot in August. When contacted, a FLY91 spokesperson said personal information about employees is a private matter and did not comment. Further details could not be immediately ascertained.

The fighter pilot of the IAF was decorated with Vir Chakra—India's third-highest wartime gallantry medal—for displaying an "exceptional sense of duty" during the dogfight, as per the award citation.

IN FUNDING ROUND LED BY BERTELSMANN INDIA

Swish in Talks to Raise $20-25 m

Pranav Mukul

Bengaluru: Bengaluru-based food delivery startup Swish is finalising a $20-25 million funding round led by Bertelsmann India Investments, which has backed startups such as Shiprocket and Snabbit, two people aware of the matter told ET.

The transaction, which is also likely to see participation from Swish's existing investors, is expected to value the two-year-old company at around $200 million, one of the persons said. Swish had last raised $38 million in March at a valuation of $120 million.

The round was led by Bain Capital Ventures, with participation from existing investor Accel.

"The company has been witnessing rapid growth, especially since its expansion into Delhi-NCR. It plans to enter more cities while also densifying its network across existing markets," one of the people cited above said.

Founded in 2024 by Aniket Shah, Ujjwal Sukheja and Saran S, Swish promises delivery of mini meals, snacks, beverages and desserts in about 10 minutes. It prepares the food at company-operated cloud kitchens located within a 1-km radius of customers.

Queries sent to Shah and Bertelsmann India did not elicit a response.

The startup initially focused on quick bites, coffee and late-night snacks, but has since expanded its menu to include breakfast, mini meals, protein-rich options, festive specials and desserts. Swish is seeking to build a business around 10-minute food delivery, a segment that quick-commerce and food delivery incumbents have struggled to make economically viable.

In February, Swiggy shut down its 10-minute food delivery app Snacc after almost a year of operations as it failed to find sustainable product-market fit.